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Happening today

● **EXTERNAL AFFAIRS**
MINISTER S Jaishankar and his South Korean counterpart Cho Hyun are set to meet at the Jeju Forum for Peace and Prosperity.

● **SUPREME COURT** is scheduled to hear a plea of actor Jacqueline Fernandez against a Delhi court order to frame charges against her in a Rs 200-crore money laundering case.

● **INDIA TAKE** on Bangladesh in a crucial Women's T20 World Cup Group A clash.

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Business as Usual

By EPUNNY



Khamenei's funeral next month, Iranian President sends invitation to PM



PM Narendra Modi with Iranian Supreme National Security Council Deputy Secretary Ghadiri Nezamipour. X/@IRAN_IN_INDIA

Divya A
New Delhi, June 24

AS IRAN prepares for a multi-city state funeral for Supreme Leader Ayatollah Ali Khamenei, who was killed in a US-Israeli air strike on Tehran on February 28, President Masoud Pezeshkian has sent a formal invitation to Prime Minister Narendra Modi to attend the funeral next month.

Sources said the formal invitation, on behalf of Pezeshkian, was sent to the Ministry of External Affairs Tuesday by the Iranian Embassy in New Delhi. They said the embassy received the formal note from Tehran two days ago.

Khamenei's funeral proceedings will begin in Tehran on July 4, and he will be laid to rest in his home town of Mashhad on July 9. The burial was initially scheduled for March but postponed in view of the conflict raging then.

There is no official word yet on who will be representing India at the funeral. Sources said a multi-nation visit by the Prime Minister is planned around the same dates.

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

EXPECT TIES TO MOVE TO A HIGHER LEVEL: GREER AT END OF TWO DAYS OF NEGOTIATIONS

Market access to non-tariff barriers: India, US review trade core elements

Commerce Ministry: Both committed to balanced, commercially meaningful pact

Ravi Dutta Mishra
New Delhi, June 24

INDIA AND the US Wednesday wrapped up two days of negotiations over a bilateral trade deal and Delhi said there had been "a comprehensive review" of core elements including "enhanced market access, digital trade, supply chain resilience, reduction of non-tariff barriers, and expanded cooperation in strategic sectors".

The US trade delegation was led by United States Trade Representative (USTR) Jamie Greer. The negotiations took place a month before Washington is expected to come out with a new tariffs architecture under Section 301 of the US Trade Act to replace reciprocal tariffs deemed illegal by the US Supreme Court in February this year.

An industry source said »CONTINUED ON PAGE 2



Union Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman with United States Trade Representative Jamie Greer in New Delhi. @FINMININDIA

E. EXPLAINED

What's taking time

Bilateral trade deal negotiations have been slow due to differences over high tariffs, agricultural market access, e-commerce regulations and India's pushback against US pressure on its energy and defence ties with Russia. The two sides are trying to secure a working deal before next month's US tariff deadline.

PUNJAB ROW OVER 'MANN VIDEO'

Police get custody of two in forensic report case, no 'labs' at Delhi and Haryana addresses



ABHIMANYU HAZARIKA

Cyberyaa Lab in Delhi's Tilak Nagar, a cybersecurity training centre.

Abhimanyu Hazarika, Sukhbir Siwach & Varinder Bhatia
New Delhi, Kharak Gagar (Jind), Chandigarh, June 24

TWO MEN arrested by Gurgaon Police in connection with an alleged attempt at bribery linked to a purported "objectionable" video of Punjab Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann were remanded in eight days' police custody on Wednesday.

The two men were arrested after an individual named Jaspreet Singh complained to police in Haryana that two sen-

ior Punjab Police officers had paid him Rs 10 lakh to give a false report on the video.

Chief Minister Mann has claimed that he is not the individual seen in the video. However, the Akal Takht has declared the clip "authentic" and declared Mann to be against the Gurus and the Panth.

The Gurgaon Police told a Gurgaon court that custody of the two accused, Arun Mahendru and Ankit Bhardwaj, was needed to investigate the bribery allegation.

"The accused are required »CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

AFTER RAPE AND MURDER OF MINOR GIRL

Accused with crime history drove cabs in Delhi, ride-hailing firms on police radar

Delhi Police writes to Ola, Uber, Rapido, seeks details of driver's verification

Alok Singh & Pragynesh
New Delhi, June 24

WITH THE cab driver accused in the rape and murder of a 10-year-old girl in the Capital found to have five criminal cases registered against him in Bihar, the Delhi Police is learnt to have written to three major

THE CITY

ACCUSED CHANGED CLOTHES, CLEANED CAR, DROPPED PASSENGERS BEFORE ARREST PAGE 4

cab aggregators — Uber, Ola and Rapido — seeking details

INSIDE

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BENGAL REMOVES EGGS FROM MID-DAY MEAL, DRAWS OPP FIRE

MAN KILLED IN MUMBAI LOCAL TRAIN AFTER ROW OVER OPEN DOOR

Missing records, Africa assets, MD salary Rs 17,000: Rajesh Exports under ED lens

After searches in two cities, agency claims gold exporter's trade transactions opaque

Deeptiman Tiwary
New Delhi, June 24

ABSENT RECORDS of foreign transactions, a purported Rs 1,035-crore investment in African mines with no supporting documents, a 40% mismatch between gold stocks found during searches and those recorded in company registers. Plus a CFO who has allegedly not drawn a salary since 2020 and a Manag-

ing Director paid just Rs 17,000 a month despite the company's reported revenues of Rs 77 lakh crore. And suspected siphoning of over Rs 600 crore through alleged share manipulation involving NRI benamidars.

These are among the preliminary findings cited by the Enforcement Directorate (ED) following search and seizure operations at nine premises linked to Rajesh Exports Ltd in

Bengaluru and Mumbai under the Foreign Exchange Management Act (FEMA), 1999.

In a statement issued Wednesday, the ED said its ongoing investigation into the gold exporter had uncovered multiple suspected contraventions relating to overseas transactions, stock holdings and share dealings, and that various documents and digital evidence had been seized during the searches.

The agency even questioned the remuneration structure of key managerial personnel, saying it appeared »CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

● GET SMALL THINGS RIGHT, REVISIT MATTERS WHICH MAY SEEM ROUTINE, HE SAYS IN NOTE TO SECRETARIES

Cab Secy's poser: Do we want 30-yr service experience or just one repeated 30 times?

Damini Nath
New Delhi, June 24

IN A two-page note sent to all Secretaries to the Government of India, accompanied by a 10-page guide on how to conduct meetings, Cabinet Secretary TV Somanathan has said that if they just follow "a beaten track", the question they may face at the end of their service is: did they get "30 years' experience or one year's experience repeated 30 times".

The note, sent on June 12, underlined the need to improve each year, to get the "small things" right, and to "pause and revisit" matters which may seem "routine".

Somanathan also asked the Secretaries to circulate the guide on holding effective meetings, drawn up by the National Centre for Good Governance (NCGG), to all civil servants. He said the Cabinet Secretariat, along with the NCGG, would circulate similar



Cabinet Secretary TV Somanathan. EXPRESS FILE

guides on various topics. The conduct of meetings was chosen as the first topic as meetings take up a lot of time in an officer's day, he wrote.

"Many officers have told me that many of our meetings tend to start late, be overstretched and directionless, and often lead to no tangible 'takeaways'," he wrote.

The Cabinet Secretary wrote that several middle-ranking officers had told him that they were happy with the »CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

PAHALGAM TERROR ATTACK

Plan was in motion week before attack, terrorists used app to log coordinates: NIA

Data analysis of two cellphones reveals photos of terrorists, chats with handler

Naveed Iqbal
Srinagar, June 24

THE PLAN to attack tourists at Baisaran valley in Kashmir's Pahalgam was active around April 15 last year, as per digital records recovered from terrorists killed after the attack. This revelation, *The Indian Express* has learnt, figures in the National Investigation Agency chargesheet filed in connection with the April 22, 2025 attack which left 25 tourists and a local ponywallah dead.

The agency's probe, it is learnt, notes that the phone of a terrorist killed during 'Operation Mahadev' in the Srinagar area on July 28, 2025, "contained two map screenshots time-stamped April 15 and 16, depicting locations near Baisaran".

The screenshots indicate the points were plotted in a mobile app, "consistent with coordinates being received from the (Pakistan-based) handler Sajid Jatt", the NIA is learnt to have said. "These timestamps show the conspiracy was live at least from April 15 onwards." The GPS-based mobile app in question is used for hiking and mountain expeditions, but was



The site of the Pahalgam attack where 26 people were killed on April 22, 2025. AP FILE

used by terrorists to share and track coordinates.

Three terrorists — Faisal Jatt alias Suleman, Habeeb Tahir alias Jibril, and Hamza Afghani — were killed on July 28 in the Dachigam forests near Srinagar.

According to the NIA probe, the three visited a dhok (a mud hut constructed in the upper reaches of the Valley and used by shepherds in the summer) of local resident Parvaiz Ahmad on April 21. Parvaiz and his uncle, Bashir Ahmad Jothad, stand accused of providing food and shelter to the terrorists a day before the attack.

"The analysis of the »CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

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Mumbai Flooded Again

Police personnel assist a person on a waterlogged road after heavy rainfall inundated several parts of Mumbai on Wednesday. PTI

HC lets POCSO victim to end 29-week pregnancy, orders audit on care and counselling of minors

Mustafa Plumber
Bengaluru, June 24

THE KARNATAKA High Court has allowed a minor girl — a sexual assault victim — to terminate her 29-week-old pregnancy and directed the state government to conduct an audit on whether minor victims of sexual assault are being provided immediate care, protection, counselling, rehabilitation, and access to statutory entitlements.

“Director, Department of Women and Child Development, shall undertake a state-wide compliance audit regarding the implementation of the directions issued by the court earlier to ensure timely intervention in cases involving minor victims of sexual assault resulting in pregnancy,” Justice Suraj Govindaraj said in a June 8 order. The audit will examine whether mechanisms have been evolved in each district and the extent of compliance by the police department, child welfare committees, district child protection units and other stakeholder departments.

On October 15, 2025, the court issued a technology-oriented SOP, including a digital portal, to assist victims in cases registered under the POCSO Act until another SOP is framed. The case involved the repeated sexual assault of a 15-year-old girl staying in Chitradurga district for educational purposes. An FIR was filed on April 16. However, the SHO allegedly did not

inform the district child protection unit, the child welfare panel, the Women and Child Development Department or other authorities as required.

The court noted that even the district child welfare officer, who was aware of the incident, reportedly did not take steps to place the matter before the child welfare panel. “Had authorities acted with the promptitude expected of them, the issue of medical termination of pregnancy could have been examined at a substantially earlier stage of gestation and the minor and her family would have been spared considerable uncertainty, distress and hardships,” the court said. “The conduct of the concerned officers, if established, would amount not merely to a failure to comply with the directions issued by this court, but also a failure to discharge the statutory and institutional responsibilities cast upon them for the protection of child victims of sexual offences.”

The bench also emphasised that the purpose of child protection framework under the law is to ensure that a minor receives immediate support, guidance and access to medical, legal and rehabilitative measures. The court directed that a medical board be formed at Vani Vilas Hospital to examine and assess the minor.

The opinion of the board was that termination of pregnancy, at 29 weeks and six days, can be undertaken.

Held for ‘custodial death’, Andhra cop now faces probe over suicide by Dalit man

Sreenivas Janyala
Hyderabad, June 24

CIRCLE INSPECTOR of the Krishnalanka police station, S V Nagaraju, arrested in a custodial death case in Andhra Pradesh’s Vijayawada is also being probed over allegations that a Dalit youth, Perupogu Kranthi Kumar, 42, died by suicide on May 21 after being harassed by him. Kumar left behind a video holding Nagaraju responsible.

Kumar, the son of Andhra Madiga Reservation Porata Samithi president Perupogu Venkateswara Rao, had alleged that Nagaraju targeted him as he was a Dalit. The four-member SIT probing Kumar’s death as well as the alleged custodial death of Gade Sai Krishna has said in its remand application for Nagaraju that prima facie evidence indicates that Krishna was tor-

tured. In its remand report, filed in Vijayawada 2nd Additional Judicial Magistrate court Wednesday, the SIT stated: “A strong prima facie inference arises that the deceased suffered fatal injuries in police custody.” Evidence regarding this “was concealed or caused to disappear”.

In his “suicide video”, Kumar had accused Nagaraju of “harassing” him over petty cases registered at the Krishnalanka police station, and beating him up several times. Rao, whose organisation fights for the rights of Madigas, said, “On May 21, a constable visited our house looking for Kumar, saying they want some information... Kumar told me he was anxious about motives of police. He died by suicide a few hours later.” Rao said due to several police visits and cases against him, Kumar was “under a lot of pressure”.

[FROM PAGE 1 | FULL REPORTS ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM]

India, US review trade

a 7-member US legislative delegation, simultaneously visiting Maharashtra, has begun exploring tech export opportunities in India. The source said that India and the US have, in principle, agreed to the deal and expect the agreement to be signed in the next 15 days.

The Ministry of Commerce and Industry said “the two sides expressed confidence that ongoing negotiations will further deepen economic ties” and strengthen the India-US Comprehensive Global Strategic Partnership.

“Ambassador Greer held multiple rounds of discussions with the Union Minister of Commerce and Industry, Piyush Goyal. The two leaders conducted a comprehensive review of core bilateral trade agreement (BTA) elements, including enhanced market access, digital trade, supply chain resilience, reduction of non-tariff barriers, and expanded cooperation in strategic sectors,” the Ministry said. Discussions focused on

pathways to conclude an interim agreement as an important milestone toward a comprehensive BTA, and both sides reaffirmed their commitment to an agreement that is balanced and commercially meaningful, the Ministry said.

The US delegation, led by Greer, also met Union Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman.

The Ministry of Finance, in a social media post, said both sides exchanged views on strengthening bilateral trade and economic cooperation, with a focus on new opportunities for growth and deeper commercial engagement.

Meanwhile, the USTR said that India has a long history of agriculture and manufacturing, and they are moving forward in technology.

“They want to move forward in AI. They want to cooperate and collaborate with the United States on the technologies of the future and trade of the future. And that’s some of the exciting opportunities that we’ll have between the United States and India,” he said.

Greer said President Donald Trump and Prime Minister Narendra Modi have an “amazing” relationship that they have nurtured over many years.

“Just last week, they met at the G7 in Evian, France, and I was there, and they agreed to take the relationship to the next level. This includes the trade deal that we’re working on, but it includes every aspect of the relationship, and we expect the relationship to continue developing and only going to a higher and higher level with every passing week,” he said.

Meanwhile, Ajay Srivastava, former trade officer and founder of think tank GTRI, cautioned against “a one-way market-access agreement rather than a balanced trade pact”.

“Even a signed agreement would offer no protection against future US trade actions, as Washington has repeatedly launched Section 301 investigations and imposed trade restrictions on countries with which it already has trade agreements. In these circumstances, India realises that delaying, or even abandoning, a rushed BTA may be the more prudent course than locking

India into obligations whose costs could far exceed any temporary tariff relief offered by Washington,” Srivastava said.

On June 18, the US launched an investigation under Section 301 against Germany, months after signing a trade deal. The US trade investigation said that evidence indicated that Germany was implementing unfair pricing policies and practices about innovative pharmaceutical products.

“Evidence further suggests that reduced revenue associated with these acts, policies, and practices contributes to, among other things, reduced investment for R&D that supports the development of innovative pharmaceuticals. As a result, the United States pays a disproportionate share of global R&D costs for innovative pharmaceuticals,” a USTR report said.

The US had also launched a separate Section 301 investigation on Vietnam last month, saying Vietnam had demonstrated a persistent failure to resolve long-standing concerns about IP protection and enforcement. Vietnam was among the first countries to sign an agreement with the US. — WITH PTI

Accused with history drove cabs in Delhi, ride-hailing firms on radar

During the probe, police found that five cases were filed against Singh in Bihar, dating back to 2015, 2017, 2018 and 2022 — two for attempt to murder and three for assault and brawling. He is also alleged to have attacked a police officer in Khagaria district of Bihar.

Police have also questioned the owner of the cab, a resident of Gurgaon. “The police have asked him whether he conducted police verification before hiring him,” said sources.

According to police sources, the probe aims to establish the companies’ hiring procedures for drivers and whether the mandatory police verification was carried out in this case. Investigators will try to establish whether there was negligence, a technical failure, or a procedural lapse by the aggregators, said sources.

“This may allow the police to take legal action against the aggregators if they are found to be flouting the rules,” a police source said.

Police have sought Singh’s complete work history, including when he joined, how many rides he completed, and whether there were any complaints against him in the past. If prior complaints are found, police will examine if any action was taken, said sources.

Sources said the probe would help connect the dots in this case, and also reveal if there were any gaps in the systems meant to ensure passenger safety.

Iran

In 2024, after Iran’s President Ebrahim Raisi and Foreign Minister Hossein Amir-Abdollahian were killed in a helicopter crash, then Vice-President Jagdeep Dhankhar travelled to Tehran and represented India.

Modi is among the world leaders who have received formal invitations on behalf of Peshkshian — leaders of China, Russia, Qatar, France and Pakistan too have been sent invitations. Last Friday, Pakistan Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif announced that a Pakistani delegation would be attending the funeral.

The invitation from Iran, days after it signed an MoU with the US to end hostilities, is a reminder of the civilizational and strategic ties between Tehran and Delhi amid the shifting dynamics in West Asia.

During the conflict, India and Iran kept bilateral channels open despite Delhi deciding not to take sides. Iran’s Foreign Minister Syed Abbas Araghchi visited India in May for the BRICS meeting.

Ghadir Nezamipour, Deputy Secretary for Defence Affairs in Iran’s powerful Supreme National Security Council (SNSC), who was in New Delhi to attend the meeting of NSAs from BRICS countries, met Prime Minister Modi Tuesday evening. On Wednesday, Mohsen Paknejad, Iran’s Petroleum Minister, reached New Delhi for a meeting of BRICS energy ministers. He will also hold bilateral discussions with Petroleum Minister Hardeep Singh Puri — following the signing of the MoU, the US has waived sanctions on Iranian oil imports for 60 days.

At the height of the Iran conflict, India had concerns about the security of the Indian diaspora in Iran and the Gulf region, its energy security and attacks on commercial vessels carrying Indian seafarers. Other than energy security, a priority area for India is the development of the Chabahar Port, its strategic gateway to Central Asia and Afghanistan, bypassing Pakistan.

Service experience of 30 yrs or one repeated 30 times: Cab Secy

subject-matter training being imparted to them, but needed more practical advice on “so-called routine matters”. “‘Routine’, though it may seem boring, is often extremely important and, thus, during our long careers in the civil service, we may need to pause and revisit it,” he wrote.

He said it would be useful for civil servants to ask themselves if they were improving each year or simply going down the beaten path. “If we are simply following a beaten track, then towards the end of our career, we may be faced with the question of whether our experience was ‘30 years’ experience’ or ‘one year’s experience repeated 30 times,’” he wrote.

He said civil servants “must take care of the small things”, which could range from how meetings are conducted, to time management, to communication with peers, superiors or subordinates.

“These things may seem trivial, but from my experience and observation, I would argue that they are very important. They often distinguish an outstanding officer from a mediocre one, even more than domain

knowledge,” he wrote.

The 10-page guide on holding meetings starts with the basics, including being clear about why a meeting is being called, who is to be called and the timing. It advises that if the purpose can be achieved through email, phone or text messages, then a meeting should be avoided.

If certain specific opinions, including on sensitive issues, are needed, then “calling a meeting may not be helpful as people may suffer from ‘herd mentality’ and they may not come out with their inspiring ideas in an open meeting because no one wants to upset the status quo. In such cases, a one-to-one interaction may be more fruitful,” it says.

It adds that important meetings should not be held a day before or after a holiday as participants may be on leave. It also advises that long meetings, that extend to over an hour, should be avoided.

A two-way flow of communication should be maintained during a meeting, it says. “Someone may be encouraged to play the devil’s advocate so that the participants are aware that you are open to different ideas,” it

says.

It also emphasises the importance of preparing minutes of meetings, giving standardised formats for different kinds of meetings, including a decision or problem-solving meeting, a selection meeting and an Expenditure Finance Committee meeting.

In the case of meetings where all participants are subordinates of the person calling the meeting, the guide says: “Subordinates are often reluctant to speak frankly for fear of contradicting the boss. However, you and your organisation will benefit from hearing the contradictory views to help you take a better decision and anticipate problems.”

For meetings intended for problem-solving, it says the hierarchical structure needs to be side-stepped so that all staff can speak freely. For meetings with non-government participants, it says the officer should “take extra care to be courteous to the participants”.

The guide ends with tips on what is a “good meeting and a bad meeting” and provides sample meeting notice, agenda and minutes.

No forensic ‘labs’ at addresses in Delhi, Haryana

to be interrogated in custody for recovering the devices that they used to analyse the videos. They are also required to be questioned on the involvement of other individuals who could be involved, and on their interactions or dealings with these individuals,” a highly placed source told *The Indian Express*.

Gurgaon Police have not identified the two Punjab Police officers whom the complainant, Jaspreet Singh, has accused of bribery. Assistant Commissioner of Police (ACP)-Crime Naveen Sharma of the Gurgaon Police told *The Indian Express* on Wednesday that investigators were continuing to examine CCTV footage from a five-star hotel in the city where the two officers allegedly stayed and met with Jaspreet Singh on June 15 and 16.

“So far we have not contacted the Punjab Police or any of their officials to assist with or join the probe. We shall do so after getting more evidence... Footage from the hotel is still being looked at before taking any call on this,” ACP Sharma said.

However, Shiromani Akali Dal (SAD) and BJP politicians have been naming a DIG- and an SP-level officer of the Punjab Police, and a purported video of the two men has been in circulation.

A senior Gurgaon Police officer said: “The hotel records, hotel bills, and CCTV footage of multiple areas in the hotel show the presence of the two Punjab Police officers... We shall proceed as per the law and take future course of action as required.”

Visits by *The Indian Express* on Wednesday to two addresses where the alleged fake forensic report on the purported video featuring Mann was prepared found no “forensic labs”.

Cyberyaan Lab in Ganesh Nagar near Central Hospital in Tilak Nagar in West Delhi is a training centre where young people are taught about cybersecurity.

Kharak Gagar village in Haryana’s Jind, where the premises of “Cipher Sentinel Lab” are supposed to be located, only has the private residence of Ankit Bhardwaj, one of the two men arrested by Gurgaon Police.

Jaspreet Singh has told Gurgaon Police that he had asked Ankit Bhardwaj and Arun Mahendru to prepare the fake forensic report. He had allegedly given a small portion of the Rs 10 lakh that he had received to one of the two men.

“We have never heard of Arun Mahendru, and he does not work here. We are just a cybersecurity training centre for kids,” a man who identified himself as an employee of Cyberyaan Lab told *The Indian Express*.

The “forensic” report submitted by Arun, who was arrested on Tuesday evening, bears the name of Cyberyaan Lab. Gurgaon Police have said he worked as a contractual employee with a government department in Panchkula, and gave a “report of video analysis in the name of Cyberyaan Lab which does not exist on the ground”.

Jaspreet Singh has told police that he had no knowledge of the authenticity, technical competence, or official registration of either Cyberyaan or Cipher Sentinel.

The Cyberyaan employee,

who declined to give his name, said they did no “AI testing” or certification of videos for government or private authorities.

“We have been running for four years now. We teach kids about ChatGPT etc. Those who train here are school passouts, or Arts or Commerce graduates who want a job in Internet companies or government departments,” the employee said.

A second employee added: “We have never worked with or trained government officials, from Panchkula or anywhere else. But we will cooperate with the police as needed. They have not contacted us so far.” This employee too declined to give his name.

On its website, Cyberyaan describes itself as a training and consultancy centre focused on cybersecurity, cloud infrastructure, and software development. It claims to have a branch office at Sikanderpur in Gurgaon.

According to the website, the institute is led by its founder and CEO Pankaj Yadav. It offers a one-year diploma in cybersecurity, besides courses on network and software testing.

Terrorists used app to log coordinates: NIA

extracted data of the two mobile phones revealed several photos of terrorists, screenshots of chats with the terrorist handler, namely Ali Sajid alias Ali Bhai, giving directions to the said terrorists and navigational data for further movements, screenshots of the app showing coordinates of locations near Baisaran Park, Pahalgalam,” the NIA is learnt to have said. Sajid, a Pakistani national, has been named as the commander of the proscribed terrorist outfit, Lashkar-e-Taiba, and its proxy, The Resistance Front.

Detailing his involvement in the attack, the NIA is learnt to have pointed out that even while being located in Pakistan, Sajid “conceived, coordinated and directed the Baisaran operation by maintaining a clandestine encrypted communication network, pushing coordinates and logistic tasks (drone drop), issuing relocation orders, and controlling route navigation.” The module executed these orders while conducting the attack.

A protected witness, who identified Faisal’s body, is learnt to have told investigators

that he had encountered Faisal along with three other terrorists in September 2024. The four, as per his recorded statements, spoke Punjabi and Urdu. “They were talking about one Sajid Jat and a location sent by him in Gogal Dara Jungle where a drone would drop a consignment,” the NIA is learnt to have said. The witness told investigators he was forced to take them to that location, “where a drone dropped a yellow-colored packet that contained 2 pistols, Rs 15 lakh, and triangle-shaped bombs.”

The investigation “clearly established” that two phones recovered from the terrorists “were sold in Pakistan”. The probe is also learnt to have highlighted the use of specialised apps to “communicate on their mobile phones with over-ground workers (OGWs)”.

The agency also noted Baisaran’s remote location and the lack of CCTV covering its expanse made it a target for the terrorists. The NIA questioned over 1,100 witnesses during the investigation. The chargesheet was filed before the Special NIA Court in Jammu in December 2025.

Rajesh Exports

inconsistent with the scale of the company’s operations.

According to the ED, the Chief Financial Officer (CFO) has not received any salary since 2020, while the Managing Director was drawing a monthly remuneration of only around Rs 17,000 despite the company reporting consolidated revenues of approximately Rs 7.7 lakh crore.

“The company’s key business indicators showed significant departures from normal commercial practices,” the ED said.

The searches, which began on June 23, were carried out at nine locations in Bengaluru and Mumbai.

According to the ED, Rajesh Exports failed to produce documentation relating to foreign transactions, including imports, exports, overseas investments and settlement of foreign trade receivables and payables.

“The company failed to produce documentation in respect of its foreign transactions... thereby rendering verification of the genuineness of such transactions almost impossible,” the agency said.

The ED cited as an example a purported investment of Rs 1,035 crore in African mining assets, stating that contemporaneous records and supporting documentation relating to the investment were neither found during searches nor provided by the company.

The agency also flagged what it described as opaque adjustments of foreign trade receivables and payables amounting to around Rs 3,000 crore.

Investigators found the company was setting off trade dues against receivables involving entities based in the UAE and other overseas jurisdictions that are now under

scrutiny.

A significant discrepancy was also detected during physical verification of inventory. According to the ED, the quantity of stock found at company premises was approximately 40 per cent lower than the stock reflected in factory records.

The investigation has also uncovered what the ED described as suspicious block trades in the company’s shares.

According to the agency, some individuals involved in these transactions feature in disclosures and leaks released by the International Consortium of Investigative Journalists (ICIJ), indicating possible undisclosed offshore links that are being examined.

The ED alleged that more than Rs 600 crore was siphoned out of India through share-manipulation transactions executed using NRI benamidars.

Queries emailed by *The Indian Express* to Rajesh Exports on the ED’s claims Wednesday did not elicit a response.

The latest findings add to the regulatory scrutiny facing Rajesh Exports after the Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI) last week alleged that the company had overstated revenues by approximately Rs 15.15 lakh crore between FY21 and FY25. SEBI had subsequently barred promoter chairman Rajesh Mehta and the company from accessing the securities market pending further investigation.

Rajesh Exports has denied SEBI’s allegations and maintained that its reported revenues are accurate. The company has attributed the regulator’s findings to what it described as a misunderstanding relating to the reporting of revenues and earnings figures of its Swiss subsidiary Valcambi.

stalled at their house. “However, they returned my phone and my wife’s phone after checking them,” Balwan said.

Sharma said Ankit is the youngest of three siblings, and had joined the National Investigation Agency (NIA) at a contractual position in New Delhi on November 3, 2025, at a monthly salary of Rs 60,000.

Before that, he had worked for several months with a private firm as a forensic expert. His son had studied forensic science after completing a course in computers, Sharma said.

“He does not have any laboratory here. If there is any laboratory, it may be in Delhi. He would usually come home only on Saturdays and Sundays after every few weeks,” Sharma said.

“We still do not know what the problem is. We have only learnt through video clips circulating on YouTube that it is related to a video involving the Punjab Chief Minister,” he said.

Ankit’s mother, Kavita, said her son had come home after almost a month around 9 am on June 20. “That same night, when we were asleep, the police arrived. They asked Ankit to accompany them. He asked them, ‘Sir, what is the matter?’, but they gave no answer,” she said.

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EXPRESSspecial

Ecological concerns as city runs out of space to dispose drain silt

Sophiya Mathew
New Delhi, June 24

AS DELHI has intensified desilting operations to improve drainage and prevent flooding ahead of the monsoon, authorities are grappling with a new concern: the heaps of silt being extracted from the city's drains. Officials say the material, often mixed with municipal waste, poses serious environmental risks and can no longer be disposed of through conventional means.

Disposing large quantities of silt has emerged as a major challenge for the Irrigation and Flood Control (I&FC) Department, which oversees flood-control drains across the Capital. Officials said conventional disposal mechanisms — such as strengthening embankments, filling low-lying areas, depositing the material at landfill sites and allowing contractors to lift it for reuse — have reached a saturation point.

The search for alternative disposal methods comes amid an intensified pre-monsoon desilting drive across the Capital. According to official figures released by the Delhi government on Wednesday, the I&FC department has removed 30.91 lakh MT silt from major and supplementary drains this year, up from around 19 lakh metric tonnes last year.

The Public Works Department (PWD), meanwhile, reported that it has completed desilting of 1,900.15 km of drains out of a total network of 2,125.87 km, achieving nearly 90% of its target. From Najafgarh drain, which constitutes the largest component of desilting operations so far, 12.7 lakh MT silt has been removed.

The challenge is particularly acute because the dredged material risks contamination to



Desilting underway at ITO in New Delhi on Wednesday. TASHI TOBGYAL

the surroundings. The department has a total of 77 drains under its jurisdiction, including 22 outfalling into the Yamuna river, and it had initially expected to clear more than 20 lakh MT of silt. According to officials, nearly 25 mixed-flow drains carrying both storm-water and sewage from which the department removes around 3.5 lakh MT silt pose a challenge as the waste contains municipal garbage and other contaminants, making its handling, disposal and reuse significantly complex.

Officials said as several low-lying areas and designated landfill sites have reached saturation, continuing to rely on traditional disposal practices is neither environmentally sustainable nor viable in the long term.

The I&FC department has invited Expressions of Interest (EOIs) from agencies engaged in legacy waste management, bio-mining and bioremediation to evolve methodologies for the handling, processing, scientific disposal and utilisation of silt extracted from its drains.

As part of this, the existing desilting and waste-handling practices will be assessed, including physical and chemical characterisation of dredged material, development of treat-

ment and reuse methods. Preparation of an implementation plan and ensuring compliance with norms prescribed by the Central Pollution Control Board (CPCB), Delhi Pollution Control Committee (DPCC) and the National Green Tribunal (NGT), are also part of the measures being undertaken.

PWD Minister Parvesh Sahib Singh Wednesday conducted an on-ground inspection in Moti Nagar to review monsoon preparedness, as per an official statement. He was quoted as saying, "Every drain, every road and every vulnerable point is being reviewed. Wherever shortcomings are found, immediate corrective action will be taken. We are ensuring that quality and preparedness remain the top priority."

The statement added: "The cumulative desilting achievement of 30.91 lakh MT is expected to substantially improve drainage capacity, facilitate faster discharge of rainwater and strengthen flood prevention measures across the city."

According to recent NGT submissions, the I&FC department has also said that it prepared a drain-wise and zone-wise action plan with "prioritization of critical and vulnerable drains".

AFTER 15 KILLED IN LUCKNOW FIRE

Crackdown on coaching centres: Inspections, sealing in Delhi-NCR

Drishti Jain
Noida, June 24

AFTER A fire at a three-storey building housing a coaching centre in Aliganj in Uttar Pradesh's Lucknow killed 15 people on Monday, Delhi has ordered a citywide inspection, while coaching institutes in Gautam Buddha Nagar and Ghaziabad faced actions — with some sealed, some inspected and several served notices — over compliance of fire safety and other norms.

While ordering an inspection drive of coaching centres across the city, Delhi Education Minister Ashish Sood directed agencies to check if major student hubs are complying with fire-safety and building norms. During a high-level meeting, Sood asked the Delhi Development Authority, the Municipal Corporation of Delhi, the Delhi Fire Services (DFS) and the Delhi Disaster Management Authority to conduct inspections in areas like Mukherjee Nagar, Rajender Nagar and Katwaria Sarai.

The MCD has been directed to share a list of 923 coaching centres surveyed across Delhi and submit a daily action-taken report to the Minister's office.

Sood said institutes found violating safety standards or other regulations would face strict action. He also directed the DFS and Delhi Police to act against errant operators. "The safety and welfare of students is our top priority. Any negligence affecting student safety will not be tolerated," he said.

At the meeting, regulatory gaps, students' welfare and alleged unfair commercial practices by coaching institutes were also discussed, officials said.

The Directorate of Higher Education is preparing a regulatory framework for coaching centres in Delhi that the government said would address systemic gaps, strengthen accountability and create a transparent mechanism for the sector. The draft framework will be submitted to the government shortly, officials said.



At the site of fire in Lucknow. FILE

Meanwhile, nine coaching institutes in Gautam Buddha Nagar were sealed and notices were issued to twelve others. In Ghaziabad, out of a total of 56 establishments where the police conducted inspections, 12 were found to be flouting norms, while two coaching institutions in Modinagar were sealed.

Officials said that a total of 66 institutions were inspected so far in Gautam Buddha Nagar as part of the drive which began on Tuesday.

On Wednesday, the District Inspector of Schools said a total of 46 coaching centres were inspected while five in Greater Noida were sealed with immediate effect due to the non-availability of required documents and non-compliance with prescribed standards.

Meanwhile, in Noida Sectors 16 and 18, as many as 12 coaching institutes were inspected, of which two were sealed. In Sector 22, four were inspected, and two were served notices and directed to halt operations. Additionally, six institutes were inspected in Noida Sectors 58 and 62.

Hotels and guest houses were also inspected in Jewar. While one of them was sealed, three others received notices.

In Ghaziabad, the District Magistrate Wednesday chaired a meeting, reviewing fire safety arrangements in residential societies and high-rise buildings across the district, directing the RWAs to maintain effective storage of combustible materials in basements, parking areas, and common-use spaces.

Delhi-NCR has reported multiple cases of fire this year that claimed several lives.

WITH INPUTS FROM ENS

Govt approves 270-km road repairing projects worth Rs 658 cr

Devansh Mittal
New Delhi, June 24

THE DELHI government approved Rs 657.99 crore to strengthen and repair 270 km of roads across the Capital, Chief Minister Rekha Gupta said on Wednesday, adding that the projects would focus on improving durability, road safety and construction quality.

The projects were cleared at a meeting of the Expenditure Finance Committee chaired by Gupta on Wednesday. The project will cover 270.63 km of roads in East, North and South Delhi and are likely to be completed by October, an official said.

Of the total approved outlay, Rs 147.08 crore has been earmarked for strengthening 58.292 km of roads in the East Maintenance Zone. Another Rs 247.31 crore will be spent on 104.42 km of roads in the North Maintenance Zone, while Rs 263.61 crore has been approved for 107.92 km in the South Maintenance Zone, officials said.

According to the government, the projects would involve cold milling of damaged road surfaces, followed by the laying of Dense Bituminous Macadam and Bituminous Concrete, the final road surface. Other works will include tack coats to bond old and new layers, lane and zebra-crossing markings, road furniture such as signboards, reflectors and safety barriers, and kerb channels for roadside drainage, officials said.

In a first, the government has also decided to introduce a zone-wise composite tendering system, replacing the conventional practice of issuing tenders road by road.

Under the new model, contractors will be responsible for maintaining roads during a five-year Defect Liability Period. The government said any potholes that develop during this period would have to be repaired within 48 hours.

Gupta said the projects were designed not only as a road-upgrade exercise but also with road safety and environmental considerations in mind.

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A REFLECTION ON A DARK ERA IN THE HISTORY OF INDIA

"It has been 50 years since the Emergency; no generation of the country should ever forget this sin of murdering the Constitution."

- Narendra Modi, Prime Minister

Date: 25th June 2026

Time: 4:00 pm

Venue: Centre for Cultural Resources & Training (CCRT), 15-A, Block D, Sector 7, Dwarka, Delhi

Program Highlights

Special exhibitions: 'Samvidhan Hatya Diwas' & 'Long Live Democracy'

Screening of short-film: 'Samvidhan Hatya Diwas'

A musical tribute to those who suffered yet remained courageous during the darkest period in Independent India's history

Chief Guest

Shri Gajendra Singh Shekhawat

Hon'ble Union Minister of Culture & Tourism, Government of India

Special Address By

Shri Ram Bahadur Rai

(Detainee During Emergency)

President of the Indira Gandhi National Centre for Arts

CBC 0910/13/0014/2627

GOVERNMENT OF NCT OF DELHI

OFFICE OF THE RETURNING OFFICER FOR ELECTION OF THE GENERAL BODY OF ALL INDIA HANDLOOM FABRICS MARKETING CO-OPERATIVE SOCIETY LIMITED/ DISTRICT MAGISTRATE (NEW DELHI DISTRICT)

12/1, JAMNAGAR HOUSE, SHAHJAHAN ROAD, NEW DELHI-110011

F.No. 1/DC/ND/RO/AIHFMCSL/2026/1759

Dated : 22/06/2026

NOTICE OF ELECTION

Conduct of Election of Delegates to constitute the General Body, Board of Directors & Office bearers of "All India Handloom Fabrics Marketing Cooperative Society Ltd. (AIHFMCSL)".

Notice is hereby given that:-

In Exercise of the powers conferred by Multi-State Cooperative Societies (MSCS) Act 2002, as amended by the MSCS amendment Act 2023 read with relevant provision made under MSCS Rules 2002, as amended with MSCS Rules in 2023, an election of "All India Handloom Fabrics Marketing Cooperative Society Ltd. (AIHFMCSL)" is to be held as per schedule attached herewith (Annexure-A), place of receipt of nomination (Annexure-B) and List of polling station (Annexure-C).

Date:-

RETURNING OFFICER (AIHFMCSL)

Place:-Chandigarh

Election Program [Rule 19H(2)]

Annexure-A

(A) General Information							
1. Name of MSCS	All India Handloom Fabrics Marketing Cooperative Society Ltd. (AIHFMCSL), Head Office, Rajiv Gandhi Handicrafts Bhavan, (3rd Floor) Baba Kharak Singh Marg, New Delhi-110001						
2. Registration No.	L-11016/2/83 dated 17.03.2016						
3. Returning Officer	District Magistrate/Collector, New Delhi						
4. Members of Board	Elected Board Members-19 (16 general, 1SC/ST & 2 Women) Nominated Member - 01 Total - 20						
5. Officer Bearers	1 President & 1 Vice President						
6. Operational Area	Whole of India						
7. Number of Members	1109						
8. Constituencies	Class	Member Category	By Law for Election Representative General Body	No. of Members	No. of Delegates to be elected	Bye Law for election of Director	No. of Director
	'A'	Apex Handloom Weavers Co-Operative Societies	20(b)	23	8	22(a)(i)	04
	'B'	Primary District Regional Level Handloom Weavers, Co-Operative Societies	20(b)	1054	23	22(a)(ii)	14
	'C'	Central /State Governments Government owned/ controlled corporation and other who are eligible under section 25(1) (h)	20(b)	32	2	22(a)(iii)	01
	Total			1109	33		19
9. Polling Booth	One polling booth to be set up Registered office/HQ, New Delhi or as decided by RO						
10. CEO Contact Detail	CEO	Mobile No.	E-mail ID				
	Mr. R Sundaresan	9244317031	allindiahandloom.ho@gmail.com				

(B) Program for seeking names of Representative from Members Societies who in terms will elect delegate

Particulars	Date
1. Handing over of List of Members (Constituency-Wise, Group-Wise) by Chief Executive, society to RO	22nd June 2026 (Monday)
2. Publication of List of Members (Constituency-Wise, Group-Wise) by on notice board and on website of the Society RO	On or before 23rd June, 2026 (Tuesday)
3. A Sending of letters to Societies by RO requesting them to send names of their representatives	On or before 25th June, 2026 (Thursday)
4. Receiving of resolution of for representative from Members-Societies by RO	On or before 23rd July, 2026 (Thursday)
5. Examination /Verification of documents of delegates received under Rule 19H(5), Rule 19H(6), Rule 19(H) (7) and section 38(3)	23rd July, 2026 to 24th July, 2026 (Thursday to Friday)
(i) Receipt of Performa of delegates /representative from Member-Society and State Govts. As per Proforma Annexed at (Annexure-4)	
(ii) Proforma to be accompanied by original Fresh Resolution of the Board of the Member - Society. [Rule 19(H) (7)] or Govt. Order in case of Government Representative.	
(iii) Proforma to be submitted by the Members Society to the Returning Officer and not to Chief Executive of the society [Refer Section 38(3) of MSCS act] and under Rule 19H(5), 19H(6) & 19H(7) of MSCS Rules recommending the name of delegates for the General Body of Society.	

(C) The Program for the election of Delegates to constitute the General Body

1. Display of provisional voter list (Constituency-Wise, Group-Wise)	27.07.2026 (Monday)	By Evening		
2. Filing objection against Provision Voter List	28.07.2026 to 31.07.2026 (Tuesday to Friday)	10.00 AM to 02.00 PM		
3. Scrutiny of objections received to the Provisional List	03.08.2026 to 06.08.2026 (Monday to Thursday)	10.00 AM to 02.00 PM		
4. Display of Final voter List (Constituency- Wise, Group-Wise)	06.08.2026 (Thursday)	By Evening		
5. Issue and Filing nomination form for election of Delegates	07.08.2026 to 12.08.2026 (Friday to Wednesday) (Except Saturday & Sunday)	10.00 AM to 04.00 PM		
6. Scrutiny of nomination forms	17.08.2026 (Monday)	Till completion of Scrutiny		
7. Publication of valid nomination forms-group wise	17.08.2026 (Monday)	After Scrutiny		
8. Withdrawal of nomination form	18.08.2026 (Tuesday)	10.00 AM to 03.00 PM		
9. Display of list of contesting valid candidate Group Wise	18.08.2026 (Tuesday)	By Evening		
10. Polling (if necessary)	Pooling booths to be set up as under or as decided by RO			
	For State/UTs/Class	Pooling Booth	Date of Polling	Counting
	Haryana, Special/Separate constituency (as per bye-laws clause no. 20(b) (iii) and Class-'A' members	New Delhi	27.08.2026	Immediate after Poll
	MH, Chhattisgarh & GJ	Mumbai	27.08.2026	
	A.P., Telangana	Hyderabad	28.08.2026	
	T.N., Kerala, Karnataka	Chennai	28.08.2026	
	Manipur, Assam, Tripura, W.B., Jharkhand & U.P.	Kolkata	31.08.2026	
		Varansi	31.08.2026	
11. Declaration of Result by RO	01.09.2026			
Note: 1. Nomination to be filed separately for each group, as per Bye-Laws				
© Election program for Board of Director amongst the elected delegate				
1. Publication of List of Representative General Body	02.09.2026		By Evening	
2. Issue and Filing of Nomination form for Director	07.09.2026 to 10.09.2026 (Monday to Thursday)		11.00 AM to 03.00PM	
3. Display of nomination received by Returning Officer on Website & Notice Board of the society	10.09.2026 (Thursday)		By Evening	
4. Scrutiny of Received Nomination Forms	11.09.2026 (Friday)		Till Completion of Scrutiny	
5. Publication of List of Valid Nomination	11.09.2026 (Friday)		Immediately After Scrutiny	
6. Withdrawal of Nominations	12.09.2026 (Saturday)		11.00 AM to 03.00PM	
7. Publication of final list of Contesting Candidates	12.09.2026 (Saturday)		By Evening	
8. Date of Polling if necessary	20.09.2026 (Sunday)		08.00 AM to 04.00 PM and all those who have entered polling station at 04.00 PM or before should be allowed to Cast vote.	
9. Counting of Votes	20.09.2026 (Sunday)		Immediate after poll	
10. Submission of Form 19M with recommendation for seeking approval of CEA before declaration of result of BOD	21.09.2026 (Monday)			
11. Declaration of result of Board Director	On or Before 25th September 2026			

(D) Nomination form Central Government

1. Receipt of Nomination form Central Govt. by RO	On or Before 19th September, 2026 (Saturday)	
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(E) Election Program of Office Bearer

Announcement of Election Schedule	28.09.2026 (Monday)	
Time window for filing nomination	09.30 AM to 11.30 AM	
1. Scrutiny of nomination papers	12.30 PM to 02.00 PM	
Time window and date for withdrawal	02.00 PM to 04.00 PM	
Display of list of the contesting candidate and schedule of election	By evening	
2. Meeting of Newly Contesting Board & Publication of List for Valid Nomination and polling (if required)	30.09.2026 (Monday)	11.00 AM onwards
3. Declaration of Result of Election of Office Bearers	On or Before 06 October 2026	

LIST OF POLLING STATION

Annexure-C

S. No.	State	Place of Polling
1.	NEW DELHI	All India Handloom Fabrics Marketing Co-Op, Society Ltd., Head Office, Rajiv Gandhi Handicrafts Bhawan, (3rd Floor) Baba Kharak Singh Marg, New Delhi - 110001
2.	CHENNAI	O/o Assistant Returning Officer All India Handloom Fabrics Marketing Co-op, Society Ltd., Export Department 6, Sunkurama Street, Chennai -600001, Tamil Nadu.
3.	HYDRABAD	O/o Assistant Returning Officer All India Handloom Fabrics Marketing Co-op, Society Ltd., Handloom House, Machani Somappa Bhawan, 5-5-395 Mukhramjahi Road, Nampally, Hyderabad-500001, Telangana.
4.	KOLKATA	O/o Assistant Returning Officer All India Handloom Fabrics Marketing Co-op, Society Ltd., Zonal Procurement Center, 2, Garstin Plac, Kolkata -700001, West Bengal
5.	VARANASI	O/o Assistant Returning Officer All India Handloom Fabrics Marketing Co-op, Society Ltd., Zonal Procurement Center, J-12 /35-E, Dhoochandni, Nati Imli, Varanasi-221002, Uttar Pradesh
6.	MUMBAI	O/o Assistant Returning Officer All India Handloom Fabrics Marketing Co-op, Society Ltd., Zonal Procurement Center, 211-219, Bharati Bhavan, 2nd Floor P.D., Mello Road, Opp. St. George Hospital, Mumbai -400001, Maharashtra.

PLACE OF NOMINATION FOR DIRECTORS

S. No.	State	Place of Polling
1.	NEW DELHI	O/o Returning Officer/ District Magistrate, 12/1, Jam Nagar House, Shahjahan Road New Delhi-110011

PLACE OF NOMINATION FOR OFFICE BEARERS

S. No.	State	Place of Polling
1.	NEW DELHI	O/o Returning Officer/ District Magistrate, 12/1, Jam Nagar House, Shahjahan Road New Delhi-110011

PLACE OF NOMINATION FOR DELEGATES

Annexure-B

S. No.	State	Place of Polling
1.	NEW DELHI	O/o Returning Officer/ District Magistrate (New Delhi District) All India Handloom Fabrics Marketing Co-Op, Society Ltd., 12/1, Jam Nagar House, Shahjahan Road, New Delhi-110011
2.	CHENNAI	O/o Assistant Returning Officer All India Handloom Fabrics Marketing Co-op, Society Ltd., Export Department, 6, Sunkurama, Street, Chennai-600001 Tamil Nadu
3.	HYDERABAD	O/o Assistant Returning Officer All India Handloom Fabrics Marketing Co-op, Society Ltd., Handloom House, Machani Somappa Bhawan 5-5-395, Mukhramjahi Road, Nampally, Hyderabad-500001, Telangana.
4.	KOLKATA	O/o Assistant Returning Officer All India Handloom Fabrics Marketing Co-op, Society Ltd., Zonal Procurement Center, 2 Garstin Plac, Kolkata - 700001, West Bengal
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New Delhi

epaper.indianexpress.com

10-YEAR-OLD RAPED AND MURDERED IN SOUTH DELHI'S MEHRAULI AREA

Build shelters for homeless: Police set to tell govt

4 am to 11 am: Accused changed his clothes, cleaned car, dropped passenger before arrest

Robust screening of drivers working with ride-hailing apps to be sought

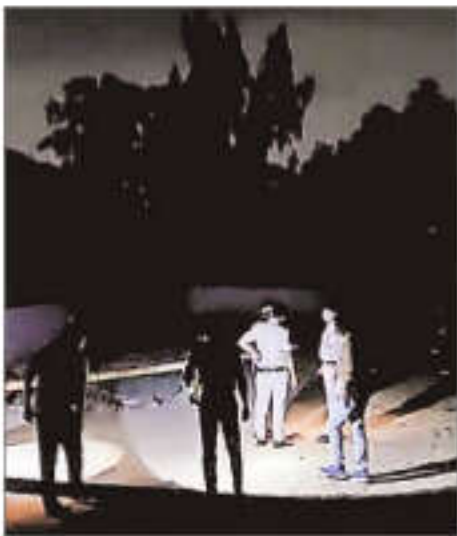
Pragynesh
New Delhi, June 24

A SHELTER for homeless people living on the streets, and a policy to have a robust screening for drivers registered with ride-hailing apps — these are two proposals that will be made by the Delhi Police in separate letters to South Delhi’s District Magistrate and the government, respectively, *The Indian Express* has learnt. The proposals come in the wake of the rape and murder of a 10-year-old homeless girl in Mehrauli area on Monday.

Sources said that the letter to the District magistrate would also mention that homeless people should be provided with jobs in organised sectors for them to get off the streets.

Moving homeless people to a shelter would prevent such incidents and keep them safer, said a source. The source also confirmed that they will also write to the Delhi government seeking a policy for robust screening for drivers registering with ride hailing platforms.

Bashu Kumar Singh, the cab driver who allegedly kidnapped, raped and killed the girl sleeping on the pavement near a Delhi Metro station with her family members, was arrested in the early hours of Monday.



Police inspect the site where the accused attacked them and was injured in return fire.

He had allegedly dumped her body in the Aravali forests along the Gurgaon-Faridabad Road. Bashu was registered with three separate ride-hailing platforms, despite having a total of five cases against him in Bihar, and had recently appeared to Bihar Public Service Commission (BPSC), said police. His family had been living in Gurgaon’s Chakkarpur village for the past 10 years.

He often went to the home where his elder brother, his sister-in-law and the younger brother lived. His younger brother is in college, while the elder one works with a private bank. Police said Bashu, who is from Bihar, is married, with two children aged six months and four years.

The victim, the eldest of four siblings, lived with her parents on the streets of South Delhi, said police. The family from Bihar had come to Delhi four months ago in search of work but they were forced to sleep on the roadside in the absence of a steady income.

Pragynesh
New Delhi, June 24

AROUND 4.15 am on Monday, cab driver Bashu Kumar Singh allegedly kidnapped a 10-year-old girl sleeping on the pavement near a Metro station in South Delhi, raped and killed her, and then dumped her body in the Aravalli forest along the Gurgaon-Faridabad Road.

Sources said the 29-year-old then headed to the house of the cab owner in Gurgaon.

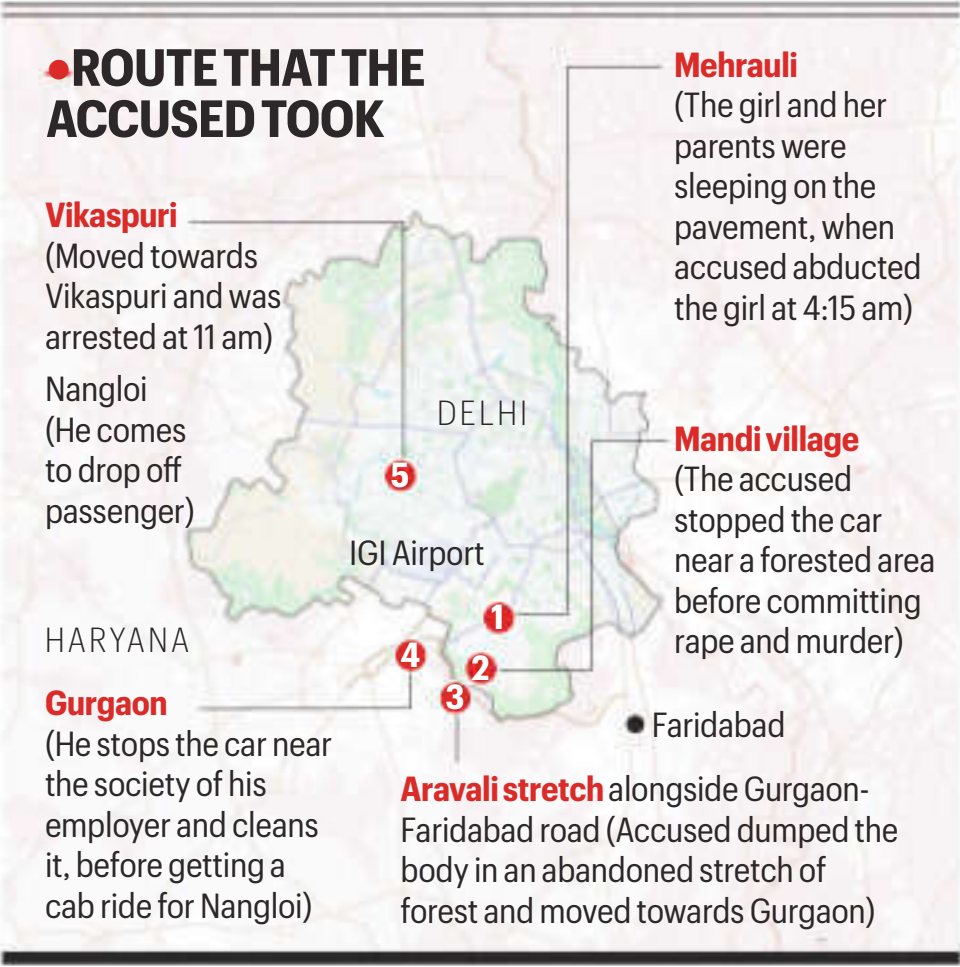
Near the home, a source said, he stopped to change his clothes and clean the car. The cab owner, a 26-year-old, had started his firm just months ago, and the white Wagon R — that Bashu drove — was his first car.

Around 4 am, Bashu, according to the investigators, first stopped near a Metro station in the Mehrauli area. “When he stopped the car, he was probably intoxicated,” said an officer.

The area is lined with temporary shelters — made of tarpaulin shades — where the homeless people spent the night.

Some don’t even have that — they are forced to sleep on the footpath. One of the families sleeping in the area was that 10-year-old girl’s family, who Bashu allegedly abducted.

Sources said he then



headed towards Gurgaon, crossing the Mandi village, which is dotted with dilapidated residential buildings and shops. The route leads to a vast stretch of farmhouses, including some upscale ones made by DLF.

The stretch has street lamps, but the farmhouses, and some abandoned patches of forest land cast a dark shadow once the night falls.

It was near one of these forests—about 7 km from where he allegedly kidnapped her—that he stopped the car and allegedly raped and then murdered

the child, sources said.

As the Mandi road ends, about 200 m away is the Gurgaon-Faridabad road where a three-km stretch of Aravali forest runs alongside.

Most of the forests have some construction work ongoing, with high-rises on the other side. But some patches are empty lots of wild shrubs, with no street light to pierce the darkness. It’s here where Bashu allegedly dumped the body.

He worked for two ride-hailing apps and wasn’t getting any rides in the early hours, a police source told *The Indian Express*.



Bashu Kumar Singh in police custody. EXPRESS

Around 8 am, he headed straight to the cab owner’s house, about 3 km from Gurgaon’s upscale Golf Course Road area. When he reached close to the house, he cleaned the car, said investigators. “But then he suddenly got a booking for a drop to Nangloi in Outer Delhi. He picked up the customer and headed towards the location. After the drop, while he was in Vikaspuri, he was arrested by the Delhi Police, who were on his heels by then, at 11 am,” said the source.

The source also said during questioning, Bashu allegedly claimed he was ‘frustrated’ that he was not getting any rides that night. When he reached

the Mehrauli area, he found the girl sleeping and decided to abduct her.

Police said the vehicle — a white Wagon R with a commercial plate — was traced using CCTV and registration details. By 11 am on Monday, the accused was taken into custody.

Police said the suspect allegedly attempted to snatch a service revolver from an escorting officer and fired at the party while being taken to the crime scene.

He was injured in the leg when police returned fire. He was subsequently admitted to hospital and a separate case for assault on a police officer has been registered.

If Bashu is guilty, please hang him, says brother of accused

‘He recently went to Bihar to take police recruitment exam,’ says kin

Nirbhay Thakur & Pragynesh

New Delhi, June 24

TUCKED AWAY behind Gurgaon’s Mega Mall lies Chakkarpur village — a labyrinth of dense, multi-story concrete structures packed tightly against narrow and unpaved lanes.

It is a typical urban village where thousands of migrant workers find cheap rental accommodations, stacked atop one another.

In A-Block, a single building

rises five floors high — its damp corridors filled with the faint smell of cooking gas.

On the fifth floor is a cramped space that Jaikishan Singh (31), the elder brother of Bashu Kumar Singh who was arrested on Monday for allegedly raping and killing a 10-year-old girl in South Delhi’s Mehrauli, and his wife Sudoba call home.

Jaikishan, who works as a deputy manager with a private bank, is still processing what happened. “The police came to my branch office in Gurgaon on Monday afternoon and took me to the station. My wife was already there. If Bashu is guilty, please hang him. But I just want the trial to be fair,” he added.

Despite having been booked in five cases, 29-year-old Bashu had been driving cabs for ride-hailing apps in Delhi-NCR for



The lane outside the house where the family of the accused stays in Chakkarpur village in Gurgaon.

EXPRESS

10 years. Five cases were filed against Bashu in 2015, 2017, 2018 and

2022 in Bihar — two of attempted murder and three related to brawls.

He also allegedly attacked a police officer in Bihar’s Khagaria district. As per the police,

Five cases were filed against Bashu in 2015, 2017, 2018 and 2022 in Bihar — two of attempted murder and three related to brawls.

Kumar had not undergone the mandatory police verification required for driving cabs.

However, his brother said that those cases against him in Bihar were “very typical” for that area. “There are property disputes where people lodge criminal cases against each other to deter them. I never took them for something too serious in my brother’s case. Every year, he came to Delhi for six months, drove his cab and earned some money. He came

to my place to eat and occasionally sleep,” said Jaikishan.

Sudoba, on the other hand, is still in shock after his arrest.

To his family members, Bashu was just another kin trying to scrape together a living in the NCR. “He used to say Bhabhi (sister-in-law) is equivalent to a mother,” Sudoba said. “We don’t know what he does outside. Had we known this, my husband would have never let him stay near us. We’re from Bengal and have been staying in Delhi for 8-9 years. He used to mostly stay on the road...I suppose. We would mostly talk on the phone only. When he would be in Delhi, he would come here twice a week,” she added.

“He had gone back to his village in Bihar to give an exam on June 10. I think it was for the post of police constable.”

GROUNDreport

10 lakh kg waste processed in 8 years: Lessons from a zero-waste residential colony in Delhi

Navjeevan Vihar’s 280 households attempted something rare — segregating, processing most of the waste within the community

Mishal Mussaddique

New Delhi, June 24

IN FEBRUARY 2017, shortly after moving into Navjeevan Vihar, Dr Ruby Makhija’s car was stolen. She approached the colony’s Residents’ Welfare Association (RWA) seeking better security measures. Impressed by her ideas, the RWA appointed her secretary.

Around the same time, the Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) had begun pushing for the implementation of Solid Waste Management rules and calling RWAs for consultations.

For Makhija, the timing felt consequential. “We are privileged. We see the contrast between cleanliness abroad and in India. I wanted to change that,” she said.

What began as discussions around governance gradually evolved into a larger question: “Could a residential colony manage its own waste instead of contributing to Delhi’s over-

flowing landfills?” she recalls.

That question led Navjeevan Vihar’s 280 households to attempt something rare in Delhi — becoming a zero-waste colony where residents segregate and process most of their waste within the community itself. Eight years later, the colony claims to have diverted more than 10 lakh kilograms of waste from landfills. Following Lieutenant Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu’s visit this week, the model is now being discussed as one that could extend beyond affluent neighbourhoods into other parts of the city.

How they started implementation

Makhija says institutional support from MCD helped early on. “The Deputy Commissioner at MCD helped us a lot. He said he’d go the extra mile if our RWA took up the initiative. That gave us the boost we needed,” said Makhija.

The team then spent



Compost being collected at the waste management centre.

MISHAL MUSSADDIQUE

months studying waste management models in India and abroad, paying particular attention to why many failed. “The project formally began in 2019,” she said. Makhija said funding largely came from the RWA’s maintenance pool.

“We collect Rs 1,200 from each household as maintenance, and 95% of residents pay upfront for the entire year, so it’s easy for us to budget,” she said.

Residents were asked to segregate waste at source using separate bins for wet, dry, and hazardous waste. “Wet waste was composted within the colony. Dry waste was stored at an RRR (Reduce-Reuse-Recycle) centre before being sent for recycling. Compost generated

through the process was reused in the colony’s green spaces,” she explains.

Now, according to residents, the colony generates around 250–275 kg of waste every day. Dry waste accounts for around 105–110 kg, while wet waste amounts to 120–125 kg. The rest is sanitary and hazardous waste.

“The compost bins we bought four years ago cost Rs 6 lakh, including one year of consumables. These days, they cost much less,” said Makhija.

The challenges

The biggest obstacle was not infrastructure but behaviour.

“Daily segregation remained inconsistent despite broad support,” she said.

Makhija said her core team responded with a mix of accountability and community pressure. “Residents who repeatedly failed to segregate were identified in colony groups. Children became ambassadors — learning about waste management in schools and through door-to-door campaigns, then encouraging parents to comply,” she said. There was another hurdle: domestic workers initially resisted, viewing segregation as additional labour.

“The RWA introduced incentives, including monthly distribution of biodegradable sanitary napkins for workers and their daughters,” she said.

Garbage collectors, too, became stakeholders once they were allowed to retain earnings from recyclable dry waste, she says. “Infrastructure required adjustments as well. Early compost pits created odour complaints from nearby homes, prompting the colony to shift to enclosed composting units,” Makhija said.

Over time, Makhija says the project became less about waste and more about participation. “The lesson is that waste systems succeed only when communities feel ownership,” she said.

The RWA’s framework, she says, now focuses on three variables: space, funding, and local leadership. “The habits need to be fixed, not the waste,” she said.

How they are helping others

The experiment has since expanded beyond one colony. Makhija founded the NGO Why Waste Wednesdays, which now audits residential colonies, DDA flats, and cantonment areas across Delhi, helping communities design local waste systems. Replication, she says, has limits. “Smaller colonies and lower-income neighbourhoods often lack funds and infrastructure, though MCD support can fill some gaps through shared composting facilities,” she said.

However, she now believes that Lieutenant Governor’s endorsement has opened a new possibility. “We have had awareness sessions in some colonies. But not an end-to-end waste management project. They barely produce any waste compared to the upscaled colonies since they reuse most of their products. I haven’t received any structure or plan from the MCD or concerned authorities, but I’m sure there will be discussions soon about the project,” she said.

From drones to traffic management: LG calls for people-centric policing



LG Taranjit Singh Sandhu with senior police officers at a review meeting on Wednesday. X/LTG@VDELHI

Express News Service
New Delhi, June 24

STRICT ACTION against reckless driving, leveraging AI, drones for crime prevention, need for a community policing framework, timely promotions — these were among the key issues highlighted by LG Taranjit Singh Sandhu during his first visit on Wednesday to the Delhi Police Headquarters after assuming office.

Laying out a roadmap for proactive, technology-driven and people-centric policing in the Capital, the LG chaired a high-level review meeting on Wednesday with Police Commissioner Satish Golcha and senior officers.

The meeting, which lasted for two hours, was attended by all Special Commissioners of Police, Joint Commissioners and Deputy Commissioners of

Kin of accused threatened survivor's family, court told in school rape case

Sohini Ghosh

New Delhi, June 24

AS THE Delhi High Court on Wednesday heard pleas by the state government challenging the bail granted to a man accused of raping a child in a school in the city, the survivor’s family claimed before the court that they were threatened and intimidated outside the court premises.

An FIR was lodged in the case on May 1 when the child’s mother filed a police complaint, alleging that her daughter was sexually assaulted during school hours by a staff member of the school.

The staffer was booked for rape under BNS and aggravated penetrative sexual assault under the Protection of Children from Sexual Offences (POCSO) Act in the case.

A teacher was also booked after the child allegedly told investigators that the teacher was present when she was sexually assaulted. Apart from the State, the survivor’s family too has moved a plea before the High Court, seeking cancellation of the bail to the two accused.

On Wednesday, the pleas were heard by Justice Vinod Kumar. Additional Solicitor General (ASG) SV Raju — appearing for the prosecution — highlighted the seriousness of the offence, and that the child victim also identified the accused as well as made specific allegations, and thus bail granted requires to be cancelled. The complainant’s counsel meanwhile, told the court, “There are certain facts I wish to bring to the court’s notice which have happened subsequently, with regard to threatening, intimidation and with regard to an incident that has happened today in the court premises...the main witness has been threatened, today also an incident has happened...the bail granted was in a very casual manner and it should be set aside.”

Meanwhile, the complainant, the survivor’s mother, also orally submitted before the court, “*Aaj bhi inke ladke ne Gate 7 ke bahar battameezi ki hai* (today too the accused staffer’s son has misbehaved with us outside Gate no 7 of Delhi HC).” The court will consider the plea seeking cancellation of the bail granted to the teacher on July 8.

Meanwhile, former AAP MLA Saurabh Bharadwaj took to X terming the alleged threats to be “shocking”.



Austerity Drive

UNION MINISTERS Jyoti-raditya Scindia and Sarbana-da Sonowal carpooled to the Union Cabinet meeting on Wednesday in line with Prime Minister Narendra Modi's call for energy conservation. Sonowal, the Minister of Ports, Shipping and Waterways, is not the only minister to have carpooled with Scindia. Heeding the PM's austerity call, Scindia, the Union Minister for Communications and Development of North Eastern Region, had travelled with Union Civil Aviation Minister Ram Mohan Naidu to a similar meeting on June 10.

Emergency Clash

AS THE Congress prepares to hold press conferences across the country on Thursday on issues related to students under the 'Chhatron Ki Goonj' campaign, some party leaders are concerned about the selection of the date. Thursday happens to be June 25, which is also the 51st anniversary of the Emergency imposed by former PM Indira Gandhi. Some Congress members fear their press conferences may get overshadowed by the BJP's narrative on the Emergency. The Congress has planned press briefings in 28 cities, with senior party leaders flying out to the venues to address the media.

Mango Mission

Taking a cue from Prime Minister Narendra Modi's recent mention of Indian mango varieties on his radio show, Mann Ki Baat, BJP president Nitin Nabin on Wednesday sent mangoes to 82 Head of Missions in New Delhi with a personal note. This comes amid a surge in demand for Indian mangoes abroad.

SPG chief gets a 9-month extension

New Delhi: Senior IPS officer Alok Sharma was on Wednesday given nine-month extension as the chief of Special Protection Group (SPG) that provides security to the Prime Minister and his immediate family members residing with him at his official residence. Sharma, a 1991-batch IPS officer of UP cadre, was appointed to the post on November 17, 2023. He was due to superannuate this month after completion of 60 years of age. PTI

Panel recommends in-principle nod for Kirthai-II hydel project

Nikhil Ghanekar
New Delhi, June 24

THE FOREST advisory committee (FAC) of the Environment Ministry has recommended in-principle approval for diversion of 197 hectares of forest land for the 820 MW Kirthai-II hydroelectric project on the Chenab river in Indus basin. The project was recommended for grant of environment clearance in 2021, but was subject to the grant of in-principle forest clearance as the project site is located in moderate to dense, high-mountainous forest area. Kirthai-II becomes the third hydroelectric project planned on the Chenab to receive approvals from the Environment ministry since the suspension of the Indus Water Treaty (IWT) in the wake of the Pahalgalam terror attack in 2025. The Centre has moved to expedite hydel projects stalled or proposed in the Indus basin since IWT's suspension. Sawalkote, Dulhasti-II, Ratle, Pakal Dul, Kwar, Kiru, and Kirthai Stage-I and II, are some of the projects planned on the Chenab river. Under the IWT, Pakistan controlled the waters of Indus, Jhelum and Chenab while India controlled Ravi, Beas and Sutlej. The Kirthai-II project site is a natural habitat of chilgoza pine trees. Even as multiple projects are proposed in the Chenab basin, the Jammu and Kashmir government has dispensed with the requirement of the cumulative impact assessment and carrying capacity in respect of Indus, Chenab and Jhelum rivers. Kirthai-II will be a run-of-the-river project, and its original proposed capacity of 930 MW has now been reduced to 820 MW, as per the FAC's minutes of the June 10 meeting. The project will be implemented by the Chenab

Multiple entries to maximum attempts: UPSC rejects 569 applications at Prelims stage

UPSC rolls out AI exercise to weed out ineligible candidates

Damini Nath
New Delhi, June 24

IN A first, the Union Public Service Commission (UPSC) carried out an exercise using AI to weed out ineligible applications for the Civil Services (Preliminary) Examination, 2026, at the preliminary stage itself, rejecting 569 such applications, *The Indian Express* has learnt. These included multiple applications by the same individual and applicants who had exhausted the maximum number of attempts.

This comes two years after then-IAS trainee Puja Khedkar was dismissed from service in 2024. Khedkar was found to have appeared for the CSE-2022 despite exhausting the maximum number of attempts, by changing her name and her parents' names. The UPSC later cancelled her candidature. Until last year, the UPSC would carry out these checks at the interview stage, after the candidate had cleared the preliminary and main examination. As per rules, six attempts up to the age of 32 years are allowed for the general category, nine attempts up to the age of 35 years for OBCs, and unlimited attempts up to the



A total of 8.18 lakh candidates registered for the exam on May 24. FILE

age of 37 years for SCs and STs. This time, a total of 8.18 lakh candidates had signed up for the examination that was held on May 24, with 5.49 lakh appearing for it. The number of applicants had reduced from 9.5 lakh in 2025, according to UPSC. According to UPSC sources, one of the possible reasons for the reduction in the number of candidates could be a series of steps introduced for the first time in the CSE this year, including Aadhaar-based authentication and de-duplication using AI.

Last year, the UPSC had rolled out a new portal for applicants, which gave the option of Aadhaar authentication for the 2026 exams. According to UPSC officials, about 94% of the applicants had opted for this, which means that they were unique applicants, with no possibility of duplication. For the remaining, around 49,000 applicants, the UPSC

used AI to detect duplicates by searching for the name, parent's name, date of birth and photos, they said.

After that, the UPSC checked if the candidates had exhausted the attempts allowed or surpassed the age limit for their category. A UPSC official said this was done using AI, looking at the applicants' database of 15 years.

In the case of the CSE, 569 such candidates were found, who had exhausted their attempts or crossed the age limit for their category, leading to the rejection of their applications. Another 69 such candidates for the Indian Forest Service examination on May 24 were also detected using the same tool, officials said.

When reached for comment, UPSC Chairman Ajay Kumar said: "Technology must serve the cause of fairness. This year, UPSC undertook a de-duplication exercise at the Prelims

examination application stage to ensure that every genuine candidate is correctly identified and that fraudulent or multiple applications are detected and eliminated. The exercise relies on secure comparison with the Commission's existing database while ensuring that candidates' information remains fully protected. UPSC strives to create a level playing field for every candidate, and technology is an important enabler in achieving that objective."

Checking for changes in the social category of candidates from previous attempts, which, too, was earlier done at the interview stage, was also done at the Prelims stage this time, officials said. Using AI, the UPSC checked if the category selected by an applicant had changed from the category selected by them in a previous attempt, for example from general to EWS or from SC to OBC. A total of 43,497 such candidates were found, it is learnt.

The UPSC then sent emails to all of them, cross-checking the change. It was found that many of the candidates had earlier applied for general category as they were not able to get the relevant certificate in time, sources said. A total of 133 applications (part of the total 569) were cancelled as a result of this exercise as they had crossed the number of attempts allowed for the respective categories, they said.

Passport a travel document, not proof of citizenship: MEA

Divya A
New Delhi, June 24

A PASSPORT is a travel document, not a proof of citizenship, the Ministry of External Affairs has said.

Even though it is issued only to citizens, it is not a document that establishes citizenship, officials clarified on Wednesday.

Earlier this year, during the hearing on the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls, the Supreme Court said Aadhaar was not conclusive proof of citizenship, just a document of identity.

The MEA also underlined measures incorporated in the new chip-based e-passports, such as biometric data, to boost global acceptance and reduce the risk of fraud.

Officials said the government continues to expand the ease of services with over 500 Passport Kendras and delivery of 1.5 crore passports and related services in 2025.

With six working days for passports, excluding police verification, the time spent at passport seva kendras spans less than 45 minutes, officials said.

Every Indian is a VIP, says Vice-President

Express News Service
New Delhi, June 24

UNDERLINING THE need for leadership that is accessible and accountable, Vice-President CP Radhakrishnan on Wednesday said the perception of "VIP culture" could weaken the trust between citizens and government.

Radhakrishnan was speaking at the launch of the book, *VIP Culture in India: Power, Privilege and the Distance from Democracy*, by Nabam Rebha, former Rajya Sabha MP from Arunachal Pradesh, and Sandeep Kumar, a UPSC coach and motivational speaker.

"Democracy flourishes when public office is seen as a responsibility rather than a special privilege. True leadership is always being accessible, accountable and connected to the aspirations of an ordinary man and woman," Radhakrishnan said.

Speaking on VIP culture, he said: "The phenomenon commonly described as VIP culture has been a subject of public debate. It includes both visible privileges and the perception that some people receive special treatment due to their position. Such perceptions can weaken public trust and create a sense of distance between the citizens and the institutions," he said.

He said Prime Minister Narendra Modi had emphasised that "public office is a means of service, rather than a privilege". Quoting the Prime Minister's remarks after the government's decision to do away with red beacons on the cars of VIPs, the Vice-President said: "Every Indian is special, every Indian is a VIP".

House panel chief flags Great Nicobar project issues; BJP members say stick to the agenda

Asad Rehman
New Delhi, June 24

THE PARLIAMENTARY Committee on Public Accounts on Wednesday discussed the Great Nicobar Island (GNI) project, with chairperson and Congress leader K C Venugopal and several Opposition members raising concerns over the project's impact on the ecology of the islands. Venugopal is learnt to have directed Union Home Secretary Govind Mohan to submit a reply on the issues linked to the project during the committee's next meeting.

The committee's agenda for Wednesday's meeting was to discuss the CAG audit paras pertaining to Andaman and Nicobar Islands Institute of Medical Sciences and the Chandigarh Welfare Board. It took suo motu cognisance of the GNI project, which has been criticised by the Congress and the Leader of Opposition, Rahul Gandhi.

Venugopal raised questions on the absence of the Andaman and Nicobar chief secretary at the meet and sought an explanation from the Home Secretary. Speaking to reporters after the meeting, Venugopal said the officer, who was summoned by the committee, had on Tuesday night informed that he would not be present at the meeting.

"He asked for permission... I did not grant it," he said.

"The Andaman and Nicobar chief secretary was not present at the meeting and the committee took a serious note of that. The committee has asked the Union Home Secretary to give an explanation on why he was not present at today's meeting," said Venugopal.

It is learnt the BJP members on the panel demanded that the discussion be held as per the agenda of the meeting, but Venugopal said since the GNI project was a matter of public importance, it could be discussed impromptu.

The Opposition members on the panel posed a set of questions to the Union Home Secretary. When he said he was not prepared to answer questions related to the project, Venugopal told him he should brief the committee on the issue during the next meeting.

The GNI project, spread over 166 sq km and featuring a transhipment container port, an international military-civilian-use airport, power infrastructure and a greenfield coastal city, involves the felling of 13,000 hectares of forests.

LoP Gandhi has alleged that the project is "one of the biggest scams" against India's natural and tribal heritage.

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Pandian wife's likely entry to BJD sparks succession debate

Sujit Bisoyi
Bhubaneswar, June 24

IN A significant move in Odisha politics, former IAS officer Sujata Rout Karthikeyan, wife of bureaucrat-turned-politician V K Pandian, is likely to join the Biju Janata Dal on Thursday.

Though the BJD is yet to officially confirm her induction, party insiders said BJD supremo Naveen Patnaik would induct Karthikeyan into the party. A group of senior BJD leaders visited Naveen Niwas, the residence of the BJD president, on Wednesday, where he is believed to have informed them about Sujata's entry into the party.

"We will support whatever decision is taken by the party president. When I was Minister for Women and Child Development, she had worked as secretary and was an able administrator. Her joining will be beneficial for the party," said former min-

ister Tukuni Sahu.

There has been speculation about her entry into the BJD for the past few months. The 2000-batch IAS officer from Kendrapara opted for voluntary retirement in March last year.

Although Sujata is unlikely to take up any position in the party and may work in Patnaik's office, a senior BJD leader said her induction is part of the party's larger succession plan.

"In view of Naveen Babu's advancing age and ailing health, he needs someone to assist in running the party, which still has a massive support base across Odisha. Sujata is likely to play that role," said a BJD leader, requesting anonymity.

Sujata's husband, VK Pandian, also a 2000-batch IAS officer and Patnaik's trusted bureaucrat, took VRS and joined the BJD in November 2023, months before the general and Assembly elections. He spear-

headed the party's campaign and candidate selection for the 2024 polls, in which the BJD suffered a major setback, losing power after ruling the state for 24 years. During the elections, the BJP's top leadership, including Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Home Minister Amit Shah, ran an aggressive campaign targeting Pandian's Tamil identity, which is believed to have contributed to the BJD's electoral setback. Pandian announced his exit from active politics after the party's defeat.

Sujata's possible entry into the BJD may not gone down well with a section of senior party leaders, many of whom still hold Pandian responsible for the party's defeat. While switching to the BJP, senior leader Debashish Samantaray had said: "V K Pandian is solely responsible for the BJD's defeat in the 2024 polls and he single-handedly managed to stop the BJD's winning spree."

Don't recognise rebel group, Sena (UBT) MPs urge LS Speaker

Express News Service
New Delhi, June 24

MEMBERS OF Parliament of Shiv Sena (UBT) met Lok Sabha Speaker Om Birla on Wednesday and urged him not to accord separate recognition or seating to the six rebel MPs who have crossed over to Maharashtra Deputy CM Eknath Shinde-led Shiv Sena, contending that such a move would be contrary to constitutional provisions.

After meeting Birla, Shiv Sena (UBT) leaders Arvind Sawant and Anil Desai told the media that the party had submitted an application to the Speaker on June 18 seeking a hearing before any decision was taken on representations made by the rebel MPs. "We had said that in case any of our MPs, individually or after forming a group, approach you saying they want to merge with another group, you should act according to constitutional provisions," Sawant told reporters.

Referring to Wednesday's meeting, Sawant said the delegation asked the Speaker whether he had received any letter or representation from the six MPs.

"He said he had not received any documents," Sawant said, adding that the party has urged the Speaker not to allow the MPs to form a separate group or be allotted separate seating in Parliament.

BOTH TMC FACTIONS ACCUSE GOVT OF UNDERMINING THE STATE'S 'FOOD CULTURE'

Eggs off Bengal mid-day meals: Suvendu draws ire for veg fare

Educators raise concerns over kids' nutrition; ISKCON, BJP defend scheme

Sweety Kumari
Kolkata, June 24

THE OVERHAUL of the mid-day meal scheme in West Bengal, announced by Finance Minister Swapan Dasgupta while presenting the Suvendu Adhikari-led BJP government's first Budget in the Assembly Monday, has triggered a storm, with the Opposition accusing the government of imposing vegetarianism on school students over its proposal to partner with ISKCON to provide cooked meals under a pilot project that would drop eggs from the menu.

The government has however significantly increased the material allocation per student under the mid-day meal scheme, proposing to roll out the ISKCON-cooked vegetarian meals in schools across the Kolkata Municipal Corporation area. While the BJP has defended the move as a "nutritional and hygiene-focused reform", the decision has drawn criticism from both factions of the Opposition Trinamool Con-

gress as well as sections of school authorities and teachers, who argue that eggs are a rich source of protein and nutrition for students and are both "culturally familiar" and an important incentive for student attendance.

Under the new mid-day meal policy, the material cost of such meals in primary schools has been increased to Rs 10 per student from Rs 6.78. Its implementation is expected to take one or two months in Kolkata as the ISKCON has to set up kitchens and logistics infrastructure in the city.

Govt defends move

Defending the decision in the Assembly, CM Adhikari sought to allay concerns over the involvement of the religious organisation in the execution of the mid-day meal scheme. "We are giving the responsibility of cooking mid-day meals to ISKCON. If you have an objection, do not say 'Hare Krishna' - no one will force you. You will get good food to eat. You will get pure food, nothing to worry about," the CM said.

School Education Minister Dipak Burman also defended the removal of eggs from the menu, arguing that vegetarian diets can adequately meet children's nutritional requirements.



CM Suvendu Adhikari at the state secretariat, Wednesday. PTI

Opposition's attack

The move has sparked strong reactions from the Opposition. The rebel TMC leader and Leader of the Opposition (LoP) in the Assembly, Ritabrata Banerjee, said, "It is five thousand years of tradition that Bengali children used to have animal protein. If ISKCON will stop non-vegetable items in mid-day meals, that not only stop eggs but also exclude masoor dal from menu, that is not desirable in Bengali culture and tradition."

TMC Rajya Sabha MP Derek O'Brien criticised the decision on social media, linking it to a broader ideological agenda.

In the run-up to the recent Bengal Assembly polls, the then incumbent Mamata Banerjee-led TMC had kept its guns trained on the BJP over matters related to Bengalis' food and cultural identity, alleging that the

BJP, if voted to power, would ban fish and turn Bengal into a vegetarian state. The BJP had rejected these charges. In their response, several BJP leaders were also seen eating fish or canvass with fish in their hands in a bid to reject the TMC's claims.

ISKCON's response

Speaking to *The Indian Express*, ISKCON vice-president Radharaman Das said the organisation currently serves mid-day meals to around 12 lakh students in more than 20 cities across eight states. "For the last 20-22 years across India, we have been doing mid-day meals. A lot of people appreciate the ISKCON meals," he said.

Rejecting suggestions that a vegetarian menu would compromise nutrition of school children, Das said the menu for the schools has yet to be finalised with the help of dietitians keeping local tastes in mind, "Chaitanya Mahaprabhu is a Bengali; we follow Gaudiya culture. We serve a Bengali thali globally, so it is wrong to say that only egg or meat completes a Bengali thali. The menu will have rice, dal, khichdi and sabji. It is wrong to think that protein is missing from the thali. There are a lot of things that have high protein like soya chunks and rajma," he said.

Enough grounds for FIR in Ram Temple donation case: VHP

Lalmani Verma
Lucknow, June 24

A DAY after the Special Investigation Team (SIT) submitted the preliminary report on the alleged misappropriation of funds and valuables donated at the Ram Temple in Ayodhya, the Vishva Hindu Parishad (VHP) on Wednesday demanded an FIR and a day-to-day hearing of the case.

Following the controversy over alleged misappropriation of donations, the VHP has also postponed its annual management committee meeting scheduled to start in Ayodhya on Wednesday due to "inevitable circumstances". All the top functionaries of the VHP participate in the meeting where key organisational decisions are taken.

Speaking to *The Indian Express*, VHP international president Alok Kumar said, "Based on the news that appeared in the media about extracts from the SIT report, it can be said that there are enough grounds to file an FIR in the matter."

Kumar said that extracts of the SIT report that appeared in the media say that in the CCTV camera footage, some people can be seen embezzling money and their names, too, have surfaced. "So, no further fact-finding is required for lodging an

Based on the news about extracts from the SIT report, it can be said that there are enough grounds to file an FIR in the matter"

ALOK KUMAR,
INTERNATIONAL PRESIDENT,
VISHVA HINDU PARISHAD.

FIR. An FIR should be lodged earlier, investigation should be expedited and a chargesheet filed, and the case should be heard on a day-to-day basis in a fast-track court," he said.

"Whoever has done this (embezzlement) should be punished. Ram bhakts will not get peace until the culprits are sent behind bars. We want maximum punishment for them," Kumar said.

Sources said the SIT report contains a summary of the findings and recommendations made by the SIT. According to sources, the report is believed to highlight alleged lapses, inadequate supervision, and negligence in the maintenance, handling, and counting of donation money and valuables. The UP government said the SIT will continue the probe and submit the complete report after 15 days.

For invoking deities, Kerala HC voids 20 BJP councillors' oath

Asks them to be sworn in again, says 'expansion of the term God' not permissible

Shaju Philip
Thiruvananthapuram, June 24

THE KERALA High Court Wednesday declared invalid the oath taken by 20 BJP councillors of the Thiruvananthapuram Municipal Corporation who took oath in the names of various deities, directing them to be sworn in again within four weeks.

A Bench of Justice P V Kunhikrishnan held that the "statute prescribes a particular manner in which an oath is to be taken by the elected members in a democracy, i.e., either in the name of God or a solemn affirmation, the expansion of 'God' is not permissible."

The court said Section 152 of the Kerala Panchayat Raj Act and Section 143 of the Kerala Municipality Act, read with the respective Schedules, provide that elected members must take the oath either in the name of God or by solemn affirmation, without any expansion. The term "God" is not defined in either Act. The situation is similar under Article 188 read with the Third Schedule of the Constitution, where the oath is also to be taken either in the name of God or by solemn affirmation.

The court was hearing a petition filed by LDF councillor S P Deepak, who pointed out that the BJP councillors had taken the oath in the names of various deities such as Gurudev, Udayanoor Devi, Kavilamma and Sree Padmanabha, and in the name of martyrs. The petitioner sought to have the oath declared invalid.

While declaring the oath invalid, the court said the councillors' election cannot be set aside on that ground.

"The mandate of the people is supreme in a democracy. They can be given an opportunity to take an oath in accordance with." The court said that while the councillors' acts so far are protected, they are not entitled to perform any functions as members of the council until they take a fresh oath or affirmation in accordance with the law.

The court said taking an oath by an elected representative in a democracy means promising the electorate that he will be honest, follow the Constitution and the rule of law, and serve the people with sincerity. Therefore, the oath should be taken in the manner prescribed by the relevant statute and rules.

The court also declared as invalid the oath taken by Congress member of Vadakkancherry village panchayat in Palakkad district who had taken the oath in the name of Kerala's late former chief minister Oommen Chandy.

The court allowed that member also four weeks time to take the oath again.



Police use water cannons to disperse SFI protesters in Thiruvananthapuram on Wednesday. PTI

Amid protests, Kerala govt halts proposed alcohol tax reduction

Shaju Philip
Thiruvananthapuram, June 24

FACING PROTESTS from the ruling UDF and minority communities over the budget proposal to reduce sales tax on low-alcohol beverages, Chief Minister V D Satheesan Wednesday told the Assembly that a decision on their sale would be taken only after consultations within the ruling alliance.

Last week, Satheesan, who also holds the finance portfolio, announced a new tax regime for low-alcohol beverages, triggering protests from the Congress and its ally, the Indian Union Muslim League. Muslim clerics' bodies and prominent Christian churches have also opposed the move, fearing it would accelerate liquor addiction in Kerala. The Opposition CPI(M) alleged

corruption behind the decision. Satheesan said: "The liquor policy will be decided by the UDF. We will hold discussions among the UDF allies and if the opinion is against selling low alcohol beverages in Kerala, we will not sell that category of liquor. What is announced in the budget is only a tax proposal. On the other hand if the UDF takes a policy decision to allow low-alcohol content beverages, then the proposed tax will be in force".

Satheesan pointed out that the previous CPI(M) government had decided to allow the sale of low-alcohol beverages but could not complete the process as Assembly election schedules were announced. "Six months after the second CPI(M) government came into office, the excise department under then minister MV Govindan had initiated steps to define low-alcohol con-

tent beverages. In the liquor policy of 2022-23, the previous government had taken a decision to make such beverages available in Kerala."

He also said the first Vijayan government in 2018 had fixed the sales tax for foreign-made foreign liquor (FMFL) at 78 per cent. When the tax on IMFL was increased to 251 per cent in 2022-23, the rate for FMFL was only 115 per cent. "Was the tax rate reduced after receiving money from Johnnie Walker and Chivas Regal?" Satheesan asked, countering the CPI(M)'s allegation that he took money in return for the new policy. Under the proposal, tax on beverages with alcohol content between 0.5% and 10% by volume (v/v) has been reduced from 251% to 120%. For alcohol content above 10% and up to 20% v/v, the tax has been lowered to 175%.

2021 Mundra port drug bust: ED raids Delhi businessman

Deeptiman Tiwary
New Delhi, June 24

THE ENFORCEMENT Directorate (ED) on Wednesday conducted searches at five locations in Delhi linked to businessman Harpreet Singh Talwar and his associates as part of a money laundering probe into the 2,988-kg heroin consignment seized at Gujarat's Mundra port in 2021, officials said.

The searches, carried out by the agency under the Prevention of Money Laundering Act (PMLA), are aimed at tracing the proceeds of crime generated from what investigators have described as one of the country's biggest drug trafficking cases.

According to officials, the raids covered premises linked to Talwar, another person, Shamshudeen, and their associates. Investigators suspect proceeds from the narcotics trade were invested in nightclubs and other businesses in Delhi.

Talwar, also known as Kabir Talwar, was arrested by the National Investigation Agency (NIA) in August 2022 in connection with the case. He was recently released on bail.

Talwar has figured in previous ED actions too. In March 2021, the Directorate of Revenue Intelligence (DRI) arrested him in Mumbai in a case involving the alleged smuggling of 21.6 lakh 'Gudang Garam' cigarette sticks valued at Rs 4.75 crore. The DRI had then alleged that the cigarettes were concealed in an import consignment arriving from Dubai.

The latest money laundering

probe stems from the September 2021 seizure of 2,988.21 kg of heroin at Mundra port by the DRI. The narcotics, concealed in a consignment declared as semi-processed talc stones imported from Afghanistan via Iran, were valued at over Rs 21,000 crore in the international market.

The NIA alleged that the smuggling operation was part of an international network involving Afghan, Iranian and Pakistani nationals. The agency also alleged links between the drug trafficking syndicate and Pakistan-based terror organisations, including the banned Lashkar-e-Taiba (LeT). Earlier this year, the NIA told the Supreme Court that proceeds from the Mundra heroin consignment were routed back to the consignors and used for funding LeT's terrorist activities. The agency alleged that the narcotics were trafficked into India disguised as legitimate imports and the legal export-import channel was exploited by the conspirators.

The NIA had previously alleged that Talwar and others were part of an international drug smuggling network that imported heroin through shell companies and facilitated its movement to distribution networks across Delhi, Punjab, Haryana and Uttar Pradesh.

The agency's chargesheet has named several Afghan nationals, Indian businessmen and foreign-based conspirators, alleging that multiple consignments had been imported into India before the September 2021 shipment was intercepted at Mundra.

SC rejects plea against high fee by pvt medical institutions

Express News Service
New Delhi, June 24

DISMISSING A plea by a General category Economically Weaker Section (EWS) candidate challenging the high fees charged by private medical colleges in Rajasthan, the Supreme Court Wednesday remarked that private medical colleges will shut if forced to take students at fee on par with government colleges.

"Capitation fee is banned. But that doesn't mean you have to take it as per government college rate... Otherwise all these private institutions, their assistance to the State in the matter of medical education will become nil. They will all close down and diversify. We need doctors in this country," Justice B V Nagarathna remarked.

The two-judge bench, also comprising Justice Joymalya Bagchi, was hearing an appeal by a General category student from Rajasthan who had taken the NEET-UG 2025 exam. The plea questioned the logic of private colleges charging fees much above the EWS income limit of Rs 8 lakh per annum.

Hearing his appeal — challenging the 2025 Rajasthan High Court order rejecting his plea for concessional fee — Justice Nagarathna said: "...this one person, he cannot say that it is exorbitant in the private institution, make it on par with the government institution."

She added, "...they are self-financing institutions. As far as government colleges are concerned, the government gives the grants."

Mann digs in heels as Opp calls for boycott

Kanchan Vasdev
Chandigarh, June 24

PUNJAB CM Bhagwant Mann on Wednesday dug his heels in rejecting the allegations that the forensic report that gave him a clean chit on a controversial video was fabricated and accused the ruling BJP in Haryana of pressuring the lab owners to target him, even as the Opposition parties escalated the attack demanding his resignation and social boycott.

Mann, in a video message, claimed the Congress, BJP and the Akali Dal have formed a "sanjha morcha" (common front) to defame him on religious grounds as they failed to challenge him politically. He said for the past few days, fake videos were being released as part of a "cheap political conspiracy" and reiterated there was no resemblance between him and the person seen in the video.

"By making that video viral, I was declared guilty," he said.

As the row intensified, Opposition parties accused Mann of trying to undermine the authority of the Akal Takht, the highest temporal authority of the Sikhs and demanded that the CM be booked under the new anti-sacrilege law.

Addressing media persons in Chandigarh, Congress leaders called upon people to observe a complete social boycott of Mann. Party's state unit chief Amrinder Singh Raja Warring said that the Congress was unanimous in its demand for Mann's resignation.

The SAD appealed to Haryana CM Nayab Singh Saini to register an FIR against Mann as well as those who, it alleged, got the "fake" forensic reports with the "sole motive of refuting Sri Akal Takht Sahib and lowering its dignity". BJP, too, continued its attack on Mann over the row.

As 'Mann video' row blows up, AAP leaders rue 'self-goal'

After arrests over 'fake' forensic report, AAP insiders fear attention has moved from footage to how party dealt with it

Kanchan Vasdev
Chandigarh, June 24

AN ATTEMPT by the AAP to counter a controversy surrounding a purported video of Punjab Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann has turned into an embarrassment for the party, with several party leaders privately describing the forensic report episode as an avoidable self-goal.

Police in Gurgaon announced Tuesday the arrest of two men on a complaint by a forensic expert that two senior Punjab Police officers paid him Rs 10 lakh to "tailor" a report certifying the video clip allegedly featuring Mann as "fake".

Questions are being raised within the AAP over the strategy adopted by Mann's advisers and sections of the party leadership. "Where was the need for this forensic report, especially from a laboratory in a state ruled by the BJP? AAP already took a stand that the video was fake. If there was need, they could have sought a report from state's own laboratory," an AAP MLA said.

While police are silent on the authenticity of the video itself, AAP insiders fear that the row has shifted attention from the contents of its footage to the manner in which the ruling party has sought to rebut allegations surrounding it.



CM Bhagwant Mann issued a video message Tuesday. ANI

Mann has been under fire from the Akal Takht, the highest temporal body of Sikhs, which has alleged that the person in the video is the CM, and declared him "Guru dokhi" (anti-Guru) and "panth virodhi" (anti-Sikh) on the basis of what it purportedly shows. The CM and AAP have denied this, calling the footage manipulated.

The AAP MLA who questions the move to seek a forensic

report also pointed out that the issue didn't seem to have any traction, and did not come up during the many recent public engagements of Mann.

Another senior AAP leader said the issue was debated internally, and "it was advised that we shouldn't get into procuring any forensic report". "However, several party leaders advised there should be one. Now this has boomeranged instead of helping," the leader said.

There was also a debate within the party over whether a technical rebuttal was needed, or a categorical denial was sufficient. "We are now in another embarrassing situation. We do not know how to get out of this," another AAP leader said, adding that there would be a fall-out. "Some heads may roll in the coming days."

The AAP had claimed that

forensic reports of the video obtained by it concluded that the individual in it was not Mann, on the basis of 1,191 reference points, including facial recognition, frame extraction, height assessment, gait analysis, and examination of body posture.

With the BJP snapping at its heels and Assembly polls drawing closer, the AAP can ill-afford another confrontation with the Akal Takht. Ties between Mann and Akal Takht have been strained since the introduction of a strict anti-sacrilege law by his government, which was seen by the latter as imposition on its territory.

The Akal Takht has summoned Mann and the AAP on June 29 for an explanation on the video, and the party is yet to clarify its plans regarding it.

Former AAP spokesperson Iqbal Singh, who quit the party

two years ago, also questioned seeking of a report. "They had dismissed the video as AI-generated and most people had accepted that explanation... They could have just sat quietly."

The AAP may have acted out of apprehension about the reaction of Sikh voters, Iqbal added. "So they tried to play smart, but got caught... A hundred lies are now being told to cover one lie. The jathedar only said regarding the video that it was not AI-generated. It was Mann who went ahead and said it wasn't him in the video."

Iqbal alleged that the controversy may even be AAP supremo Arvind Kejriwal's way of "off-loading" Mann. Incidentally, even as the row brews, Kejriwal is arriving in Punjab to participate in a series of Hindu religious events being organised by the state government. Publicly, the AAP has rallied behind the CM.

5 arrested over ‘meat, booze’ on Ganga, get bail

Express News Service
Lucknow, June 24

FIVE MEN were arrested Tuesday for allegedly consuming alcohol and cooking non-vegetarian food aboard a boat on the Ganga river in Varanasi. All were granted bail the same day.

The accused have been identified as Deepak Kumar, Ajay Sahni, Arun Kumar Sahni, Anurag Nishad and Rahul Sahni, all in their 20s and residents of Varanasi, said police. They did odd jobs. The incident, however, does not appear to be recent. Police said preliminary examination suggested it had been recorded during the winter months.

A case has been registered at the Dashashwamedh police station on Monday night under BNS sections 196 (promoting enmity between different groups) and 299 (deliberate and malicious acts, intended to outrage religious feelings of any class by insulting its religion or religious beliefs).

22-yr-old stabbed in Mumbai local train after row over closing door; accused held

Manish Kumar Pathak
Mumbai, June 24

A 22-YEAR-OLD man was stabbed to death, allegedly by a co-passenger, inside the first-class compartment of a Mumbai local train on Tuesday night, following an argument over keeping the door open amid heavy rainfall, police said. The accused, identified as Roshan Suvarna (30), was arrested from Panvel on Wednesday.

The victim has been identified as Mayank Lohar, a resident of Virar who worked in a clothing showroom in Andheri East and was returning home after work when the incident took place. According to the Borivali Government Railway Police (GRP), Lohar boarded the Churchgate-Nalasopara fast local at Andheri at 10.43 pm.

According to investigators, Suvarna had finished his shift at a cargo facility near Andheri

and consumed nearly an entire bottle of rum before setting out for home.

“He was in Andheri East and initially planned to return home by cab. However, due to heavy rain and difficulty in getting a cab, he changed his plan and boarded a local train from Andheri railway station,” said a police officer who was part of the team that apprehended him at Panvel railway station.

Police said Suvarna was standing near the door of the first-class compartment when Lohar and several other commuters repeatedly asked him to shut the door as rainwater was entering the coach. An argument followed.

Suvarna claimed that Lohar hit him on the forehead, due to which his spectacles fell off, and that a few other passengers also assaulted him. Investigators are verifying this with witnesses. Fellow passengers intervened and separated the two



Victim Mayank Lohar worked at a clothing showroom

men but Suvarna remained angry, police said, adding he was carrying a knife in the bag.

“He opened the bag, took out the knife and stabbed Lohar who was standing in front of him multiple times in the chest and abdomen,” said an officer. Suvarna was angry with Lohar because he was the first to insist that the door be

closed, police said.

After stabbing Lohkar, Suvarna allegedly brandished the knife and threatened other passengers, preventing anyone from intervening, police said. As the train approached Platform No. 6 at Borivali station around 11.04 pm, he jumped off before it came to a complete halt and escaped.

Two purported video clips, reportedly recorded by fellow commuters, captured the chaos that unfolded inside the compartment after the stabbing. An 18-second clip purportedly shows the accused walking through the blood-stained compartment with a knife in his hand, while other passengers scramble to move away. Voices can be heard warning others and saying that he had killed a man.

In another 20-second clip, a passenger is seen kneeling beside Lohar, trying to revive him as other commuters look

on in shock.

Lohar was taken to the emergency medical room at Borivali station, and later shifted to Shatabdi Hospital in Kandivali, where he succumbed to his injuries.

Investigators scanned footage from more than 400 CCTV cameras at Borivali, Andheri, Mira Road and Nalasopara stations and nearby areas. Based on technical surveillance and specific inputs, police tracked down Suvarna and arrested him from Panvel on Wednesday. Police said he was planning to leave for his home in Mangaluru.

Suvarna, a resident of Mira Road East, is being questioned and further investigation is underway.

This is the second stabbing reported on the Western Railway suburban network this year. In January, a college lecturer was stabbed during an altercation at Malad station.

• BRIEFLY



Vehicles stuck in debris after a landslide and flash floods near the NEEPCO project colony, Keyi Panyor district, on Wednesday. PTI

ARUNACHAL PRADESH

Heavy rain triggers landslides and flash floods; 1 dead, 4 still missing

INCESSANT RAIN triggered flash floods in Arunachal Pradesh's Keyi Panyor district Wednesday, leaving one dead and four others missing, injuring 17 others and damaging at least 18 residential units, while landslides disrupted road connectivity and stranded travellers, officials said. The body of Nirmala Gupta (35), a teacher at Vivekananda Kendra Vidyalaya on NEEPCO campus in Yazali, was found during a search, Keyi Panyor DC Shweta Nagarkoti said. Search for the four missing persons is underway. A team of SDRF has been deployed, while the NDRF has been alerted and is moving towards the area to assist in relief, officers said. ENS

4 dead, 4 injured in tempo-van collision in Bihar

FOUR PERSONS, including two women and a seven-year-old child, were killed, and as many were injured in a head-on collision between a tempo and a pickup van in Bihar's East Champaran district Wednesday. “The Bettiah-bound tempo was coming from Motihari with passengers on board, while the pickup van was coming from the opposite direction. The vehicles collided head-on near Phulwaria Nayaka Tola, leading to the deaths,” Sugauli SHO Avneesh Kumar said. Further probe is underway to ascertain the cause of the accident. PTI

UP man shoots son dead, injures daughter-in-law

A 70-YEAR-OLD man allegedly shot his son dead and critically injured his daughter-in-law after a dispute over farming and family issues, in Uttar Pradesh's Fatehpur district Wednesday, police said. In Sitapur village, accused Ram Khilawan Verma allegedly opened fire at his son Avnish Verma (36) and daughter-in-law Manisha (26) using his licensed double-barrel gun, police said, adding that Ram is yet to be arrested. The body has been sent for post-mortem, and further legal proceedings are underway. PTI

Tarun Tejpal acquittal: Goa govt flags ‘embarrassing questions’ to victim, calls it ‘perverse findings’

Pavneet Singh Chadha
Panaji, June 24

CHALLENGING THE acquittal of Tarun Tejpal, the former editor-in-chief of *Tehelka* who was accused of sexually assaulting his then colleague in a Goa hotel in 2013, the Goa government on Wednesday argued before the High Court of Bombay at Goa that it was a “classic case of perverse findings”.

Solicitor General Tushar Mehta, appearing for the state government, told the HC that “embarrassing” questions put to the complainant during her cross-examination, concerning whether it is immoral to have consensual sex or consume alcohol or smoke cigarettes voluntarily or whether she had conversations containing “sexual overtones” with friends, should not have been asked or taken into consideration by the trial court. “This is the learned Judge, recording findings... with regard to the girl who has remained consistent through her testimony. This is what perversity looks like. This is the classic case of perverse findings,” he said.

The woman journalist had complained that Tejpal sexually assaulted her in the hotel elevator on November 7, 2013, and November 8, 2013. In 2021, a sessions court in Goa acquitted Tejpal of all charges, observing that the complainant “did not demonstrate any kind of normative behaviour” that a victim of sexual assault “might plausibly show”. Ruling that there was no medical evidence, it said the woman's messages to the accused clearly establish that she was neither “traumatised nor terrified” and this “com-



Former *Tehelka* editor-in-chief Tarun Tejpal is accused of sexually assaulting his then colleague at a Goa hotel in 2013

pletely belies” the prosecution's case. The Goa government had subsequently filed an appeal in the HC of Bombay at Goa challenging the acquittal, and arguments in the case are ongoing.

In its judgment in 2021, the trial court had cited the woman's relationships in the past, her views on consensual sex, drinking, smoking, her “cheerful and happy and far from traumatised or upset” appearance in photographs taken after the alleged assault, her visit to the hotel suite of an actor she was chaperoning “at an unnaturally late hour”, “flirtatious and sexual conversations” with friends over WhatsApp to come to the conclusion that she “cannot be called a trustworthy or reliable witness”. Mehta told the HC that the prosecution had insisted on not putting such questions to the prosecutrix and she was not on trial, but the trial court stayed silent.

“These are all embarrassing questions. We are not supposed to embarrass rape victims or molestation victims. Therefore, the Supreme Court has said that the trial court, while recording

evidence, is not a post office. The court is not supposed to sit there as a mere court. They will have to participate and stop wherever something contrary to the statute is there,” he said.

Citing the court's reliance on the deposition of a witness who claimed that the prosecutrix had “flirtatious and sexual conversations” with friends and acquaintances and WhatsApp chats as the proof, he said, “This is character assassination... clearly prohibited under the Indian Evidence Act. It should not have gone in the judgment, much less gone into the consideration of the court... If this is the law which is to be accepted, then we would be violating the statutory provision, where the past character of the prosecutrix is not to be questioned... This can never be a ground of defence. In the present day... the generation... they send such messages with some sexual overtones and adult content... that does not mean that she is agreeing... (or) she is consenting to having sexual intercourse or oral sex,” he said.

In its judgment in 2021, the trial court said there was no corroborative evidence supporting the allegations made by the complainant. “It is extremely revealing that the prosecutrix's account neither demonstrates any kind of normative behaviour on her own part — that a prosecutrix of sexual assault on consecutive two nights might plausibly show nor does it show any such behaviour on the part of the accused.” The court said it was “unnatural” on part of the woman to message Tejpal about her location where she was chaperoning a prominent US actor.

EXPRESS special

Families met in February, engaged in a week: The hasty Ketan-Siya wedding plan

Sushant Kulkarni
Pune, June 24

KETAN AGARWAL'S family had emphatically denied that his fiancée, Siya Goyal, could have anything to do with his shocking death at Lohagad Fort, saying “she is our own”, but police went ahead with their routine inquiry and ended up uncovering a chilling murder plot.

A police officer part of the investigation said 25-year-old Ketan's family was asked if they suspected any foul play in his death at Lohagad Fort near Pune on June 18. The family defended 20-year-old Siya and told the cops that they did not want unwanted controversies. “But as a procedure, some basic inquiry to piece together the sequence had to be done,” said the officer. And as the inquiry progressed, police found clues clearly pointing to how Siya and her boyfriend, Chetan Choudhary, allegedly plotted and executed Ketan's murder. The cops also found that the families of Ketan and Siya fixed their wedding in February, and they were engaged just a week after the families met.

On June 21, three days after Ketan died after falling off the fort and 350 metres into a gorge, a team from Lonavala Rural police station visited the fort. The cops checked footage from the CCTV cameras and spotted a man in a hoodie close behind Ketan and Siya. In the footage, Siya is seen giving what appeared to be a signal to the man in the hoodie, and the latter responds.

“While checking the CCTV footage, we saw a man moving close to Ketan and Siya; he looked suspicious. On a hot day, he was wearing a hoodie to hide his face... The focus of our CCTV analysis was just Ketan and Siya till then, but we also started checking this man in a hoodie. We found that Siya kept looking back every two to three minutes at this man in a hoodie. At one point, Siya is seen taking



Ketan Agarwal and his fiancée Siya Goyal

her hand near her face and signalling something, and the man in the hoodie responds to that signal. This strengthened our suspicion,” said an officer part of the probe.

Dumped his passport to ‘jeopardise’ Bali trip

A police officer said, “A suspicious finding was the time taken by the man in the hoodie to climb up and down the fort. He climbed up and down in 48 minutes. This suggested he was on the fort for less than 10 minutes, considering 25-odd minutes taken to climb up and 15 minutes to come down. Who goes to a historic hill fort to stay at the top for just 8-10 minutes?”

In her initial statements to the police, Siya had said Ketan slipped and fell off the cliff when they were taking photos. But later, when we spoke to her at length, she said that she was tired after they climbed the fort. She said she sat down to rest and asked Ketan for a bottle of water. And while handing her a bottle, Ketan lost his balance and slipped. This shift in statement was another big inconsistency. The suspicion on this front was confirmed after the police found not a single photo taken at the fort on Ketan's phone that day. The spot where Siya said they stopped for rest has almost no space to sit, and is secluded from other, better accessible rest spots. The spot is not easily visible. This seemed premeditated. By cross-referencing Siya's calls to Chetan, we confirmed that he was the man

in the hoodie,” the officer said.

Chetan had a plan to hoodwink the cops, the police officer said. He had kept his phones at home and brought the phone of a staffer working in his family's grocery business, they said. “This confirmed that it was a conspiracy,” the officer added.

Earlier, police detailed how Siya allegedly sabotaged a trip to Bali, where she and Ketan were to have a pre-wedding photoshoot. Police have said she hid Ketan's passport and they had to return from Mumbai after he could not find his passport at the airport. Siya took Ketan to Lohagad twice before June 18, but the murder plan could not be executed on both occasions, police have found. Ketan was the son of real estate businessman Vishal Agarwal and a director in the family-run firm. And Siya is a commerce student who recently started a bakery business. She was in a relationship with Chetan, who is pursuing a BBA course in Pune. While Siya's family is in the business of spices and dry fruits, Chetan's family has a grocery business.

Siya and Chetan, police have found, have been in a relationship since October last year.

In February this year, Ketan's family travelled to Karnataka for a wedding. It was at this wedding that he and his family met Siya and her family, who too were attending the wedding. On February 12 and 13, police found, families of Siya and Ketan discussed their match. On February 19, the two were engaged at a hotel in Pune.

Air India plane strays into Pakistan airspace

Press Trust of India
New Delhi, June 24

AN AIR India plane operating a flight from the national capital strayed into the Pakistan airspace on Monday night while manoeuvring a go-around at

the Amritsar airport.

Aviation regulator DGCA on Wednesday said interim action has been taken against the air traffic controller in Amritsar and also the airline's operating crew for non-reporting of the event. In a statement, the airline said the

incident has been reported to the regulatory authorities and is being investigated internally.

DGCA did not specify the actions taken against the air traffic controller and the crew. Details about the passengers onboard could not be ascertained.

‘6 Indian publishers contacted me’: Joe Sacco on his 2013 Muzaffarnagar riots graphic novel

Aishwarya Khosla
New Delhi, June 24

PENGUIN RANDOM House India has pulled out of plans to distribute Joe Sacco's *The Once and Future Riot*, his graphic novel reportage of the 2013 Muzaffarnagar riots, but the acclaimed cartoonist-journalist says that at least six Indian publishers have approached him about bringing the book out.

Sacco, who is credited with pioneering war reportage in comics form, has used the form to report on Palestine and the Bosnian War, and his work has been translated into 14 languages. “About six Indian publishers have approached me about publishing the book in India,” Sacco told *The Indian Express*. “so I also have the impression that India still contains people who want to preserve the Indian experiment



Cartoonist-journalist Joe Sacco says Penguin India asked him to change quotes from people he had interviewed for the book

and who will push back against the forces that seek to hinder political self-examination.”

The Once and Future Riot, published in 2025, is a 135-page illustrated account of the 2013 Muzaffarnagar communal riots in western Uttar Pradesh, which left over 60 dead and 40,000 displaced. It was expected to

reach Indian shelves by August-September. However, Gaurav Shrinagesh, CEO of Penguin Random House India, told *The Indian Express* earlier this month that the title had been red-flagged during pre-check and legal scrutiny, including an inaccurate map of India's borders and unanswered requests for citations. “We are very clear about this: if we know there is an inaccurate map and no changes are forthcoming, we will not do it,” he said.

“The citations never came through because I sent none in,” Sacco said. “My book was thoroughly fact-checked by my editors at my North American publisher, Metropolitan Books,” he said, adding that Penguin Random House India's actual list of “required” changes went well beyond the map. “Some of these requirements were for me to change quotes from people I had

interviewed, including a public figure, so as to mute their rhetoric. I do not change quotes.” “I was also asked to move a caption down the page and, most importantly, to remove my conclusion that Hindu nationalism is “firing on all cylinders,” he said, adding that he felt that his book was “balanced and fair.”

The litany of changes and concerns from Penguin Random House India ultimately led Sacco to conclude that it did not want to distribute the book, and so he told his agents that he would “not comply with the onerous verifications and requirements, and that's where I left it.” The requirements, he says, included Penguin Random House India asking for “consent forms” for use of quotes and “likenesses to be verified,” which was another pain point.

FULL REPORT ON
WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

Hina Rohtaki
Chandigarh, June 24

AN AUCTION house in Paris withdrew heritage furniture linked to Chandigarh, scheduled to go under hammer on June 25, following diplomatic intervention by the Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) after the Union Territory Administration raised the issue and registered two FIRs over the suspected theft and illegal export of the two Pierre Jeanneret-designed armchairs, officials on Wednesday said.

It is the first time that the UT Administration has managed to stall the overseas sale of the furniture that is part of its cultural and architectural heritage.

Auctioneer François Epin had listed the two teak-and-cane armchairs for auction with estimated values of €5,000-€7,000 and €4,000-€5,000, respectively. They bear inventory mark-



The two chairs that were to go under the hammer. EXPRESS



ings that connect them to public institutions in Chandigarh. One armchair carries the marking “PU Chem/55”, indicating its association with Panjab University's Chemistry Department, while the other one bears the marking “PGI/W/CH-0202”, linking it to PGIMER, Chandigarh.

Acting on the directions of Administrator Gulab Chand Kataria, the UT Culture Department under the supervision of

architectural history is a matter of national and international significance. According to officials, the MEA informed the UT Administration that the items had been withdrawn from the auction following efforts by the Embassy of India in France.

Earlier, Director (Culture) Avikesh Gupta, and Director (Museum) Isha Kamboj held a meeting late on Tuesday wrote to the SSP demanding registration of an FIR over the alleged theft of heritage furniture and initiation of the recovery proceedings. In the letter, a copy of which is with *The Indian Express*, Gupta referred to a communication from the Secretary, Government of India, Ministry of Culture, stating that an Office Order issued by the MHA on February 22, 2011, directed prevention of loss of valuable heritage items being auctioned in international markets.

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If there are questions of current or contemporary relevance that you would like explained, please write to explained@indianexpress.com

• DIPLOMACY

After Op Sindoor freeze, a thaw in India-Turkey ties

Divyva A
New Delhi, June 24

INDIA AND Turkey’s bilateral ties have often been overshadowed by one external factor: Pakistan. Last year, the relationship hit rock-bottom when following the Pahalgam terrorist attack in April, Turkey was Islamabad’s only ally in West Asia to explicitly condemn Operation Sindoor, India’s military response in May 2025. It was no surprise that ties went into cold storage for much of 2025. This year, however, both countries are showing signs of a rapprochement. In April, foreign office consultations resumed after being kept in abeyance for four years. The same month, the two sides also cooperated on the security front, with New Delhi extraditing fugitive narcotics trafficker Salim Dola from Turkey — with more to come.

Strategic mistrust

After Recep Tayyip Erdogan came to power in Turkey in 2002, bilateral relations saw frequent high-level visits, exchange of business and cultural delegations, and people-to-people interactions. Bilateral trade grew from \$700 million in 2002 to \$13.82 billion in 2022. Bilateral ties began to plummet, however, after Erdogan criticised the 2019 revocation of Article 370 at the UN. The years until late 2025 saw a massive diplomatic rift driven by the Kashmir issue and Ankara’s supply of military hardware to Pakistan, which heightened mistrust in New Delhi.

Post-Sindoor fallout

The friction, however, reached its peak during Operation Sindoor, which Turkey labelled as “unprovoked aggression” killing “innocent civilians”. Reports of Pakistan utilising Turkish-supplied drones during the four-day conflict prompted severe diplomatic and economic

backlash in India. Meanwhile, New Delhi moved to deepen its engagement with Cyprus, the Mediterranean island nation which both Turkey and Greece claim. Prime Minister Narendra Modi’s first international visit following Sindoor was to Cyprus’s capital, Nicosia.

Air India cancelled its multibillion dollar aircraft maintenance contract with a Turkish firm, while major Indian universities

STRATEGIC GATEWAY

- A working relationship with Turkey offers India geopolitical leverage in the Islamic world, a gateway to European and Central Asian markets, and trade and infrastructure partnerships.
- Ankara imports \$6 billion in goods, mostly raw materials and intermediate products including textiles, chemicals, and auto and machinery components.

suspended memorandums of understanding with Turkish institutions. Bilateral merchandise trade shrank, and Indian tourist arrivals in Turkey dropped by nearly 37%. India also revoked the security clearance of a Turkish company that handled operations at nine airports.

The thaw

In April, India invited Turkey for the 12th round of bilateral consultations. This came four years after foreign office consultations were held in Turkey. “We believe dialogue is better than not talking and deepening disagreements and misunderstandings. The conversations have been satisfactory,” India’s Ambassador to Turkey Muktesh Pardeshi told *The Indian Express*. Ankara has also shown willingness to cooperate on law enforcement, as in Dola’s extradition.

A win-win for both

Those in the know said that after the backlash, Turkey began to insulate its economic interests in Asia from its Pakistan alliance. Turkey stands to gain substantially with India — a bilateral trade exceeding \$10 billion annually, potential infrastructure expertise and a strategic hedge in its foreign policy. India is a major market for Turkish exports such as marble, machinery and agri products, while Turkey benefits from Indian machinery, auto components and chemicals, besides tourism and capital.

Sources said Turkey also cleared the air on military support to Pakistan, maintaining that it did not send any additional assistance, but as part of the long-standing defence ties between the two countries.

A senior diplomat told *The Indian Express*: “If we accept that Turkey has brotherly relations with Pakistan and that perhaps can’t be changed, we can still see merit in having our own friendly relations with them.” Indian interlocutors said if Turkey adopts a more nuanced position on the Kashmir issue, it could help solidify relations.

• CLIMATE

In dry monsoon, a test of resilience

This season’s rainfall is predicted to be the lowest in a decade. But India may be better prepared to absorb the stress this time



AMITABH SINHA

AFTER REMAINING largely inactive for more than a week, the monsoon finally picked some strength and momentum beginning Monday. Maharashtra, for instance, received its first good rainfall of the season on Tuesday. But the monsoon’s behaviour so far in June has raised concerns that the season might be even drier than predicted.

June was supposed to be among the relatively better rainfall months. The India Meteorological Department (IMD) forecast that while rainfall over India during the entire monsoon season was likely to be 90% of the long-period average, June was expected to get at least 92% of its normal rain.

This was because it was expected to be least affected by the El Niño phenomenon in the equatorial Pacific Ocean, which has a tendency to suppress rainfall over the Indian region. But with barely a week remaining, the June rainfall deficit is more than 40% and appears unlikely to be bridged.

An IMD bulletin on Wednesday forecast low to moderate rainfall activity in the areas covered by the monsoon — which is only around half of the country’s landmass. Around this time in June, the monsoon normally covers almost the entire country.

Not El Niño yet

Though the El Niño phase of the equatorial Pacific Ocean, off the northwestern coast of South America, has been declared to have emerged, this has not been the reason for the large rainfall deficit in June so far. This is because the effects of El Niño, or the opposite La Niña phase, on the Indian monsoon comes with a lag. It usually takes more than a month for the complete effects of El Niño to become evident over the Indian region.

IMD director general Mrutyunjay Mohapatra said the El Niño phenomenon had a very small role to play in the monsoon performance in June. “El Niño emerged around the first week of June. We are now beginning to see its impact on the monsoon. It is not that there is no impact. But it is not the main reason for the rainfall deficit in June,” Mohapatra said.

He identified other reasons — low pressure systems of inadequate strength; weak monsoon currents; and the unfavourable phase of a moving wind and cloud system called Madden Julian Oscillation, or MJO.

Like El Niño, MJO is an ocean-atmosphere interaction that influences weather events across the world, though only over a short term. But while the El Niño phenomenon plays out in the Pacific Ocean, MJO is a moving system of winds and clouds. The system engulfs the entire equatorial region like a ring but moves in an eastward direction. It helps bring rain in some regions but suppresses it in others. As it keeps moving, the areas where it brings rainfall keep changing.

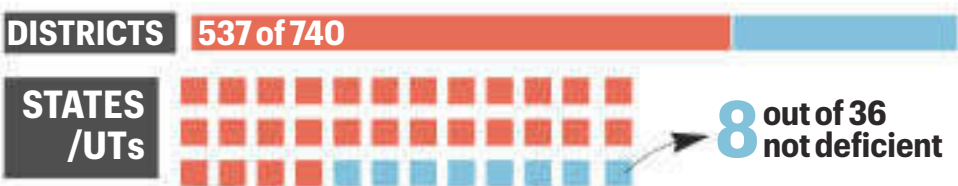
During June, the rain-bearing part of MJO was located far from the Indian region. The part of the MJO system that was around the Indian region was suppressing rainfall. But that is changing now.

“Through most of June, the MJO was in an unfavourable state for us. But it is moving and it is expected that the favourable part of MJO would be over the Indian region around the first week of July. We can expect some good rainfall around that time,” Mohapatra said.

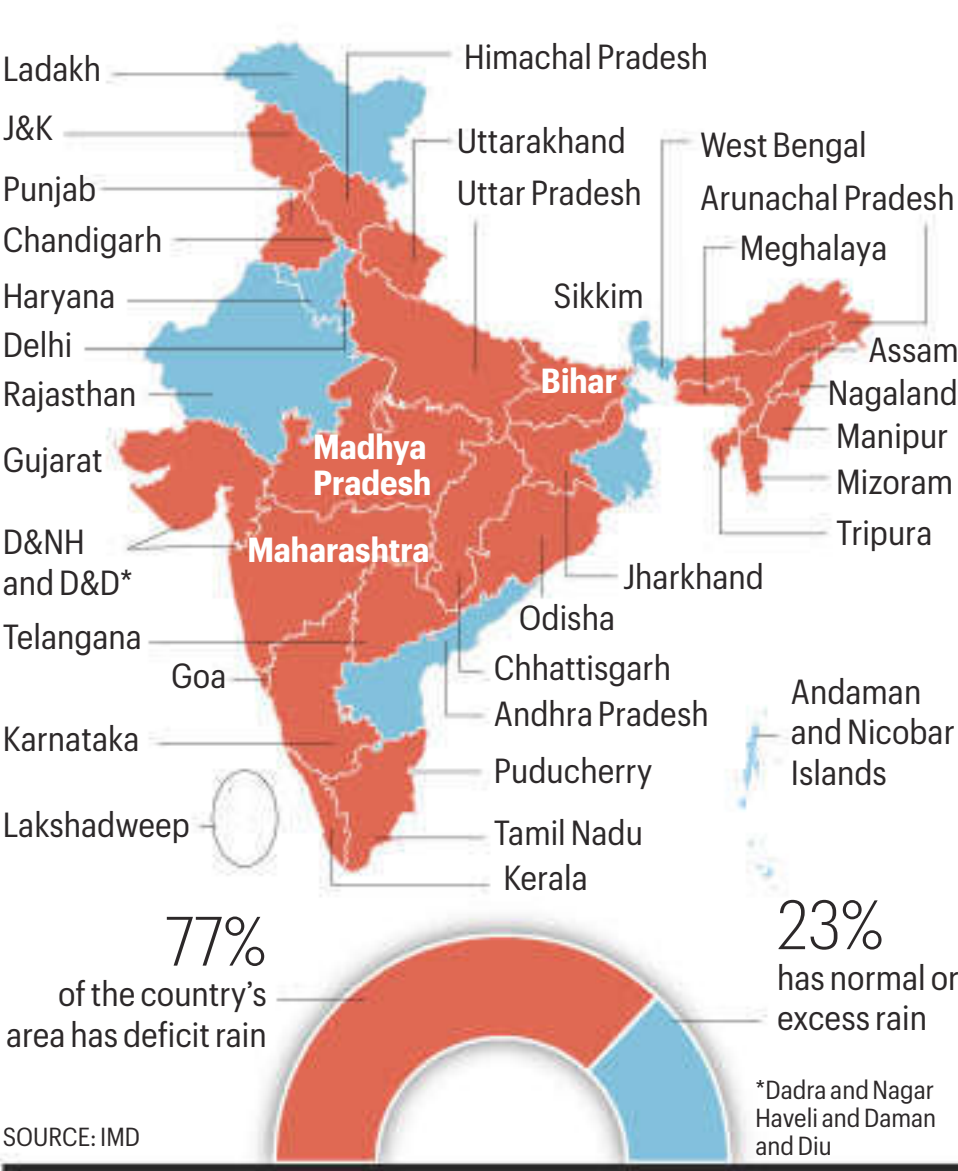
As of now, the monsoon getting active again is a big relief, but the effects of El Niño will also become progressively stronger. As

• LOOKING TO THE SKIES

Areas with more than 20% rain deficit, as on June 24:



The states/UTs with deficit rainfall



of now, almost 75% of the country’s land area has more than 20% rainfall deficiency.

Reducing monsoon dependence

Historically, India’s dependence on the monsoon rainfall has been very high. The four-month long rainy season accounts for about 75% of India’s annual rainfall.

This water is critical for irrigation, recharging groundwater, replenishing natural water bodies such as rivers and lakes, generating hydropower, and maintaining reserves in reservoirs. A bad monsoon would lower agricultural productivity, affect power generation, threaten food security, reduce farm incomes, suppress rural demand and dampen overall economic growth. The last time when India faced a particularly bad monsoon, trains had to be engaged to transport drinking water to extremely dry regions.

Over the years, however, efforts have been made to reduce India’s dependence on the monsoon. Though the land under irrigation has not changed substantially, there have been improvements on other fronts. A bulk of the work under the rural employment scheme has been aimed at developing infrastructure related to rainwater harvesting, water storage and conservation. Official reports show an improvement in groundwater situation in the last few years. The emergence of solar and wind electricity has reduced reliance on hydropower.

“We would still need to plan and intervene effectively, but our ability to absorb and deal with the stress has certainly improved. The impact of a bad monsoon should be lesser than what it used to be, let’s say, ten years ago,” said K J Ramesh, former Director General of Meteorology at IMD.

With the rainfall this season expected to be the lowest in at least a decade, India’s resilience will be tested. Thanks to the abundant rainfall in the last two years, the major reservoirs are running at relatively good storage levels. The rapid increase in renewables capacity is reducing the reliance on hydropower, and preserving storage levels in reservoirs. And there are indications that timely forecasts of a potentially bad monsoon prompted farmers to sow kharif crops amid pre-monsoon showers.

“Under climate change scenarios, it is going to get even more unpredictable. Even when we get quantitatively good rainfall, regional and local variations are huge. Developing greater resilience is the only way forward,” said M Rajeevan, former Secretary of the Ministry of Earth Sciences.

Stronger safeguards

Major reservoirs are functioning at relatively good storage levels thanks to good rain in previous years.

The emergence of solar and wind electricity has reduced the reliance on hydropower, preserving storage levels in reservoirs.

Official reports show a steady improvement in groundwater situation in the last few years.

A bulk of the work under the rural jobs scheme have been about developing water storage and conservation infrastructure.

What’s driving Europe heatwave, and why is it struggling to cope?



People cool off at a canal in Paris as France reels under a heat wave. AP



YASHEE

AROUND 50 people dead. Schools shut, public transport interrupted, air-conditioned cinema halls and museums asked to shelter the young and the elderly for free, farmers harvesting their crop at night. Western Europe is reeling under a severe heatwave, with countries from Netherlands to UK to Italy to France affected.

In France, 40 people drowned over the past week because they went swimming in unsupervised waters. The country recorded its hottest day (since record-keeping began in 1947) on Tuesday, recording a maximum temperature of 44.3 degrees Celsius. Italy and the UK have also issued extreme heat alerts.

Why is Europe so hot at present?

UK’s Met office said: “The developing heatwave is being driven by a strong area of high pressure building over continental Europe. This high pressure is promoting widespread sinking air, which suppresses cloud formation, allows for prolonged sunshine and leads to increasing temperatures through compressional heating.”

This phenomenon is also called the Omega Block or the heat dome effect.

An Omega Block, so named because it is shaped like the Greek letter Ω, is an area of high pressure between two zones of lower pressure. The heat dome also refers to an area of high pressure high above a landmass. Because of this high pressure zone, warm air rising from the ground is not able to escape into the atmosphere and is trapped close to the surface, further heating up the surroundings.

Generally, winds known as jet streams blow from the west to east over Europe, moving weather systems. This steady flow has now been disrupted, leading to the omega-shaped air flow.

This specific weather pattern aside, Europe has in general been warming up very fast, thanks to the effects of climate change. The 2025 edition of the European State of the Climate, an annual report published by the Copernicus Climate Change Service and the World Meteorological Organization, says: “Since the 1980s, Europe has been warming twice as fast as the global average, making it the fastest-warming continent. Heatwaves are becoming more frequent and severe, while extreme rainfall is leading to cata-

strophic floods. Glaciers continue to melt. Climate change is also affecting biodiversity, which is vital for a sustainable future.”

Apart from a high rate of industrialisation, urban heat islands (where highly concretised urban areas heat up faster), fracking for oil and gas, and other human activities, Europe is also suffering from something called the albedo effect, which refers to how surfaces reflect sunlight. The only area in the world heating up faster than Europe is the Arctic, where glaciers are melting rapidly. While the bright, white ice would have reflected heat back, the darker Arctic waters are absorbing it, heating up neighbouring Europe further.

But why is Europe suffering so badly from the heat?

Many parts of the world routinely see temperatures crossing 40 degrees Celsius and continue functioning normally. Why have the same temperatures proved so debilitating for Europe?

“Europe’s struggle with increasingly intense heatwaves reflects a deeper mismatch between rapidly evolving climate realities and systems designed for a different era. Much of Europe’s infrastructure, urban planning, and public health architecture developed under historically temperate climatic conditions, where resilience was built primarily around colder weather patterns. However, climate change is fundamentally altering this baseline. Heatwaves are becoming more frequent, longer, and more severe, exposing structural vulnerabilities that existing adaptation measures have not fully addressed. Urban heat retention, ageing populations, and uneven preparedness capacities across states further amplify these risks,” Zerín Osho, director of the India Program of the think tank Institute for Governance & Sustainable Development, told *The Indian Express*.

In much of western Europe, air conditioners are far from the norm. Homes are built to keep heat in, using insulated materials with high thermal mass like thick stone, brick and concrete. In winter, they absorb heat from radiators and slowly release it into the room. They do the same during a heatwave.

Then there is the fact that western Europe gets more hours of sunlight than say a place like India. This gives homes very little time to cool down at night, specially when nights are not much cooler than the day. “While Europe has strengthened heat action plans and early-warning mechanisms over recent years, current events suggest that adaptation continues to lag behind the pace at which climate risks are unfolding,” Osho said.

• POLICY

How government’s overhaul of FCRA rules puts focus on religious conversion

Deeptiman Tiwary
New Delhi, June 24

THE UNION Home Ministry has tightened the foreign funding framework for NGOs and associations under the Foreign Contribution Regulation Act (FCRA). It has issued two notifications that revise penalties and specify purpose-based, geography-linked registration while explicitly keeping foreign money out of proselytising activities.

The two new notifications

The first notification amends the Foreign Contribution (Regulation) Rules, 2011, requiring every FCRA registration to specify both the purposes for which foreign funds can be used and the states or Union Territories where such activities can be undertaken. Organisations must now select their activities from a government-prescribed Schedule of 105 permissible purposes.

Existing FCRA-registered associations have been given one year to indicate the purposes and geographical areas they wish to re-

tain in their registration. Any subsequent expansion in scope will require fresh approval.

The notification also broadens the definition of “key functionary”, restricts organisations with foreign nationals in key management positions from ordinarily receiving registration or prior permission, introduces a minimum utilisation requirement for renewal and cancellation decisions, tightens conditions for release of subsequent instalments of foreign funds, and mandates more extensive disclosures in annual returns, including activity reports, social media account details and information on ultimate donors.

The second notification revises compounding penalties for violations such as excess administrative spending, speculative investments, diversion of foreign funds and use of foreign contributions outside approved purposes or areas. It raises the cost of non-compliance while providing organisations with a structured mechanism to settle violations through compounding instead of facing full criminal prosecution.

Change from 2011 Rules

The changes mark a shift from a relatively broad, programme-based framework to a far more prescriptive regulatory regime. Under the 2011 Rules, organisations broadly identified themselves as undertaking religious, cultural, educational, economic or social activities and described their programmes. The new Rules require them to choose from a government-notified list of approved activities, with registrations tied to those specific purposes.

A second major change is geographical restriction. While organisations earlier disclosed their areas of operation, registration itself was not linked to specific states or Union Territories. The new framework makes geography part of the licence.

The 2011 Rules referred mostly to “Members of the Executive Committee or Governing Council” and “Chief Functionary”, without defining “key functionary” which have now been specified as directors of companies, partners in firms, trustees of trusts, the *karta* of a Hindu Undivided

Family, office bearers and members of governing bodies, and “any other officer or person... who has control over, or responsibility for the management” of the association.

The Rules also explicitly exclude “proselytisation” from permitted religious activities, define “key functionary” more broadly, place new restrictions on organisations with foreign nationals in leadership positions, introduce a minimum utilisation threshold for foreign funds, and tighten scrutiny of organisations receiving funds through prior permission.

The changes significantly increase government oversight over how and where foreign contributions can be used.

Focus on proselytisation

One of the most notable features of the new Schedule is the repeated use of the phrase “excluding proselytisation” in relation to religious activities. While the 2011 Rules recognised a range of religious activities, they did not expressly refer to proselytisation. The new framework allows faith-

based activities such as religious education, theological study, preservation of religious traditions and religious gatherings, but explicitly excludes conversion-oriented work.

The Constitutional backdrop is significant. Article 25 guarantees the right to profess, practise and propagate religion, but the Supreme Court in *Rev. Stainislaus vs State of Madhya Pradesh* (1977) held that the right to propagate religion does not include a right to convert another person.

By expressly excluding proselytisation, the Centre is signalling that foreign contributions can support religious activities but not conversion-oriented work. The move is in line with the long-standing concern within the Sangh Parivar that foreign-funded organisations are involved in religious conversion.

Since coming to power, the Narendra Modi government has faced allegations of targeting Christian organisations under the FCRA regime over suspicions of conversion. Several Christian institutions, including Missionaries of Charity and Church of North India-linked entities, have faced

FCRA action. The government has maintained that these actions were based on specific violations of FCRA provisions.

The penalty framework

The second notification, under Section 41(1) of the FCRA, revises compounding penalties for several violations relating to the receipt and utilisation of foreign contributions. Among the key changes:

- Spending foreign contribution beyond the 20% cap on administrative expenses will attract a penalty of Rs 1 lakh or 5% of the excess expenditure, whichever is higher.
- Utilising it in speculative activities will attract a penalty of Rs 1 lakh or 30% of the amount invested, whichever is higher.
- Using it for purposes other than those for which it was received will attract a penalty of Rs 1 lakh or 30% of the amount involved, whichever is higher.
- Accepting or utilising foreign contribution for purposes or in states and Union Territories not covered by registration will invite similar penalties.



Five decades after Emergency, difficult questions, unheeded warnings



COOMMI KAPOOR

IT'S A question I am often asked and my reply pleases neither side of the political spectrum in these polarised times. Having witnessed firsthand Indira Gandhi's 1975 Emergency, I am frequently quizzed whether the situation in the country is really better 50 years down the line. If I suggest that today's restrictions on the media are not as draconian as the ones between 1975 and 1977, those left aghast by the creeping authoritarianism of Narendra Modi's rule view me as someone who has sold out to the government. But can sledgehammer legislation that upheld prior censorship, putting dissidents behind bars indefinitely without even the farce of a trial, temporarily suspending the sacred constitutional right of *habeas corpus*, etc. be better than whatever is happening in the country today? The government's cheerleaders are equally unhappy with my response. The Emergency may have been worse, but are we insidiously and slowly heading in the very same direction?

India today is not a shining example of the democracy that the framers of our Constitution envisaged. Recently, the Delhi High Court pulled up the Delhi Police's Economic Offences Wing for high-handedly shutting down the portal *News-Click* six years ago, arresting the editor and invoking anti-terror laws against him. Television channels devote far too much time to propagating government narratives through BJP spokespersons or fellow travellers, even if this is couched as debate. This format generates more sound than light. Journalists would be better employed following their true calling — investigating and reporting the news on the ground. Media correspondents increasingly resort to self-censorship and soft-peddle uncomfortable truths for fear of offending people in power and being cut off from news sources essential for their livelihoods. US President Donald Trump last

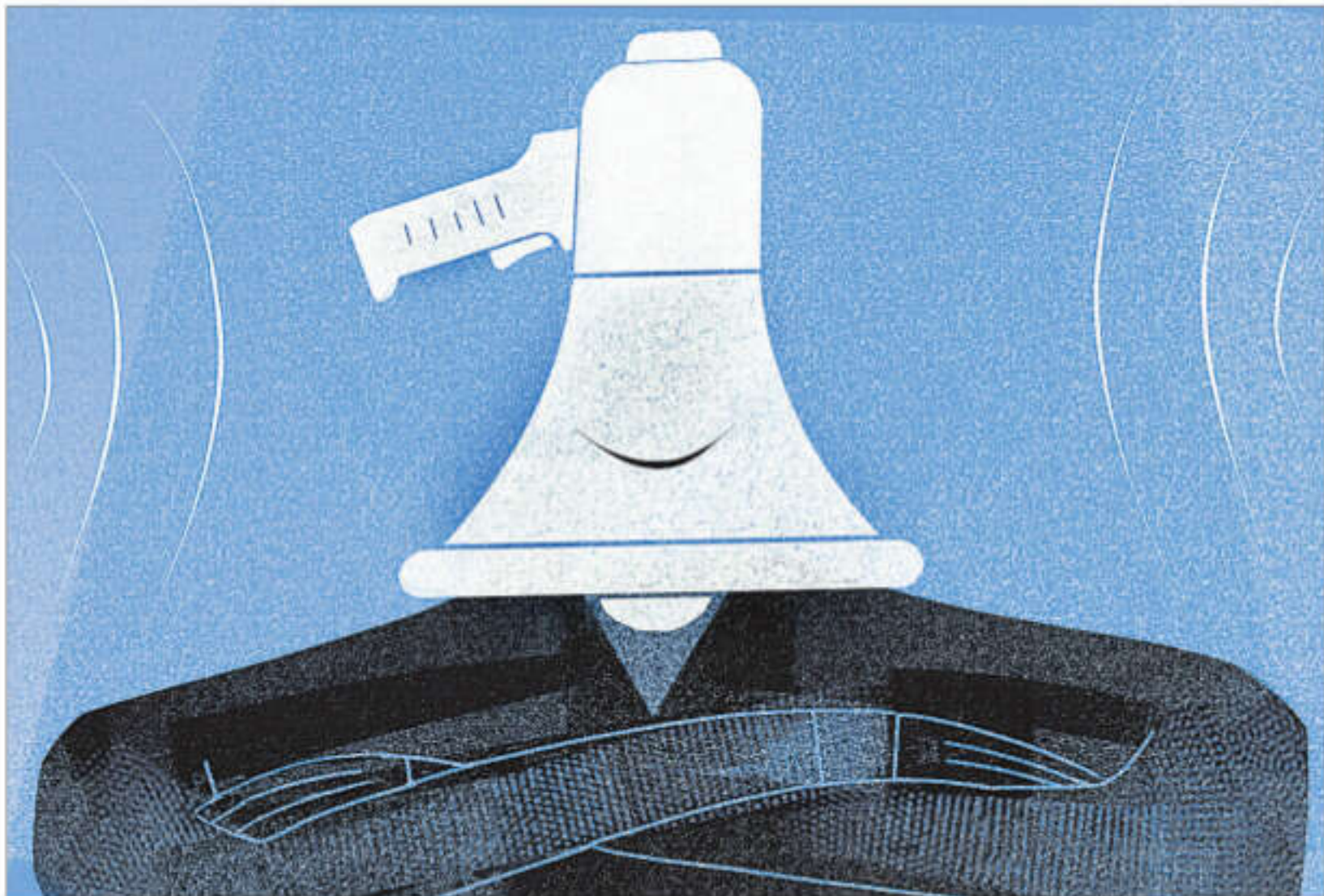


ILLUSTRATION: C R SASIKUMAR

week unwittingly affirmed the suspicion that Indian journalists nowadays shy away from asking uncomfortable questions, remarking approvingly to Prime Minister Modi at a joint press conference in France, "Your reporters are much nicer than mine."

Today's nomenclature for yesteryear's censor is media adviser, embedded in the party or the government. They are usually professional communication experts who have little connect with the John Stuart Mill school of a free marketplace of ideas. Callow media consultants strive simply to choreograph a narrative as if media management is a marketing ad or a public-relations exercise. Unnecessarily toxic trolling of contrary viewpoints on social media and the harassment of media dissenters and political opponents by utilising government investigative agencies are today's tools of censorship. The justification for violating citizens' rights is the all-encompassing "national security"

In a country as diverse as India, with a culture of outspokenness, debate and argument, truth cannot be suppressed for long, particularly in the days of social media. So why make the mistake that Indira Gandhi made 50 years back?

bogey, which has been cited to amend IT rules so that the government can even access alleged "unlawful" internet chatter.

Today's media managers need to learn a lesson in pragmatism and politeness from successful past media advisers, in party and government, such as V N Gadgil, J P Mathur, Sharada Prasad, B G Verghese, Govindacharya, Ashok Tandon, Harish Khare and Arun Jaitley. They managed better outcomes by befriending journalists through easy access, tolerance and a polite exchange of differing viewpoints,

rather than cutting off sources of information when opposing views were expressed. In a country as diverse as India, with a culture of outspokenness, debate and argument, truth cannot be suppressed for long, particularly in the days of social media. So why make the mistake that Indira Gandhi made 50 years back in assuming that opposing viewpoints can be wished away?

Increasingly, those in power believe they are not directly

answerable to the people. The government's radio silence over major mess-ups in the NEET and CBSE examinations, affecting lakhs of students, is a telling example. To respond to public complaints is perceived as a weakness by today's regime. The lack of internal debate in the ruling party, too, is perturbing. The BJP parliamentary board rarely meets and when it does, it merely rubber stamps decisions taken elsewhere. The surprise elevation of inexperienced junior party persons as chief ministers, without any prior consultations, is yet another instance of the absence of inner-party democracy. No less concerning is the falling standard of independence and probity of constitutional bodies meant to uphold democratic values. The Election Commission's blatant exclusion of over 90 lakh names from the West Bengal SIR rolls unnecessarily put a question mark over an election where the public mood was clearly against Mamata Banerjee. Recently, the way TMC and Shiv Sena (UBT) MPs have jumped ship overnight reinforces the cynical belief that most Indian politicians have a price. The crux of a true democracy is securing a majority in Parliament through an ethical recourse to the ballot box, not by winning over opposition legislators by whatever means, fair or foul, post elections. In the ongoing ruthless mission to secure a two-thirds majority, one recalls uneasily just how Indira Gandhi utilised her brute two-thirds majority to subvert our Constitution and push through Emergency rule.

As the country marks the half-century anniversary of the Emergency, many ruling party supporters wax eloquent on Indira Gandhi's Emergency excesses as a warning to future generations not to go down that discredited path and derail democracy. Ironically, many of the practices of the Emergency are actually being emulated today. Even the unnecessary sycophancy of rulers in advertisements, bill boards and at public events seems ominously reminiscent of that black period and recalls Congress President D K Barooah's fawning slogan, "Indira is India and India is Indira."

The writer is contributing editor, The Indian Express

When Bihar led the resistance to authoritarianism



SAMRAT CHOUDHARY

JUNE 25, 1975, stands as one of the darkest chapters in the history of Indian democracy. It is a date that evokes pain and concern in the minds of all those who cherish democratic values. The Emergency was not merely a political episode. It was an unprecedented assault on India's Constitution, democratic institutions, freedom of expression, and civil liberties. It reflected a dangerous mindset that was willing to sacrifice democracy to preserve political power.

The younger generation must understand that there was a period in India's history when the spirit of the Constitution was suppressed, the judiciary came under pressure, the press was censored, and political opponents were imprisoned without due process. Significantly, these actions were not imposed by an external force but by a Congress-led government.

The catalyst for this crisis occurred on June 12, 1975, when the Allahabad High Court declared the election of then-Prime Minister Indira Gandhi invalid. In a healthy democracy, the moral course of action would have been to respect the verdict and step down. Instead, Congress chose to protect power. Fundamental rights were curtailed, civil liberties suspended, and millions of citizens deprived of their freedoms. An atmosphere of fear, repression, and uncertainty engulfed the nation.

Yet, if the Emergency symbolised authoritarianism, Bihar became the strongest centre of democratic resistance. This is the land that gave the nation Loknayak Jayaprakash Narayan, one of the most respected champions of democracy. The call for "Sampoorna Kranti" (Total Revolution) that arose from Patna's Gandhi Maidan shook the very foundations of authoritarian rule. The JP Movement was not merely an agitation against a government; it was a movement for systemic reform and democratic renewal, challenging corruption, dynastic politics, appeasement, and the arrogance of power.

Thousands of students, youth, farmers, teachers, and ordinary citizens from Bihar joined the struggle to defend democratic values. Many were imprisoned and subjected to severe hardship, yet they refused to surrender their commitment to democracy. Bihar's contribution to this national movement re-

mains a matter of immense pride; without JP's leadership and the courage of the people of Bihar, the struggle against authoritarianism would not have acquired the historic strength it ultimately did.

Today, Congress often speaks about freedom of expression, but the nation has not forgotten that it was during the Emergency that press censorship was imposed on an unprecedented scale. Newspapers were required to obtain official clearance before publishing sensitive reports. Critical voices were silenced, journalists were intimidated, and media institutions faced immense pressure. Narayan, Atal Bihari Vajpayee, Lal Krishna Advani, George Fernandes, Nanaji Deshmukh, and thousands of political workers and activists were imprisoned. Their only offence was their unwavering commitment to democracy, constitutional governance, and the rights of the people. Dissent was treated as a crime.



ILLUSTRATION: TANUSHRI MITRA

The Emergency serves as a stark reminder that the excessive concentration of power weakens democratic institutions. When authority becomes confined to a few individuals, institutional checks and balances begin to erode, placing constitutional values at grave risk. Ultimately, it stands as a warning against the dangers of dynastic politics and unchecked political power.

In sharp contrast, under the leadership of Prime Minister Narendra Modi, India has entered an era of greater transparency, public participation, and inclusive development. The guiding principle of governance today is: "*Sabka Saath, Sabka Vikas, Sabka Vishwas, Sabka Prayas*." The poor, women, youth, Scheduled Castes, Scheduled Tribes, backward classes, and marginalised communities have become central stakeholders in India's development journey.

The Emergency is a lesson about the importance of safeguarding our democratic institutions. On this anniversary, I pay heartfelt tribute to all those who stood firm in defence of democracy and refused to yield before authoritarian rule. I offer my special respect to the people of Bihar, who, under the leadership of Loknayak Jayaprakash Narayan, played a historic role in safeguarding democratic values. Let us renew our commitment to protecting the Constitution, strengthening democratic institutions, and preserving the rights and freedoms of every citizen. Democracy is not merely a system of governance; it is the very soul of India, and the contribution of Bihar in defending that soul will forever remain etched in the nation's history.

The writer is Chief Minister of Bihar

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Lucknow tragedy

THE INFERNO at the Lucknow coaching centre is more than a tragedy; it is a systemic failure of governance, regulation, corruption, and civic conscience ('A recurring, preventable tragedy in Lucknow', *IE*, June 24). Fifteen young lives were lost in a death trap where narrow staircases, inadequate ventilation, and ignored fire audits exposed a lethal cocktail of negligence and complicity. Had there been a tech-driven, AI-powered compliance audit and an IoT-enabled fire-safety mechanism in place across our urban centres, the outcome might have been different. Whether in Malviya Nagar, Rajkot, or now Lucknow, unless citizens demand accountability, the troubling question remains: How long will India continue to mourn the avoidable deaths of its youth?

Abhinav Shah, Lucknow

THE LUCKNOW building fire follows a pattern seen across Indian cities — commercial establishments operating without effective fire-safety compliance ('A recurring, preventable tragedy in Lucknow', *IE*, June 24). The National Building Code exists, but enforcement remains inconsistent. Mandatory third-party fire audits, personal liability for building owners, and publicly accessible compliance records would create more effective deterrents than reactive inspections.

S M Jeeva, Chennai

Innovation race

TECHNOLOGICAL SOVEREIGNTY is not built by policy announcements alone ('Will a nation grow, stagnate, decline? Technology will tell', *IE*, June 24). It requires sustained investment in foundational research, manufacturing capability, and talent that can design and deploy technology, not merely operate it. India has the demographic base. Converting that into technological capacity demands consistency in funding, institutional autonomy, and a long-term commitment that outlasts electoral cycles.

K Sakunthala, Coimbatore



BIMAL N PATEL AND ANKIT K

INDIA'S PERMANENT membership of the UN Security Council is no longer a question of aspiration. It has become a test of whether the world can adapt to the current geopolitical flux. Since World War II, the world has fundamentally changed, overseen by an institution that largely has not. India, as the world's largest democracy, represents one-sixth of its total population. Recognising its rightful place will ensure the UNSC's credibility in addressing global challenges.

India ranks among the top three in purchasing power parity, with estimates placing its 2026 GDP PPP above \$20 trillion. It influences global trade flows, technology supply chains, energy markets, and developmental finance. India's armed forces are among the world's largest and it is among the top defence spenders, with its 2026 defence budget reaching a record \$86 billion. India is currently among the few countries with a credible nuclear triad, yet its strategic culture has remained oriented toward deterrence and stability, rather than revising the international order.

Beyond material capabilities, India's normative and functional contribution to international peace and security is noteworthy. Its troop contribution has been one of the largest since 1948 despite suffering one of the highest numbers of fatalities among UN peacekeeping contributors. This reflects India's com-

Beyond material capabilities, India's normative and functional contribution to international peace and security is noteworthy

mitment to multilateralism and its willingness to support UN mandates at all costs.

On several crucial international agendas, India is one of the major stakeholders, shaping outcomes in energy transitions, green finance, and technological innovation. Cutting across the North-South divide, India demonstrated its leadership in the International Solar Alliance and the recent G20 presidency under the theme "*vasudhaiva kutumbakam*". It is emerging as a hub in technology governance. On maritime security, its role in the Indian Ocean shows strong commitment to freedom of navigation and adherence to the UN Convention on the Law of the Sea and its institutions such as the International Tribunal for the Law of the Sea.

Equitable representation is one of the most important challenges the UNSC faces. Despite Asia accounting for 60 per cent of the world's population, only one Asian state holds a permanent seat. UNSC expansion can also address challenges that directly affect Asian countries but often receive inadequate attention, while preventing the pursuit of any single country's narrow agenda.

The G4 initiative, by India, Japan, Brazil and Germany, aims at increasing UNSC membership, with six new permanent seats, including two each for Asia and Africa.

Since permanent membership comes with veto power, restricting it to only five countries has resulted

in structural and functional challenges. In the 1960s, the UNSC expanded the number of non-permanent members to 10 without making any changes to the P5. Thus, the influence of the permanent members increased over time. The growing practice of consensus-based decision-making has given rise to de facto vetoes. Outcomes such as presidential and press statements, or the decisions of sanctions committees, require unanimity, allowing any member, permanent or elected, to block or delay action. As the Council expands, achieving consensus becomes more difficult, thereby increasing opportunities for individual states to exercise this informal veto in pursuit of narrow national interests. Equitable reform requires expanding permanent membership with veto power to ensure fair representation.

A permanent seat for India at the Council would strengthen stability in Asia and beyond. It would closely align the institution with changing geopolitical realities and establish the legitimacy of its decisions, offering the UNSC a chance to revamp itself. The India of today, envisioned as *vishwamitra*, is well positioned to address the evolving challenges of the UNSC.

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Who killed the radical artist?

holders — galleries, universities, museums, art fairs, etc. — accept neither risk nor responsibility. Without institutional solidarity, it is unfair to expect artists to be brave. Kapoor flourished at a time when the artist was driving the market. Now, dissent seems a luxury few can afford.

Remember art student Kundan Kumar Mahato, who, in 2022, was rusticated following his internal project at MSU Baroda? He questioned Indian society's treatment of women by filling silhouettes of Hindu goddesses with newspaper clippings detailing crimes against women — exactly what art is meant to do, provoke, reflect, challenge. Yet, when the university faced attacks from fringe right-wing elements, it abandoned him. Although Mahato was later allowed to resume his course by the court, his incarceration became a cautionary tale.

There are also enough incidents of both mid-career and established artists' voices being stifled. Amol Palekar's speech at the opening of Prabhakar Barwe's retrospective at NGMA, Mumbai, comes to mind. When Palekar criticised the abolition of the local artists advisory board at NGMA, he was asked by the curators and other authorities to limit his speech to the artist's practice. Ironically, Barwe was among the pioneering Indian modernists who challenged traditional teachings.

I was convinced of a systemic rupture

Global capitalism has not robbed art of its radical edge; rather, it has robbed its custodians of the courage to stand by it

about two years ago during a conversation with a prominent New Delhi-based gallerist. She explained why she chose to keep her gallery open while her peers went on a day-long strike in solidarity with Gaza, following the Israeli bombing of Rafah. "I can't do that. I also have Israeli clients," she said, adding, "Our artists are free to share their own political opinions. We will never officially amplify them."

This is the loss Kapoor was talking about, where art is perceived solely as a commercial asset. Now imagine being a provocative artist with this gallerist. You either quit or self-censor. Inevitably, artists choose to survive.

In May, Finland's Espoo Museum of Modern Art (EMMA) announced a new support model for artists. Acknowledging that artists today are working in "survival mode",

EMMA's new director, Krist Gruijthuisen, said this model would not just provide artists with financial aid beyond the customary token fee, but also reinvent the support system to encourage them to take risks. Perhaps institutions across India, and the world, can take a leaf out of EMMA's playbook.

The aim is not to dissociate art from the market, but to decouple creative purpose from survival so the market can complement thoughtful, radical, meaningful art. To rephrase Kapoor's argument: Global capitalism has not robbed art of its radical edge; rather, it has robbed its custodians of the courage to stand by it. A snub from one of the world's wealthiest artists may just be the wake-up call the art world needs.

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TEHRAN SAYS PEACE IN LEBANON IS AS IMPORTANT AS PEACE IN IRAN

Rubio defends deal on Gulf tour, Israel bent on troops in Lebanon

We're winning by a lot, Iran making big concessions: Trump

Reuters
Tel Aviv, Dubai, June 24

THE UNITED STATES' top diplomat sought backing from skeptical Gulf allies on Wednesday for President Donald Trump's deal with Iran to end their war, while in another challenge to the accord, Israel insisted it would keep troops in southern Lebanon.

The US and Iran signed an initial accord last week to end a war that has upended West Asia and pressured global economies with the closure of the Strait of Hormuz.

Under the deal, the strait is now slowly reopening and on Wednesday benchmark oil prices fell more than \$3 to their lowest level since before the war started as supply concerns eased further. But conflicting accounts have emerged over elements of the deal, which has prompted criticism of Trump at home and in the Gulf.

Financial incentives for Iran, control of the Strait of Hormuz and Israel's parallel war in Lebanon have all been disputed, highlighting the fragility of the accord. "We're winning by a lot. Iran is making very big concessions," Trump told reporters on Wednesday.

Speaking in Kuwait City, the second stopover in a tour of three Gulf nations, Secretary of State Marco Rubio said the US was "completely aligned with our partners in the Gulf".



US Secretary of State Marco Rubio with UAE's President Mohamed bin Zayed Al Nahyan at a restaurant in Al Maryah Island, Abu Dhabi, on Wednesday. @SECURIBIO

"We're not going to do anything that undermines the security of our allies, our long-standing allies in the region," he told reporters before heading to Bahrain. Rubio also reiterated the Trump administration's opposition to Iran's demand to charge tolls on shipping through the Strait of Hormuz, something also opposed by Washington's Gulf allies.

Regional Scepticism

The proposed peace deal has been met with scepticism in West Asia, where many states came under attack from Iran during the war and view the accord as too generous to Tehran, including a \$300 billion fund and the waiver of some sanctions.

Washington's Gulf allies fear the reconstruction fund could help Iran to rebuild its military,

while the accord also does not address Tehran's ballistic missile capacity.

Israel Adamant

Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu and Defence Minister Israel Katz both stressed again on Wednesday that Israel would not pull troops out of southern Lebanon, where they say they have created a security zone to protect residents of northern Israel.

"The IDF is prepared ... and we are not retreating. We announced that in any case we are not withdrawing, and as of this moment — and this is a political achievement — there is no American demand for Israel to withdraw from Lebanon," Katz said in an onstage interview at a conference in Tel Aviv.

He made his comments as Lebanon and Israel discuss a

US-backed proposal at talks in Washington for Israeli forces to pull out of some of the territory it invaded in the war and hand it to Lebanese-army control.

"For us, a ceasefire in Lebanon is as important as a ceasefire in Iran, and further, an end to the war in Lebanon is as important as an end to the war in Iran," Iran's parliament speaker Mohammad Baqer Ghalibaf said on Wednesday.

Iran Slams US

Responding to Rubio's comments in Kuwait, Iran's foreign ministry spokesperson Esmail Baghaei said on X: "We can't have a peaceful region so long as American militarism and interventionism persist, and their occupying proxy (Israel) continues, with absolute impunity, to inflict endless wars across region and perpetrate genocide..."

IAEA chief: Visits to Iran nuke sites soon; after final deal, says Tehran

Reuters
Tokyo, June 24

THE HEAD of the UN's nuclear agency signalled Wednesday that Iranian nuclear enrichment sites would be visited by his inspectors, a key component in the interim US-Iran to reach an end to the war. But an Iranian diplomat promptly rejected this, saying such a visit can only come after a final deal — a denial that highlighted the precariousness of the ongoing negotiations.

The remarks by International Atomic Energy Agency head Rafael Mariano Grossi was the firmest yet from the United Nations agency, which is viewed as key in determining the status of Iran's nuclear stockpile.

Since Israel launched a 12-day war on Iran in 2025, the IAEA has been blocked by Tehran from visiting enrichment sites where Iran is believed to store enough highly enriched uranium to potentially build as many as 10 nuclear weapons, should it choose to rush for the bomb.

Iran has long maintained that its program is peaceful, though it is the only country in the world to have uranium enriched up to 60% purity without a weapons program.

The US and Iran offered contradictory remarks Tuesday about whether those sites would be inspected.



People cool off at a fountain in Rome on Wednesday. REUTERS

Europe heatwave shatters records; dozens dead, power lines go down

Power grid fails in France, schools shut in UK, Eiffel Tower & Louvre change timings, Paris Fashion Week feels the heat

Reuters
Paris, London, Rome, June 24

WESTERN EUROPE was in the grip of a heatwave on Wednesday that claimed dozens of lives, disrupted power supplies, shut schools and cultural landmarks, as forecasters warned the extreme temperatures could persist until the end of the week.

Smashing previous records, Britain logged its highest temperature for June, reaching 36.1 degrees Celsius in southern England as a heat dome hovered over much of Western Europe.

Temperatures in Paris hit a June record of 40.9C, a day after France recorded its hottest day since records began nearly 80 years ago, when temperatures peaked at 44.3C in the southwestern town of Pissos.

Italy's health ministry placed 16 cities — including Florence, Milan, Rome, Turin and Verona

— on its highest heat alert, and warned the heatwave could intensify further, peaking between Sunday and Monday.

At least 48 people have died in France from drowning since the onset of the heatwave while trying to cool off, authorities said, and two young children were killed by heat in a car.

Spain reported two elderly people had died of heatstroke after days of temperatures exceeding 40C, though conditions there began to ease on Wednesday following the hottest late-June days on record, according to national weather agency AEMET.

France's nuclear power plants, which supply most of the country's electricity, cut output by about 7% of total demand as high temperatures limited access to cooling water.

Britain's record reading followed only the second extreme heat warning ever issued.

Hundreds of schools closed or shortened their day as officials warned that high temperatures could endanger even healthy people. The city's rail networks were affected by the heat, including delays and speed restrictions on major London Underground lines and cancellations of some commuter services.

The Eiffel Tower and the Louvre announced early closing times, and the Changing of the Guard outside Buckingham Palace was scaled back, without the usual ceremony of soldiers in scarlet tunics and heavy bearskin hats.

In Paris, where the annual Fashion Week was under way, the audience sweated through the Louis Vuitton show as male models showed off creations by pop singer Pharrell Williams on Tuesday evening. Labels including Dior and Rick Owens changed their schedules to hold shows in the morning.

Top court backs Trump in 'green cards' case, says govt has authority

Associated Press
Washington, June 24

THE SUPREME Court sided with the Trump administration Tuesday in an immigration case dealing with the government's power over green card holders accused of crimes.

The 6-3 decision centres on an immigration officers' 2012 decision to put lawful permanent resident Muk Choi Lau on immigration parole when he returned from a short trip to China because he had been accused of a counterfeiting crime.

Lau argued that the officer overstepped their authority, and the decision wrongly allowed the Department of Homeland Security under then-President Barack Obama an easier path to removal after he pleaded guilty to selling counterfeit clothes in New Jersey. The high court disagreed. "Border officers did not have the burden to establish by clear and convincing evidence that Lau had committed a crime involving moral turpitude," Justice Clarence Thomas said.

Justice Ketanji Brown Jackson dissented, writing that the decision to put Lau on immigration parole effectively sentenced him to "immigration limbo" before he'd been convicted of any crime. "I worry that the Court has now handed the Govern-

ment a massive blank check," she wrote in the dissent joined by her two liberal colleagues.

The liberal group Alliance for Justice echoed that concern, saying the ruling could provide an expanded path for revoking green cards.

But Advancing American Freedom, a group founded by former Republican Vice President Mike Pence, called it an important case to allow the removal of people who "abuse the privilege of being granted lawful permanent resident status."

The decision comes as the high court considers a series of immigration-related issues against the backdrop of President Donald Trump's sweeping immigration crackdown, though this case started before Trump took office.

His administration argued that suspicion of a crime is enough to put a lawful permanent resident, also known as a green-card holder, on immigration parole. Federal attorneys urged the court to take an expansive view of executive authority over immigration.

The court is also considering cases over Trump's push to end birthright citizenship, potentially revive a restrictive asylum policy and end temporary legal protections for migrants fleeing war in their homelands.

France reports first Ebola case: Doctor returning from Congo trip

Reuters
Paris, June 24

A DOCTOR who recently returned to France from a humanitarian mission in the Democratic Republic of Congo has tested positive for Ebola, marking the country's first confirmed case linked to the current outbreak, the health ministry said on Wednesday.

The patient has been placed in isolation and health authorities are tracing contacts, the ministry said in a statement, adding that the risk to the wider European population was low.

It has infected more than 1,000 people and killed 267, generating the largest number of confirmed cases within the first month of any episode of the disease, the World Health Organisation said this week.

Experts say the disease was probably circulating for months before it was officially declared on May 15.

Early confirmed cases were identified in urban areas, and infections have since been reported in at least three densely populated displacement camps.

The two largest previous Ebola outbreaks occurred in West Africa, in Guinea, Sierra Leone and Liberia between 2014 and 2016, and in Congo in 2018.



Displaced Palestinian children play on a swing at a tent camp in Gaza City. FILE

Israel targeted children in Gaza, says UN panel of independent experts

Associated Press
Jerusalem, June 24

A TEAM of independent experts commissioned by the United Nations accused Israel of deliberately shooting children in Gaza and repeated its accusation that Israel has committed genocide in the territory. Israel vociferously denies claims that it committed genocide during its 21/2 year war in Gaza.

The Independent International Commission of Inquiry on the Occupied Palestinian Territory, an investigative body that operates under the UN Human Rights Council, said in its report Tuesday that roughly 30% of the Palestinians killed from October 2023 to October 2025, more than 20,000 in total, were children.

The report also said the toll the conflict had taken on

children in Gaza amounted to war crimes and genocide, building on accusations it first made against Israel in September.

"Even after the October 2025 ceasefire, children continue to be killed and seriously injured, with continued disregard by Israel for the ceasefire and for the protection owed to Palestinian children under international law," Srinivasan Muralidhar, the commission's chair, said.

More children are believed to be missing or buried in unmarked graves. Israel has denied deliberately targeting civilians and pushed back on accusations, including from rights groups, that it committed genocide in Gaza.

Israel's Foreign Ministry called the report a "libelous sham" and said the claims included hadn't been verified.

Ukraine strikes deep into Russia, hits energy and military assets

Associated Press
Kyiv, June 24

UKRAINIAN FORCES struck a major natural gas processing plant and two key satellite communications centres in their latest nighttime attacks on Russia, Ukraine's General Staff said Wednesday.

The operation was part of Ukraine's aerial campaign targeting energy facilities and military industries that has intensified as Kyiv builds bigger and better long-range weapons to ward off Russia's full-scale invasion, now in its fifth year.

In response, Moscow has ordered the redeployment of some air defense systems from Russian regions to the capital and to Crimea's Kerch Bridge, a crucial link for supplying Russian troops, Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy said. The bridge connects the Crimean Peninsula with the Russian mainland.

"It is important that as many Russians as possible come to understand that it is the Russian leadership's rejection of diplomacy that is prolonging the war," Zelenskyy said on X.

Zelenskyy has accepted an unconditional ceasefire demanded by US President Donald Trump but Russian President Vladimir Putin has refused.

• BRIEFLY

PERU

Keiko Fujimori secures decisive lead in presidential election



Peru's presidential candidate Keiko Fujimori. REUTERS

CONSERVATIVE KEIKO Fujimori gained an insurmountable lead in Peru's presidential runoff late on Tuesday, setting her on track to assume the presidency. Fujimori, a four-time presidential hopeful and the daughter of former President Alberto Fujimori, now has 50.11% of the votes, putting her ahead of leftist rival Roberto Sanchez by 43,386 votes. There remain only 40,213 potential votes to be counted, according to data from Peru's ONPE electoral authority. The electoral authority is yet to declare a winner. REUTERS

PAKISTAN

Girls' school building blown up in KPK region

UNIDENTIFIED MILITANTS blew up a government girls' primary school building in the Khyber Pakhtunkhwa province in northwest Pakistan, police said Wednesday. The school located in Birmal tehsil of South Waziristan district, bordering Afghanistan, was destroyed using dynamites late on Tuesday night. District police officer Tahir Shah said no individual or group has claimed any responsibility for the blast as of Wednesday afternoon. PTI

CHINA

Top defence and space official under graft probe

THE DEPUTY head of China's defence industry administration and its national space administration, Bian Zhigang, is under investigation for "suspected serious violations of discipline and law", the country's anti-graft watchdog said on Wednesday. China is in the midst of a years-long anti-corruption campaign initiated by President Xi Jinping which has seen scores of senior officials and top generals probed, removed and purged. REUTERS

• ALL THE WINNING CANDIDATES SHARE MAMDANI'S PROGRESSIVE ECONOMIC PLATFORM, AND THEY RAN CAMPAIGNS THAT FOCUSED INTENTLY ON ENDING U.S. SUPPORT FOR ISRAEL

Mamdani-backed candidates sweep New York primaries, cementing his 'kingmaker' role

Nicholas Fandos
New York, June 24

MAYOR ZOHHRAN Mamdani and his allies swept a series of congressional primaries in New York City on Tuesday in a remarkable show of strength for the insurgent left that sent shock waves through the Democratic Party.

Mamdani's candidates toppled a pair of incumbents backed by the city's political establishment, including major labor unions and the House Democratic leader. Another candidate backed by the mayor won an open House seat, and a handful of democratic socialist challengers he supported were

winning down the ballot.

For months, Mamdani threw himself and his energized political organization into the three marquee congressional contests, campaigning late into the night in the race's final days and calling the election a referendum on the direction of the party.

All the winning candidates share Mamdani's progressive economic platform, and they each ran campaigns that focused intently on ending US support for Israel, a sign of how far public opinion has shifted on the issue, even in New York.

Late Tuesday night, the mayor stood beaming at a victory party in Brooklyn, where

supporters chanted "Free, free Palestine" and "DSA." After embracing many of the same advisers who led his own successful campaign last year, he declared "a new chapter in our party's history."

"A year ago, it was not the end of a political movement," he said. "It was the beginning." Mamdani's deep involvement amounted to an audacious gamble for a brand-new mayor trying to lead an already fractious city. He alienated key allies along the way, but the payoffs were far-reaching.

At home, the outcome will now cement him as the unquestioned political kingmaker of the nation's cultural and fi-



Zohran Mamdani and Brad Lander at a watch party after their primary wins in Brooklyn, New York, on Tuesday. REUTERS

nancial capital and the Democratic Socialists of America as a formidable force.

The results also shook the

foundations of the Democratic Party far beyond the five boroughs. When they are certified, Mamdani, 34, and his move-

ment will be on track to double the number of socialists in Congress from two to four. The outcome will also force a Democratic Party, already searching for its identity, to reckon with its ascendant, unapologetic left.

"It's seismic," said Jon Paul Lupo, a Democratic consultant who was a top adviser to the city's last progressive mayor, Bill de Blasio.

The races do not necessarily suggest Mamdani has expanded his appeal. Each of the contests in which he endorsed took place in areas where the mayor won comfortably in last year's election and remains deeply popular.

But Tuesday's results

showed two things about his young mayoralty. Mamdani has a high tolerance for political risk-taking, well beyond that of any of his modern predecessors. And, at least for now, he has the ability to transfer his high-wattage political brand onto other candidates in a way that only a few politicians in any office have been able to.

Brad Lander, 56, a close ally whom Mamdani urged to run for Congress, ran up a staggering 30-point margin in an affluent Brooklyn and lower Manhattan district. He defeated Rep. Daniel Goldman, a wealthy Levi Strauss heir who had opposed the mayor in last year's elections and had close

ties to the American Israel Public Affairs Committee, the pro-Israel lobby.

Claire Valdez, 36, a little-known member of the state Assembly also recruited by Mamdani to run, ran up larger than expected margins for an open seat in a gentrifying swath of Brooklyn and Queens so far left it has been nicknamed the "Commie Corridor."

She defeated Antonio Reynoso, the Brooklyn borough president, who had far deeper roots in the district and the support of the popular Rep. Nydia Velázquez, who is retiring; the left-leaning Working Families Party; and nearly every major labor union in the city. NYT

FOR LOSSES UP TO RS 50,000, 85% OR RS 25,000, WHICHEVER IS LOWER, WILL BE PAID

Digital fraud: RBI revamps rules, widens framework

ENS Economic Bureau
Mumbai, June 24

THE RESERVE Bank of India (RBI) Wednesday unveiled a revised compensation mechanism for victims of digital payment frauds and widened its framework for limiting customer liability. As per the RBI, a bona fide victim who has lodged a complaint involving gross loss of up to Rs 50,000 on account of fraudulent electronic banking transaction (EBT) will be compensated 85% of the net loss amount or Rs 25,000, whichever is less, once during the lifetime. They must report the fraud on the National Cyber Crime Reporting Portal or National Cyber Crime Helpline (1930) and to the bank within five calendar days from the date of occurrence, it said in the Reserve Bank of India (Commercial Banks-Responsible Business Conduct) Third Amendment Directions, 2026. The new directions will apply in cases of electronic banking transactions undertaken by customers of a bank on or after January 1, 2027. For complaint on a fraudulent

• COMPENSATION FOR ONLINE FRAUD

NEW DIRECTIONS will apply in cases of electronic banking transactions undertaken by bank customers on or after Jan 1, 2027

FOR COMPLAINT on a fraudulent EBT involving a loss of less than Rs 29,412, where a compensation of 85% is paid, 65% will be borne by the RBI, 10% by the customer's bank

IN CASE of a complaint arising from cross-border fraudulent

lent EBT involving a loss of less than Rs 29,412, where 85% of compensation is paid, 65% will be borne by the RBI, 10% by the bank and the remaining 10% by the beneficiary bank, it said. On a complaint from cross-border fraudulent EBT, 65% will be borne by RBI and the remaining 20% by the customer's bank. For fraudulent EBTs involving losses between Rs 29,412 and Rs 50,000, where compensation is capped at Rs 25,000, RBI said the burden will be shared among the RBI, the cus-



EBT, 65% will be borne by the RBI and the remaining 20% by the customer's bank

tomer's bank and the beneficiary bank. In such cases, the RBI will contribute Rs 19,118, while the customer's bank and the beneficiary bank will each contribute Rs 2,941. If it arises out of cross-border fraudulent EBT, the RBI and customer's bank will contribute Rs 19,118 and Rs 5,882, respectively. Beneficiary bank refers to the bank where the fraudulently debited amount is first credited. In cases where there is more than one beneficiary bank, the applicable compen-

Rules to compute banks' forex risk exposure revised

Mumbai: The central bank Wednesday issued final rules governing how banks calculate their net foreign exchange exposure and the capital needed to be set aside against potential FX risk. The RBI had proposed changes to the rules earlier this year. The changes were intended to better align regulations with global norms and ensure consistent implementation across regulated entities. The RBI has clarified that banks have the option to exclude certain structural foreign currency investments from the calculation of net open position on both a standalone and consolidated basis. **REUTERS**

sation to be borne by each bank shall be in the proportion of the amount credited to their respective account. **FULL REPORT ON [WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM](#)**

Premature to talk about rate hikes, says RBI Guv Malhotra

ENS Economic Bureau
Mumbai, June 24

RESERVE BANK of India (RBI) Governor Sanjay Malhotra Wednesday pushed back against market expectations of an imminent rate hike, saying it would be "premature" to discuss monetary tightening when inflation risks remain uncertain and the central bank is closely monitoring global developments. "If it was so certain that we were going to hike rates in the coming months, we would have changed our stance from neutral to restrictive. We did not do that," Malhotra told ETNow in an interview. His remarks prompted a rally in the bond market, with the yield on India's benchmark 10-year government bond falling five basis points to 6.82%, its lowest level in three months. Overnight index swaps, a key indicator of rate expectations, also eased by 10 basis points as traders scaled back bets on policy tightening. Malhotra said the RBI remained data-dependent and was closely watching whether recent price pressures, particularly from fuel costs, spread into broader inflation. **FE**

WEAK MONSOON FORECAST CLOUDS SUPPLY OUTLOOK

Why Grid India is turning to more gas-based power

Pratyush Deep
New Delhi, June 24

THE GRID Controller of India (Grid India) has advised gas-based power stations to plan fuel procurement arrangements, anticipating the need for additional gas-fired generation for 7-8 days in June. The move comes amid weather forecasts indicating below-normal rainfall across the country during the June-September monsoon season. The projected requirement is in addition to the 2.6 gigawatts (GW) of gas-based generation capacity already available from isolated field stations. The assessment is based on projected demand, planned and forced outages of generating units, hydro, renewable generation profiles and present weather information available at Indian Meteorological Department (IMD), according to the Grid India's advisory issued on June 10.

Three key factors

Grid India cited three major considerations for this resource adequacy assessment. These include historical data for the mentioned months, planned upcoming capacity, proposed planned outages and prevailing forced outages, and uncertainty and variability of renewable energy generations. "The above assessment will be reviewed in late June-26 and an updated/modified outlook will be provided, if required," the advisory added. While gas accounts for only a small share of India's overall generation mix, it plays a crucial rebalancing role during evening peak hours, especially during pre-monsoon summer months, when solar output drops. Typically, around 10 GW of gas-fired capacity is relied upon during peak summer. This year, however, the conflict in West Asia has cast a

• REBALANCING ROLE

- While gas accounts for only a small share of India's overall generation mix, it plays a crucial rebalancing role during evening peak hours
- Typically, around 10 GW of gas-fired capacity is relied upon during peak summer
- This year, however, the conflict in West Asia has cast a shadow over fuel availability for gas-based power plants
- Amid concerns over supply disruptions, the government has moved to prioritise gas allocation to certain sectors during periods of shortage

shadow over fuel availability for gas-based power plants. Amid concerns over supply disruptions, the government has moved to prioritise gas allocation to certain sectors during periods of shortage. According to officials, only about 5 GW of gas-based generation capacity is currently available. The situation has been compounded by forecasts of below-normal rainfall during the monsoon season, prompting hydroelectric power stations to conserve water in their reservoirs, officials familiar with the matter told *The Indian Express*. "Reservoirs serve a dual purpose — irrigation for agriculture and electricity generation. Until the monsoon gains momentum in July, the priority is to preserve water levels. That is why the requirement for additional gas-based generation has become more important," an official aware of the matter said. **Hydro role in meeting peak demand** This year's situation stands in contrast to last year, when hydroelectric power played a

crucial role in meeting evening peak demand and providing vital grid-balancing support. However, forecasts of below-normal monsoon rainfall have altered the equation. With hydro generators prioritising reservoir conservation, their ability to provide flexible peak-hour generation has become more constrained. Thus, gas-based power plants are expected to shoulder a larger share of the balancing requirement during evening peak hours. The growing reliance on gas-fired generation is also reflected in a rise in spot-market purchases of natural gas by power sector entities. As per the data provided by the Indian Gas Exchange (IGX) — the country's leading gas-trading bourse — the power sector companies purchased 13,92,500 million Metric Million British Thermal Units (MMBtu) of natural gas between June 1 and June 23. The same stood at nil during June last year often attributed to lower demand due to rain. Notably, gas-based power plants in India are increasingly relying on the spot market to meet their requirement this summer as the conflict in West Asia disrupts supplies under long-term import contracts and clouds fuel availability. Between April 1 and May 31, power-sector entities purchased 45,07,850 MMBtu of natural gas from the spot market, which is 340.4% higher than the corresponding period in 2025. The rise in purchases came despite a sharp increase in spot-market gas prices amid supply disruptions due to the conflict in West Asia. The average spot gas price stood at Rs 1,606 per MMBtu in April, up 43.5% from Rs 1,119 per MMBtu a year earlier. Prices rose further to Rs 1,857 per MMBtu in May, a jump of 77.5% over Rs 1,046 per MMBtu in May last year. In June, the average spot gas price stood at Rs 1,846 per MMBtu. **FULL REPORT ON [WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM](#)**

Adani eyes 10 GW nuclear power plan

George Mathew
Mumbai, June 24

ADANI GROUP plans to develop 10 gigawatts (GW) of nuclear power generation capacity over the next nine years, Chairman Gautam Adani said Wednesday, as it looks to capitalise on recent reforms that have opened India's nuclear power sector to private participation. If realized, the 10 GW target would represent one of the largest private-sector commitments to nuclear energy in India. "With land identified and a 10 GW targeted capacity by 2035, we are positioning ourselves early to serve the growing national demand for clean, round-the-clock power," Adani said at the group's annual general meeting. The new law — Sustainable Harnessing and Advancement of Nuclear Energy for Transforming India Bill (SHANTI Bill) — passed by the Parliament in December 2025 is expected to unlock private sector participation across a wide spectrum of nuclear activities including nuclear power generation, reactor supply and operation, nuclear fuel mining and RDD across the nuclear fuel cycle. Apart from Adani, companies such as Reliance Industries, NTPC and Lalitpur Power Generation Company are also planning to enter the nuclear energy segment. Tata Power is looking at smaller-sized reactors, including small modular reactors. Capital costs to set up nuclear projects are high, and private players in India have very limited experience in the segment. At Adani Power, the group is implementing India's largest ever private sector power capex programme of over Rs 2 lakh crore, with a target of

• PRIVATE PLAYERS

SHANTI ACT, which was passed last year, is expected to usher in private participation across nuclear activities such as power generation, reactor supply

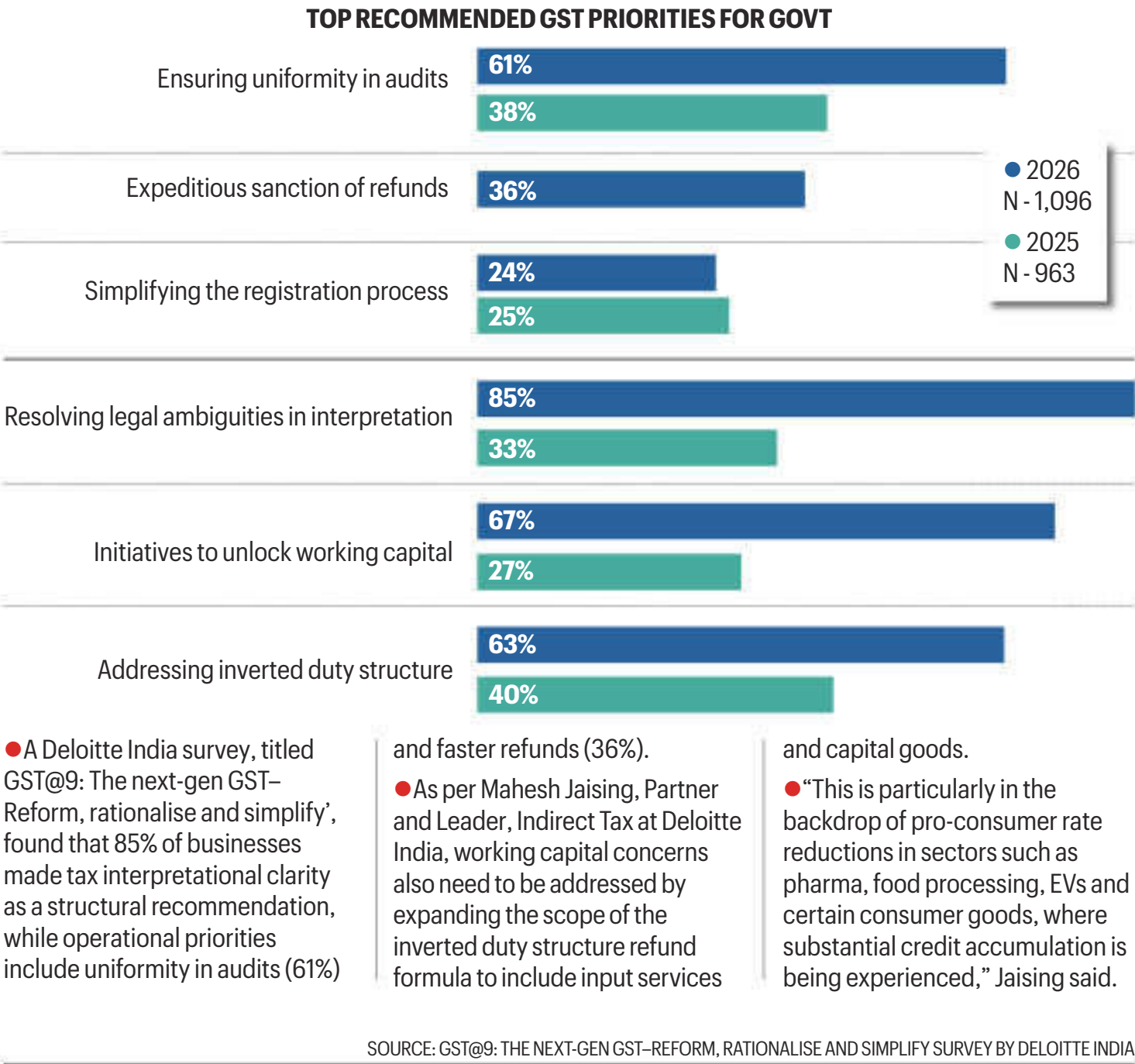
FIRMS LIKE NTPC, Reliance Industries, are also eyeing an entry in the segment. Tata Power is focused on smaller-sized reactors

ADANI POWER is implementing India's largest ever private sector capex programme of over Rs 2 lakh crore, aiming to reach 45 GW of capacity in the next five years

reaching 45 GW of capacity over the next five years, he said. "We are also honoured to be partnering with the government of Bhutan's Druk Green Power Corporation. As part of this partnership, the Adani Group and the DGPC will jointly develop 5,000 megawatts of hydropower projects in Bhutan," Adani said. On the aviation sector, he said partnerships with Leonardo and Embraer are helping lay the foundation for integrated helicopter and regional aircraft manufacturing ecosystems in India. "We are building a national aerospace platform that spans manufacturing, MRO, services and pilot training," he said. "During Operation Sindoor, our drones, anti-drone systems, missiles and ammunition supported our armed forces when it mattered the most." He said the group is putting in place a three-layer structure across both its headquarters and sites to reduce bureaucracy, sharpen accountability and bring decisions closer to execution. **FULL REPORT ON [WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM](#)**

• NINE YEARS OF GST: MORE REFORMS SOUGHT

The goods and services tax (GST) regime will complete nine years on June 30, with its rollout on July 1, 2017 completely overhauling India's indirect tax system. However, as last September's GST 2.0 reforms showed, the system continues to evolve.



FIRE AT STT GLOBAL DATA CENTRES INDIA FACILITY

Clients fear loss of decades of data

New Delhi: A fire at a New Delhi data centre used by global tech firms has left some customers fearing the loss of decades of data and caused network disruptions for Google Cloud services in India, as per a company letter and sources. The blaze at the STT Global Data Centres India facility, owned by Singapore's ST Telemedia and India's Tata Communications, caused "extensive damage" to parts of the site,

making data recovery difficult, a Tata Communications unit said in a letter to a client seen by *Reuters*. The firm, part of the salt-to-aviation Tata group, told Indian stock exchanges on June 5 it had activated business continuity plans to limit disruption after an early morning fire at the facility. One client, Matrix Cellular, an Indian firm that sells international SIM cards, told *Reuters* it was struggling to recover more

than two decades of data lost in the incident. Some of Google Cloud's intermittent network disruptions in India are also linked to the fire, a source with direct knowledge of the matter said. The fire was "so severe that it caused extensive damage" and hindered services, Tata Communications unit Novamesh said in the June 15 letter to Matrix Cellular, which has not previously been reported. **REUTERS**

• INDIA FACES A PILOT SHORTAGE, WITH ITS LARGEST AIRLINE, INDIGO, HAVING JUST 7.6 PILOTS PER NARROWBODY PLANE

India eyes simulator-led pilot licencing, document shows

Reuters
New Delhi, June 24

AN INDIAN government panel has proposed a new pilot licence option that would shift more training into simulators and cut the time cadets spend flying real aircraft as it aims to ease a pilot shortage, a draft report shows. The Multi-Crew Pilot Licence (MPL) under discussion was introduced by the UN's International Civil Aviation Organization in 2006 and adopted by many countries in Europe, Asia and West Asia in addition to traditional pilot-training pathways. India is now considering the licence to build a more predictable pipeline of junior pilots trained for individual carriers as airlines expand their fleets, according to an unpublished

19-page draft report dated June 3 reviewed by *Reuters*. Under the proposed plan, cadets would complete 100 to 120 hours in training aircraft, including at least 20 hours solo, compared with at least 200 hours under India's existing rules. Much of the remaining practical training would be conducted in commercial jet simulators under an alternative route the draft said "may shorten timeline for cadets." "If implemented with strong regulatory oversight and industry collaboration... (the new licensing route) can reduce manpower shortages," the government panel's draft report said. The report was prepared by a committee headed by a senior official of India's aviation regulator that included representatives from IndiGo, Air India and flight-training or-



Airlines have been asked to respond to the plan. **REUTERS**

Pilot shortages

India faces a pilot shortage, with its largest airline, IndiGo, having just 7.6 pilots per narrow-body plane, the report said, well below the global average of around 10. IndiGo in December cancelled thousands of flights after it failed to plan adequately

for new rules limiting pilots' working hours, leaving it short of pilots. The MPL, used for co-pilot hires at carriers including Qatar Airways and Europe's easyJet, is less portable between airlines in the early stages of a pilot's career and could help ease Indian carriers' turnover concerns. The government proposal said greater reliance on simulators could "lower operational risk" while giving cadets more focused practice in handling critical and emergency situations. The option does not reduce training rigor and only redistributes training emphasis toward structured simulation, it added, saying it should not be "misunderstood as a shortcut due to lower aircraft flight hours." The plan, however, has already drawn some concerns, with the Association of Flight

Training Organisations saying cutting time in real aircraft could weaken cadets' hands-on flying skills and judgement in unexpected situations, according to a letter dated June 9. The group has asked the regulator to mandate at least 150 hours in actual aircraft, instead of the 100 to 120 hours proposed in the draft. The draft report itself acknowledged that some pilots could have "weaker hands-on flying instincts and less confidence handling unexpected situations independently." IndiGo backed the pilot licensing proposal during consultations in August, an email shows, with Ashim Mitra, the airline's senior vice president of flight operations, writing that MPL was needed to "support the growth of aviation whilst ensuring safety as the bedrock."

Training Organisations saying cutting time in real aircraft could weaken cadets' hands-on flying skills and judgement in unexpected situations, according to a letter dated June 9. The group has asked the regulator to mandate at least 150 hours in actual aircraft, instead of the 100 to 120 hours proposed in the draft. The draft report itself acknowledged that some pilots could have "weaker hands-on flying instincts and less confidence handling unexpected situations independently." IndiGo backed the pilot licensing proposal during consultations in August, an email shows, with Ashim Mitra, the airline's senior vice president of flight operations, writing that MPL was needed to "support the growth of aviation whilst ensuring safety as the bedrock."

• MARKETS

Sensex 76,991.22 790.54 1.04%	NIFTY 24,021.65 197.55 0.83%	Gold ▼ ₹1,42,178	US Dollar ▼ ₹94.66
		Silver ▼ ₹2,22,035	Oil ▼ \$74.34

NOTE: GOLD, SILVER RATES AS PER INDIA BULLION AND JEWELLERS ASSOCIATION DATA GOLD PER 10G, SILVER PER 1 KG; CRUDE OIL (INDIAN BASKET) AS OF JUNE 23, 2026

Classifieds

PERSONAL

I, **hitherto** known as **HEMLATA, W/O TARUN RAMPAL, R/OA-30,1ST-FLOOR,SHISH RAM PARK,UTTAM NAGAR,D,K-Mohan Garden S.O,West-Delhi,Delhi-110059**, have changed my name and shall hereafter be known as **HEMA RAMPAL.** 0040862403-1

I, **SYED SABIYA, S/O SYED MUZAMMIL AHMED R/O H NO D 68 SECTOR 30 NOIDA GAUTAM BUDDHA NAGAR, PO NOIDA UTTAR PRADESH 201301** have changed my name **SABIYA SYED** for all future purposes 0071043885-1

I, **Laiqueuzzaman Khan, S/o Latif Uzama Khan, R/o O-14, Gali No.16, Brahmpuri, Seelampur, North-East Delhi-110053**, have changed my name to **Laique Uzama Khan** for all purposes. 0040862402-4

I, **Ankit Sangal, R/O 88, A 2 Z Colony Phase-1, Green Estate, Muzaffarnagar U.P.-251001**, Have Changed my Minor Daughter's name **Nandini to Nandini Sangal.** 0040862409-8

I, **AYUB ZAHIDA AYOOBI** w/o Late **Mohammad Tajwar Khan R/o A-14, Second Floor, Friends Colony East, New Delhi-65**, inform that **AYUB ZAHIDA AYOOBI, ZAHIDA KHAN** and **A ZAHIDA AYOOBI** all are one and the same person. 0040862292-1

I, **Hunny W/O, Sachin Kumar R/o 47/1, 2nd Floor, Old Rajinder Nagar, Delhi-110060** have changed my name to **Hunny Gakhar** for all purposes. 0040862387-1

I, **AKHTARI W/O-ASIM MALIK R/O-U-13 DDA-FLATS TURKMAN GATE DELHI-6**, HAVE CHANGED MY NAME, FROM **AKHTARI TO AKHTARI BEGUM** FOR ALL FUTURE, PURPOSES. 0040862403-3

I **Shruti, W/o Sachin Tyagi, R/o H.No.2155, Sector-2, Faridabad** have changed my name to **Shruti Tyagi** after marriage. 0040862409-1

I, **AFSANA BEGUM, wife of, RIYAZUDDIN, R/O-H.NO-B-18 KH.NO.576M, DURGA ENCLAVE- GREATER NOIDA, WEST, CHIPYANA-BUZURG GAUTAM-BUDDHA NAGAR, UTTAR PRADESH-201009**, have changed my name to **AFSANA BEGUM SAIFI**, for all, purposes 0040862445-4

I, **is** for general information that, I, **MAMTA PANDEY, W/O SHRI RAMESH PANDEY R/O 120/J-EXTENSION ASHIRVADI APARTMENT, GALI NO-3 LAXMI NAGAR DELHI-110092**, declare that **NAME OF MINE HAS BEEN WRONGLY WRITTEN AS MAMTA RANI** IN MY 10TH SCHOOL RECORD. The actual NAME OF MINE IS **MAMTA PANDEY.** 0040862288-1

I, **Suryansh Shreyasker S/O, Rampal Singh Kashyap R/O Superpetech Eco Village Greater Noida West** have changed my name to **Suryansh Shreyasker Kashyap.** 0040862174-1

I, **Salim Zaki S/o. Mohd Zak R/O-2453, Chatta Jam Begi, Tiraha Behram Khan, DaryaGanj, Delhi-110002**, have changed my name to **SALEEM permanently** 0040862445-3

I, **Amit Kumar/Amit, S/o-Chander Parkash, R/o-flat no-402, Tower-14A, Sector-48, Vipul Green Gurgaon, Haryana-122001**, Have changed my name to **Amit Sachdeva** for all purposes 0040862402-5

I, **Nawazish Alam Khan s/o Amir Alam Khan R/o A-4/240, Paschim Vihar, Delhi-110063** have changed my minor son's name from **MOHAMMAD RAHBAR** to **REHBAR ALAM KHAN** permanently. 0040862286-1

I, **ARVIND S/O LATE SHRI MUNNA LAI, R/O H.NO.244/73, NEAR JAIN VATIKA SCHOOL, SCHOOL BLOCK, MANDAWALI FAZALPUR, DELHI-110092**, have changed my name from **ARVIND** to **ARVIND SINGH** for all future purposes. 0071043919-1

I, **Anil Kumar Gupta, S/o Madan Lai, R/O 10/17, Third-Floor, Near Choudhary Sweet, Shakti Nagar, Delhi-110007**, Changed my name to **Anil Kumar** for all purposes. 0040862409-3

I, **MOHAMMAD HALIM ANSARI S/O MOHAMMED MUSLIM ANSARI R/O FLAT.NO.1502, TOWER-N1, SUPERTECH ECO VILLAGE-1, GREATER NOIDA WEST, G.B. NAGAR U.P.-201306** HAVE CHANGED MY NAME TO **MOHAMMED HALIM ANSARI FOR ALL THE FUTURE PURPOSE.** 0071043898-1

I, **VRIRANI KAMIL KAMARUDDINBHAI**, residence of, **AT TIMBI, TA-JAFRABAD DIST AMRELI GUJARAT-362730** have changed my SON's name, from **VRIRANI KENNITH KAMILBHAI** to **KENNITH KAMIL VIRANI**, vide- Affidavit dated 24/06/2026. 0040862402-8

I, **SUMAN, D/O- PRAKASH CHAND, R/O- COTTAGE NO-4 SHIPRA SUN CITY INDIRAPURAM GHAZIABAD UTTAR PRADESH-201014**, HAVE CHANGED MY NAME TO **RITU RASTOGI**, FOR ALL PURPOSES. 0040862403-7

I, **KEWAL KRISHNAN, S/O- MUNSRI RAM ADDRESS-1/3538-A ST.NO-5 MANDOLI ROAD RAM NAGAR EXT. SHAHDARA, DELHI-110032**, changed my name to **KEWAL KRISHAN** 0040862402-1

I, **NIKITA D/O KAPIL R/O A-6/71, 3RD FLOOR, SECTOR-16, ROHINI DELHI-110089**, have changed my name to **NIKITA SEHGAL.** 0040862403-5

I, **Farahat Hasan, S/o Azhar Hasan, R/o B-503, New Friends Colony, South Delhi, Delhi-110025**, have changed my name to **Farhat Hasan.** 0040862409-5

I, **Geeta Dhyan, W/o Kanhaiya Lal Dhyan, resident of F-5 Sector 12 Noida U.P.201301**, have changed my name from **Geeta Dhyan** to **Dikka Devi**. Henceforth I would be known by the name of **Dikka Devi** for all future purposes. 0040862347-1

I, **REVANTH B, F/O-B SWEENISHA R/O-SMQ.No.39D, Pinto Park, Palam, New Delhi-110010**, have change my, minor daughter name, from **B SWEENISHA** to **BOLLARAPU SWINI SHERIN** (DOB- 9/7/2012), via- Affidavit IN- DL38080113346505Y Dt- 6/4/2026, which may be amended accordingly. 0040862402-10

I, **NEHA YADAV, D/o- RAJPAL, R/O- H.NO.-902, KHURANA ROAD, KALU WALI GAMRI, PATTI AFGAN, KAITHAL, HARYANA-136027** have changed my name to **NEHA** 0040862403-9

I **hitherto** known as **SHIVPRIYA KHLINNALI** alias **SHIVPRIYA MATHUR D/O DEEPAK KHLINLANI** and **W/O GAURAV MATHUR R/O 2506 DIVYANSH PRATHAM PARTMENTS, AHINSA KHAND-2, INDIRAPURAM, GHAZIABAD, UTTAR PRADESH-201014**, have changed my name and shall hereafter be known as **SHIVPRIYA MATHUR** 0040862445-1

I, **PARVEEN KUMAR, S/O LATE SHRI LAKHMI CHAND AGGARWAL, R/O D-61, LORD KRISHNA ROAD, ARUNDRASH NAGAR, DELHI-110033**, changed my name from **PARVEEN KUMAR**, to **PARVEEN KUMAR AGGARWAL** for all purposes. 0071043883-1

I, **Km.Usha** Alies **Usha, W/o Arun Kumar, R/o C-363 Street No.15, Bhajanpura, North-East Delhi-110053**, have changed my name to **Usha Rani**, for all purposes. 0040862402-3

I, **SANTOSH W/o Krushan Kumar R/o 74, Kushak No.1 Kadi Pur Delhi-110036**, have changed my minor daughter name **LAHAR** to **LEHAR.** 0040862409-7

I, **Satendar Kumar S/o Late Musafir Mahto R/o B-173, Navjeevan Camp, Govind Puri, Delhi-110019** have changed my name from **Satender** to **Satendar Kumar** for all future purposes . 0040862382-1

I, **Ranveer Singh S/O- Ramdas, Address-K-2nd-70, gali no-02, Sangam vihar, new Delhi-110062**, have changed my name **TO Ranvir Singh** 0040862403-2

I, **Manoj Sharma S/o Shri Rajesh Sharma R/o 17/191, Gali No. 8, Than Singh Nagar, Anand Parbat, New Delhi-110005**, Have changed my name to **Guru Sharma** for all purposes 0130066163-1

I, **Suryansh Shreyasker S/O, Rampal Singh Kashyap R/O Superpetech Eco Village Greater Noida West** have changed my name to **Suryansh Shreyasker Kashyap.** 0040862174-1

I, **Salim Zaki S/o. Mohd Zak R/O-2453, Chatta Jam Begi, Tiraha Behram Khan, DaryaGanj, Delhi-110002**, have changed my name to **SALEEM permanently** 0040862445-3

I, **Amit Kumar/Amit, S/o-Chander Parkash, R/o-flat no-402, Tower-14A, Sector-48, Vipul Green Gurgaon, Haryana-122001**, Have changed my name to **Amit Sachdeva** for all purposes 0040862402-5

I, **Amal Bhasin, S/o-Anil Kumar Bhasin, R/o C-303, Jagdambe Apartments-C-58/25, Sector-62, Noida, Gautam BudhNagar, U.P.-201309**, have changed my name to **Amal Kant Bhasin**, for all, future purposes. 0040862409-9

I, **Sweety Kaur Alang w/o Tajinder Singh R/o 7/52, Double Storey, Kabool Nagar, Shahdara, Delhi-110032** have changed my name to **SWEETY ALANG.** 0040862294-1

I, **Kochatil Rajesh Menon S/O P.Aravindakshan** born on 05.11.1972 residing at R 288b, Greater kailash 1, have changed my name to **Rajesh Menon** vide affidavit dated 18.06.2026 at New Delhi. 0071043866-1

I, **Mahekk Kapur**, daughter of **Sanjay Kapur** resident of **339, Hauz-Khas Apartments, Hauz-Khas, South West Delhi, Delhi-110016**, have changed my name to **Mahekk Kapur**, for all, future purposes. 0040862403-4

I, **Sandhya Barik W/o Anup Kumar Barik, 1201, Kempstone Tower,T-10, Sector 43, Omaxe Hills-2, Faridabad** have changed my name to **Sandhya Rani Barik** 0040862409-2

I, **SHAHKH NADEEM AHMED S/o Shaikh Mahmood**, aged about 55 years, R/o Flat No.407, Asia House, K.G. Marg, New Delhi-110001, do hereby solemnly affirm and declare that "SHAHKH NADEEM AHMED" & "SHAHKH NADEEM AHMED MAHMOOD" belong to one and the same person. 0040862283-1

I, **SANJIV RANJAN, S/O- MANORANJAN SHARMA, R/o- Flat.No.577, Sanskriti Apartment, DDA-Multistorey, Sector-19B, Dwarka, South-West Delhi, New Delhi-110075**, have changed my minor Son's name, from **SHAURYANSHA RANJAN** (Aged 17-years and 6-months) to **SHAURYANSH RANJAN**, for all, future purposes. 0040862403-8

I, **KEWAL KRISHNAN, S/O- MUNSRI RAM ADDRESS-1/3538-A ST.NO-5 MANDOLI ROAD RAM NAGAR EXT. SHAHDARA, DELHI-110032**, changed my name to **KEWAL KRISHAN** 0040862403-5

I, **SUDESH , W/O PURAN KISHORE R/O H NO 50 VILL SINGHOLA NARELA PO NARELA NORTH WEST DELHI 110040** have changed my name **SUDESH KUMARI** for all future purposes 0071043891-1

I, **SADAR JAHAN, W/O WARIS KHAN, R/O B-580, GALI NO-17, SHRI RAM-COLONY RAJIV-NAGAR, DELHI-110094**, HAVE CHANGED MY MINOR CHILD NAME **MOHAMMAD AHAD KHAN TO MOHD MONISH KHAN** for all future purposes. 0040862402-7

I, **Jyoti W/o-Satish Kumar, R/o-H.No.-15, Kalyan Panna, Pole No.4-A, Near Govt Dispensary, Tikri Kalan, West Delhi-110041**, declare that **Jyoti & Jyoti Dahiya** both are the same Person. 0040862409-11

I, **Tajinder Singh Alang s/o Harjinder Singh r/o 7/52, Double Storey, Kabool Nagar, Shahdara, Delhi-110032** have changed my name to **TAJINDER SINGH.** 0040862294-2

I, **Mahender Kumar S/o Late Sohan Lai R/o H.No. 1624, Second Floor, Janta Flats, near G.T.B. Hospital, G.T.B. Enclave, Dilshad Garden, North East Delhi, Delhi-110093**, declare that name of mine has been wrongly written as **MAHINDER KUMAR** in my **PAN Card No. AUDDPK17157R, PPO No. 601201402321** ad my **Aadhar Card No. 7893 6520** may be amended accordingly. 1961. The actual name of mine is **Mahender Kumar** which may be amended accordingly. 0040862296-1

I, **premchandra/ Prem chand mouriya s/o kedarnath R/o T-211 chhuriya mohalla tekhad Okhla phase-1, Delhi-110020**, have changed my name to **New name Prem chand** Permanently. 0071043922-1

I, **AMAN S/O- RAJESH KUMAR, R/O-COTTAGE NO-4 SHIPRA SUN CITY INDIRAPURAM GHAZIABAD, UTTAR PRADESH-201014**, HAVE CHANGED MY NAME TO **AMAN RASTOGI**, FOR ALL PURPOSES. 0040862403-6

I, **Mohammad Abubak S/o Farhat Hasan, R/O B-503, New Friends Colony, South Delhi, Delhi-110025**, have changed my name to **Mohammad Abu Bakar Choudhary.** 0040862409-4

I, **Alauddin Khan S/o Nizamuddin R/o 155, KH.NO.490/106, Third floor, Gharonda Neem Ka Bangar Patparganj, East Delhi-110091**, That I have changed my name from **Alauddin** to **Alauddin Khan** for all purposes. Both name belongs to one and same person. 0071043881-1

I, **Amrendra Kumar**, residence of, **C/O- Sancha Niwash, Road no-01, Pandasheel Nagar, Pandra, Post-Hehal, Dist.- Ranchi, State-Jharkhand, 834005**, Have changed my Son's name, from **REYANSH TO REYANSH RANJAN** Vide- affidavit dated-24/06/2026 0040862402-9

I, **Monu son of Sohan Lai, resident of, House.No- 2A/27, H-Block, Gali.No-2, Near Ayyapa-Temple Road, Mohan-Nagar Maruti Kunj, Bhondsi, Gurgaon, Haryana-122102**, have changed my name to **Monu Saini**, for all, future purposes. 0040862402-2

I, **MUKESH S/O RAMESH KUMAR R/O JHUGGI NO.F-44, SHAHBAD DAIRY SAHIBABAD DAULATPUR, DELHI-110042**, have changed my name to **MUKESH RAJAT.** 0040862409-6

I, **KRISHNI W/O Mala Ram, residing at Nangal Dargu Mahendergarh Haryana**, have changed my name **Krishni to Krishana Devi.** 0130066139-1

I, **Shubham Sharma, S/o Sunil Kumar, R/o 2/27, Pandit Mohalla, Kondli, Delhi-110096**, hereby declare that my name has been mistakenly recorded as "Subham Sharma" in my Union Bank of India Account No.708502010006775. My correct and official name is "Shubham Sharma", as mentioned in my Aadhaar Card, PAN Card, and other official documents. Henceforth I would be known by the name of **Shubham Sharma** for all future purposes. 0071043866-1

LOST & FOUND

I, **ANITA** Dewedi, W/o Late. Santosh Kumar, R/o- H.No.821, FF, First-Floor, Near-Govt.School, Sector-3, Ballabgarh, Faridabad, Haryana-121004, have lost my original sale deed. No.4733 dated-01.12.2000, duly registered in the office of the Sub Registrar Tehsil-Ballabgarh, Faridabad, Haryana. A Finder may contact on above address. 0040862302-1

Lost my Allotment Letter, Possition Letter and Related Documents of, Flat-No.656, PKT A1, SEC 35 in Rohini Residential Scheme 1981, Vide Application No. 45604, has been lost. Finder may please contact - Dinesh Chander, S/o Late Sh Kripa Ram R/o G1/6/141, Vaishali Sec 6, Ghaziabad Uttar Pradesh, 201010. Mobile No. 97587 67656. 0040862442-5

My original documents, i.e. ownership papers of property - Plot No. 656, PKT A1, SEC 35 in Rohini Residential Scheme 1981, Vide Application No. 45604, has been lost. Finder may please contact - Dinesh Chander, S/o Late Sh Kripa Ram R/o G1/6/141, Vaishali Sec 6, Ghaziabad Uttar Pradesh, 201010. Mobile No. 97587 67656. 0040862442-5

PUBLIC NOTICE

PUBLIC NOTICE
The public at large is hereby notified on behalf of my clients **Mohd Salamuddin, Sir Sh. Abdul Khaliq and his wife Late Mrs. Baby Khatoon**, currently residing at **R/o Plot no.62, Block-C, Street No.19, Nangal Vihar Estate, Bahadur, Najafgarh, New Delhi-110043** that my client have permanently dissolved and severed all ties with his son **E. Mohd. Sabir Husain** and his wife, **Nasrin Khan** and their children. This severance includes all social, financial, and emotional connections, and my clients disclaim any future responsibility or association with them on pretext of non-conflict family relations from several years. Our clients shall not be responsible for any acts and deeds of the above named dissolved persons from the date of this notice is issued till the future.
Sd/-
SAHIR KAUSHIK (Advocate)
Lawyer's Chamber No. 636
Dwarka Courts Complex, New Delhi-110075

PUBLIC NOTICE
General Public is hereby informed that my client **Smt. Sita Verma W/o Late Mihail Lal T-Hust, Patnachar Vidhalyata, Timpur, Chilli Lines, Delhi-110016** have severed all her relations and social connections with her son namely **Bhatat Kumar Verma** and his wife **Smt. Rঞ্জim Verma Do Sh. Keshav Verma**, who are living separately somewhere else as they have proven to be most disobedient, disrespectful and harmful towards my client and my client hereby disown and debar them from inheriting any of her movable and immovable properties. Anybody dealing with them shall be doing so at his/her own cost and peril and for which my client and her other family members shall not be held liable or responsible.
Sd/-
N.K. Mishra (Advocate)
Ch. No. 588-A, 1st Floor, Western Wing, Tis Hazari Courts, Delhi-54

PUBLIC NOTICE
Notice is hereby given to general public that I, **Pratibha Krishnarao Salunke** wife of **Krishnarao Udhavrao Salunke** have lost the original Sale deeds with registration number 7920 registered on 07/02/2018 at office of Sub- Registrar SR V A Hauz Khas, New Delhi /Delhi and sale deed with registration number 9016 registered on 24/12/2019 at office of Sub- Registrar SR V A Hauz Khas, New Delhi /Delhi on 07/06/2026 from my residence at 16/3 Vatika Greens, FH No. KH No 595, 608, 609, Village Gadaipur, Chhattarpur , Delhi 110030. Apart from the sale deeds, other documents related to these sale deeds have also been lost. In this regard, an FIR (LR NO 389235/2026) has been lodged at Mehrauli / e-Police Station on 02.07/2026.

Finder of these documents is requested to return them to my address above. Further any person(s) or institutions dealing with or carrying out any transaction using these documents will do so entirely at their own risk and cost. The undersigned will not be responsible for any transactions, misuse or illegal activities carried out using these lost documents.

सार्वजनिक सूचना
सर्वसाधारण को सूचित किया जाता है कि मेरे मुनिकित्तवाक रमदेवत पुत्र खमरुणी मे वारा मंद, दिल्ली 110017, विजयपुर, बल्लभगढ़, पश्चिम उत्तर प्रदेश, दिल्ली-110045, अपनी बह-अनवर समीति का परिवारिक बंधनवा दिनांक 31/01/2026 के समुपरी अंतुस्तर, अपने पुत्र 1 मुनी के बीच सदस्यत्व से अलग हो गई है। (उपरी अंतुस्तर) में इस सूचना पर किसी को पूर्व खमरुणी नहीं होगा। मेरे मुनिकित्तवा रमदेवत, मेरे भी स्वयं प्रमाण करते हैं कि उनका सदस्यता पुत्र मोहित अंतुस्तर अपनी भी सदस्यता से अलग हो गई है। अंतुस्तर में उक्तों द्वारा किया गए किसी भी प्रकार के बैंक, खमरुणी या अन्य विधिवी रमदेवत, बैंक और देवदारिपति के विना मेरे मुनिकित्तवा रमदेवत, उनका, परिवार या उनका भी मेरी प्रमाण या अंतुस्तर पर से उत्तरदायी नहीं होगा। खमरुणी स्व स्वयं सिमिदार होगी। खमरुणी अंतुस्तर और मेरा अंतुस्तर (यदि कोई) का केवलिक जीवन सदस्यता में किसी भी रूप में है। यह उनका मेरी संपत्ति है। इस विवाद में मेरे मुनिकित्तवा रमदेवत, का उनको परिवार का कोई संबंध या हस्तक्षेप नहीं है। इसके लिए उनका पूर्व स्वयं सिमिदार है। यदि अंतुस्तर में उनके और किसी भी प्रकार की कानूनी प्रक्रिया होती है, तो मेरे मुनिकित्तवा रमदेवत और उनका परिवार उनसे लिए किसी भी रूप में सिमिदार नहीं होगा और न ही हस्तक्षेप का हस्तक्षेप है। हस्तक्षेप नहीं और स्वयं अंतुस्तर अपने स्वयं का हस्तक्षेप है। मेरे मुनिकित्तवा रमदेवत, की खमरुणी विधिवी उर्म वारा डिपॉजिटरीन दफ्तर (A.1177 विजयपुर (बल्लभगढ़) की बर्तमान अधिकृत देवदारिपति को अंतुस्तर, परिवार के किसी सदस्य द्वारा प्राप्त किए गए किसी अन्य रूप के लिए भी मेरे मुनिकित्तवा रमदेवत, का दायित्व नहीं होगा।
रमेश जी बाम (अधिकृत)
इमरालिट नंबर डी-239/79

सार्वजनिक सूचना
सर्वसाधारण को सूचित किया जाता है कि मेरे मुनिकित्तवा रमदेवत पुत्र खमरुणी मे वारा मंद, दिल्ली 110017, विजयपुर, बल्लभगढ़, पश्चिम उत्तर प्रदेश, दिल्ली-110045, अपनी बह-अनवर समीति का परिवारिक बंधनवा दिनांक 31/01/2026 के समुपरी अंतुस्तर, अपने पुत्र 1 मुनी के बीच सदस्यत्व से अलग हो गई है। (उपरी अंतुस्तर) में इस सूचना पर किसी को पूर्व खमरुणी नहीं होगा। मेरे मुनिकित्तवा रमदेवत, मेरे भी स्वयं प्रमाण करते हैं कि उनका सदस्यता पुत्र मोहित अंतुस्तर अपनी भी सदस्यता से अलग हो गई है। अंतुस्तर में उक्तों द्वारा किया गए किसी भी प्रकार के बैंक, खमरुणी या अन्य विधिवी रमदेवत, बैंक और देवदारिपति के विना मेरे मुनिकित्तवा रमदेवत, उनका, परिवार या उनका भी मेरी प्रमाण या अंतुस्तर पर से उत्तरदायी नहीं होगा। खमरुणी स्व स्वयं सिमिदार होगी। खमरुणी अंतुस्तर और मेरा अंतुस्तर (यदि कोई) का केवलिक जीवन सदस्यता में किसी भी रूप में है। यह उनका मेरी संपत्ति है। इस विवाद में मेरे मुनिकित्तवा रमदेवत, का उनको परिवार का कोई संबंध या हस्तक्षेप नहीं है। इसके लिए उनका पूर्व स्वयं सिमिदार है। यदि अंतुस्तर में उनके और किसी भी प्रकार की कानूनी प्रक्रिया होती है, तो मेरे मुनिकित्तवा रमदेवत और उनका परिवार उनसे लिए किसी भी रूप में सिमिदार नहीं होगा और न ही हस्तक्षेप का हस्तक्षेप है। हस्तक्षेप नहीं और स्वयं अंतुस्तर अपने स्वयं का हस्तक्षेप है। मेरे मुनिकित्तवा रमदेवत, की खमरुणी विधिवी उर्म वारा डिपॉजिटरीन दफ्तर (A.1177 विजयपुर (बल्लभगढ़) की बर्तमान अधिकृत देवदारिपति को अंतुस्तर, परिवार के किसी सदस्य द्वारा प्राप्त किए गए किसी अन्य रूप के लिए भी मेरे मुनिकित्तवा रमदेवत, का दायित्व नहीं होगा।
रमेश जी बाम (अधिकृत)
इमरालिट नंबर डी-239/79

NOTICE

NOTICE is hereby given that the **Certificate for 100 Equity Shares bearing Equity Share Certificate No. 122582 and Distinctive Nos. 35503423-35503522** under the folio **No 73282110** of **UltraTech Cement Limited** standing in the name of **Mani Nahata** has/have been lost or mislaid and the undersigned has / have applied to the Company to issue duplicate Certificate of the said shares. Any person who has any claim in respect of the said shares should write to our Registrar, **KFin Technologies Limited, Selenium Tower B, Plot 31-32, Gachibowli, Financial District, Hyderabad-500032** within one month from this date else the company will proceed to issue duplicate Certificate(s).
Name(s) of Shareholder(s)
Mani Nahata
Date: 24.06.2026

PUBLIC NOTICE
NOTICE IS HEREBY GIVEN TO the general public that my client **Ms. Geeta D/o. Mr. Tulsi Das**, is intending to purchase the immovable property described in the Schedule below from **Smt. Ravinder Kaur W/O Sh. Balji Singh, R/o WZ-79A, Gali No.6, Krishna Park, Tikka Nagar, New Delhi-110018**. Any persons(s), bank, financial institution, or anyone having or claiming any right, title, interest, ownership, share, lien, charge, mortgage, lease, interest, easement, or other right of any nature whatsoever in, to, or upon the said property, or any part thereof, through inheritance, gift, sale, or otherwise, is hereby required to make the same known in writing with supportive documentary evidence to the undersigned at the address given below. Objections or claims must be submitted within 15 days from the date of publication of this notice. On my email: advocatessanjaykumar@gmail.com or WhatsApp No. 9807584112. If no valid claims or objections are received within the stipulated period, the said property will be considered the sole transaction of the said property, and no claims of any nature will be entertained thereafter. Any such claims will be considered waived.
SCHEDULE OF PROPERTY:
LG Flat No. AZA-237, JANAKPURI, NEW
Sd/-
Sanjay Kumar
Advocate
Ch. No. Cst/061, Joseph, Tis Hazari Courts, Delhi-110054

सार्वजनिक सूचना
सर्वसाधारण को सूचित किया जाता है कि मेरे मुनिकित्तवा श्रीमती कृष्णा देवी खली स्व, मंगल दास निवासी 1 खोका टी खोपा जी.टी. रोड खली पहाड़ी, मुराका गंज, दिल्ली-10007 मे अपनी पुत्री मोनिका कर्क को उस पर 52 वर्ग फीट पर से उनके स्वयं अग्रपुत्र के कारण अपनी स्वययन प्राप्त-अनवर समीति आदि दे देवदारन बर चरत सम्पन्न स्वययन बर लिया है। कोई भी व्यक्ति जो मोनिका कर्क को मेरा दे दिया भी प्रकार का कोई लेन-देन या सम्पन्न इत्यादि विवाद है वह उसके लिए स्वयं सिमिदार होगा, खमरुणी मे मोनिका कर्क मोनी किसी भी प्रकार के हितहित एवं हितहित नहीं आएँ के लिए वह मुनिकित्तवा सिमिदार नहीं होगा।
SANJEEV JAIN
(ADVOCATE)
Earl.No. D/226/1991

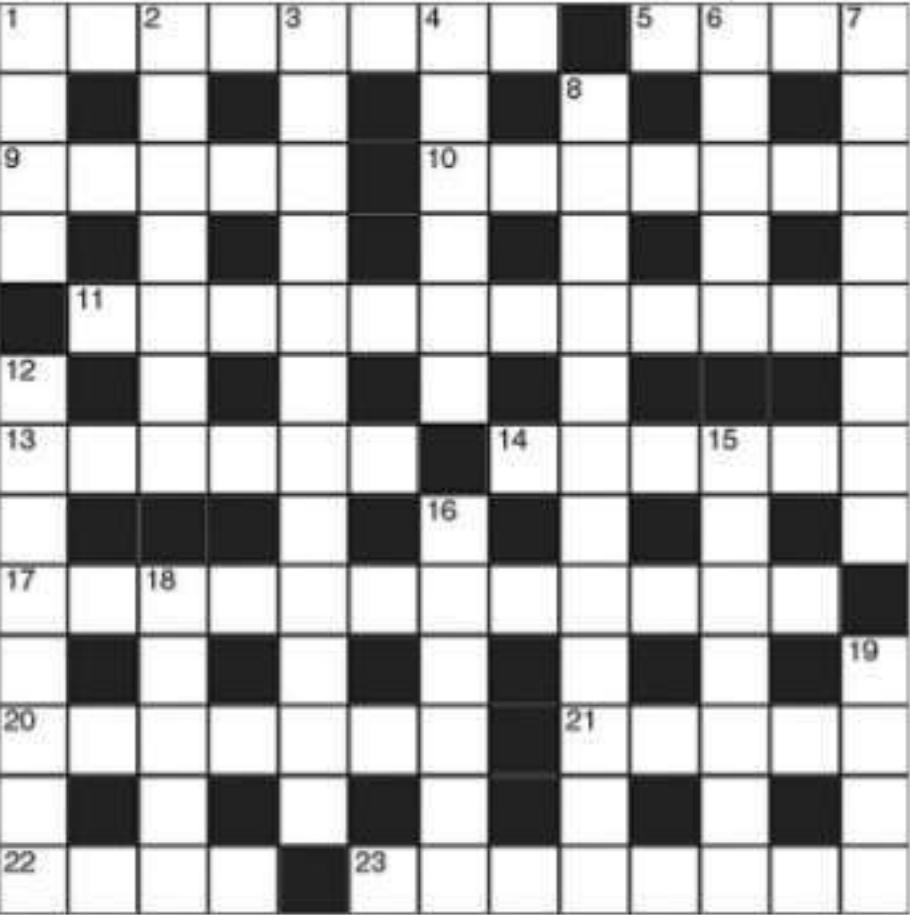
NORTH WESTERN RAILWAY

OPEN TENDER NOTICE (Through e-Tender)
On the behalf of President of India e-Tenders are invited by the CWM, Carriage Workshop, NWR, Jodhpur.
E-Tender Notice No.: 2026-26-Buffer Heating Date 23.06.2026. **Name of Work with its Location:** "Heat Treatment of Buffer Plunger with Spindle at firm premises". **Approximate Cost of work:** Rs. 3186377.60 (Rupees Thirty-One Lakh Eighty-Six Thousand Three Hundred Seventy Seven and Paise Sixty Only.). **Earnest Money to be deposited:** Rs. 63700.00 (Rupees Sixty-Three Thousand Seven Hundred Only.). **Last date and time for Submission of e-tender and Opening of e-tender:** 17.07.2026 Up to 15:00 Hrs. and 17.07.2026 after 15:00 Hrs. **Web site from e-tender forms can be obtained:** www.irops.gov.in. **Address of the NIT issuing Office:** Office of the CWM, Carriage Workshop, NWR, Jodhpur-342001 (Rajasthan) **911-MG/26**
Follow up on: www.facebook.com/NWRRailways & www.instagram.com/NWRRailways

SOUTH EAST CENTRAL RAILWAY

E-TENDER NOTICE
Sr.Divisional Engineer (Co)/ S.E.C. Railway, Nagpur acting for and on behalf of President of India invites **E-Tender for execution of work mentioned below:-**
Tender Notice No.: N-16-NGP-2026-2027. **Approx. Tender Value:** ₹ 2,30,52,523/-, **Earnest Money:** ₹ 4,61,100/-.
Name of the work: (1) Construction of Relay Hut at Non-Interlocked LC gates having TVU-10000 over Nagpur division of SECR LC No. BK-4, BK-24, BK-36, GJ-8, GJ-9, GJ-10, GJ-19, GJ-21, GJ-30 & GJ-31 (10 Nos) improvement of LC gates over Nagpur Division.
For the above tenders the Bidders will be able to submit their original / revised bids up to 15.00 Hours on 02.07.2026 only.
Manual offers are not allowed against these tenders and any such manual offers received shall be rejected. Details are available on our website : www.irops.gov.in
Sr.Div. Engineer (North)
PAM/06/11 SECR/Nagpur
f South East Central Railway X @seccrall</

CROSSWORD



ACROSS
1 Rocks are dislodged — revealing frogs? (8)
5 Request a piece of apple a day (4)
9 The way to beat an egghead (5)
10 Countryman gives vegetables to a worker (7)
11 You and Eve (6,6)
13 Pieces of eight (6)
14 Goes for spin and breaks left wrist (6)
17 They take interest in their work (12)
20 Love of two churches (7)
21 Table of contents gets Enid upset and cross (5)
22 A boy naturally opposed to the current trend (4)
23 Broken leg is set by linesmen (8)

DOWN
1 Make trivial complaint about vehicle parking (4)
2 Work socially acceptable advanced as posh (7)
3 Don't give up working as a judge (4,2,6)
4 They're very fast but may be shot (6)
6 Live wires taken on stage perhaps (5)
7 Stagger — a lot of weight is in the wood (8)
8 Second anniversary of a press union? (5,7)
12 Traffic force includes thousands (8)
15 Fresh red rose at the back of the altar (7)
16 Rice for example eaten for breakfast (6)
18 Agree about mother being domestically unsettled (5)
19 A number overturned an alliance (4)

SOLUTIONS CROSSWORD 6023 ACROSS: 1 Green belt, 8 Using, 9 Keyhole, 10 Ledger, 11 Defile, 12 Thinking, 15 Distance, 18 Ampere, 20 Yonder, 21 Killing, 22 Id est, 23 Stationer **DOWN:** 2 Reeve, 3 Ethnic, 4 Bulletin, 5 Tureen, 6 Pilgrim, 7 Aggregate, 11 Deadly sin, 13 Idealist, 14 Asunder, 16 Agents, 17 Apollo, 19 Range

JUMBLLED WORDS

Given below are four jumbled words. Solve the jumbles to make proper words and move them to the respective circles below. Select the letters in the shaded circles and jumble them to get the answer for the given quip.

_____ is the art of being the only one who knows you're scared to death - Harold Wilson (7)

GUVAE

SWORD

BEKLCU

AEINUG

ANSWER: Courage

is the art of being the only one who knows you're scared to death - Harold Wilson

SOLUTIONS: Vague, Words, Buckle, Guinea

OVER THE HEDGE



CALVIN & HOBBS



MARVIN



DIFFICULTY LEVEL 2s INSTRUCTIONS
To solve a Sudoku puzzle, every digit from 1 to 9 must appear in each of the nine vertical columns, in each of the nine horizontal rows and in each of the nine boxes.

DIFFICULTY LEVEL
1s = Very easy; 2s = Easy; 3s = Medium; 4s = Hard; 5s = Very Hard; 6s = Genius

SUDOKU 6360

		4	3	9				
8				1				
3	5	2		7				
	2		6	3			8	
3								5
9			7	8		4		
			9		5	2	1	
			8				9	
			3	6	5			

SOLUTION SUDOKU 6359

8	6	3	7	5	2	4	9	1
4	7	2	9	3	1	8	5	6
1	9	5	4	8	6	3	7	2
3	2	7	6	9	4	1	8	5
9	5	4	2	1	8	6	3	7
6	8	1	5	7	3	2	4	9
7	3	6	8	2	5	9	1	4
5	4	8	1	6	9	7	2	3
2	1	9	3	4	7	5	6	8

GOVERNMENT OF TELANGANA
HYDERABAD METROPOLITAN WATER SUPPLY & SEWERAGE BOARD
O/o Chief General Manager (Engg), STP-Circle-II, Khairatabad, Hyderabad-500004, TG.

EOI No.01/CGM/II/STP-C/Recycling and Reuse of treated water/EOI/2026-27, Dt: 24.06.2026
The HMWSSB intends to invite global Expression of Interest (EOI) from the interested agencies, international/national infrastructure companies, specialized waste water treatment developers and global investors for development of tertiary treatment units, treated wastewater conveyance and distribution infrastructure, to major demand centers on a Design, Build, Finance, Operate and Transfer (DBFOT) basis for 2 project corridors i.e., Project 1 - Attapur to Chandan Valley and Project 2 - Nagole to Future City under a Public-Private Partnership (PPP) framework.
The EOI document contains the details of qualification criteria, scope of work and evaluation criteria, etc. can be downloaded from <https://tender.telangana.gov.in/login.html>.
Last date & time of submission: 21st July 2026 before 5.00 PM.
Sd/- Chief General Manager (Engg), STP-Circle-II, Khairatabad, Hyderabad-04, TG.

TENDER NOTICE
PRABHA ENERGY LIMITED
Corporate Office : 12A, Abhishek Corporate Park, Opp. Swagat Bungalows BRTS Bus Stop, Ambli Bopal Road, Ambli, Ahmedabad - 380058.
Phone: 02717-488 611, E-mail : pncam02@prabhaenergy.com

1	Tender No.	PEL/CBM/NK BLOCK/HIRING SERVICES FOR LAND ACQUISITION/06/26
	Description of Work	Hiring Services for Land Acquisition for North Karanpura CBM Block, Jharkhand
	Last date of submission of bid	07 July 2026 at 17:00 Hrs. IST
2	Tender No.	PEL/CBM/NK BLOCK/HIRING SECURITY SERVICES/06/26
	Description of Work	Hiring Services for Security Services for North Karanpura CBM Block, Jharkhand
	Last date of submission of bid	07 July 2026 at 17:00 Hrs. IST

PEL, as joint operator, on behalf of consortium comprising with PEL, ONGC and IOCL, invites tender from reputed and experienced Service Providers / Contractors for above mentioned services at North Karanpura CBM Block, Jharkhand, India.
Interested agency may please visit <https://pepl.etenders.in>. Tender Documents are available for download on e-tender portal.

NORTH CENTRAL RAILWAY

NOTICE FOR EXPRESSION OF INTEREST (EOI)
INTERESTED PARTIES FOR PROVISION OF PARCEL SERVICES THROUGH COMPREHENSIVE MANAGEMENT OF PARCEL OFFICE ACTIVITIES AT AGRA Cantt. (AGC) & MATHURA JN. (MTJ)
Notice No. DRM/C/AGRA/PARCEL ACTIVITIES/2026 Date: 24.06.2026
Name of station where the work is to be executed: Proposal can be submitted for Parcel Activities at Agra Cantt. & Mathura Jn. railway station under Agra division. Details of average parcels and luggages per day dealt at station are as under:

S. No.	Station	Head	No. of Packages	Weight (Quintals)	Freight (Rs.)
1.	Agra Cantt.	Outward	1014	440	1,44,589/-
		Inward	426	157	-
2.	Mathura Jn.	Outward	207	105	51,739/-
		Inward	115	48	-

Scope of Work: i. Checking/ensuring of packing and labelling of consignments as per extant Railway rules. ii. Operation and maintenance of parcel scanners through skilled/certified personnel. iii. Transportation of booked parcels from parcel office to platforms and loading train-wise/destination-wise using mechanized / motorized trolleys. iv. Unloading of parcels from trains and shifting them to the parcel office shed. v. Provision of mechanized/motorized trolleys for parcel movement within station premises. vi. Optional value-added services such as packing, first-mile and last-mile delivery. **Objective of EOI:** To provide efficient, reliable, and customer-oriented parcel services by ensuring comprehensive management of all parcel office activities, including booking, handling, tracking, storage, and delivery, while maintaining operational efficiency, safety, and service quality and optimizing resource utilization.

Submission of EOI: Maximum upto date- 10.07.2026 (Up to 15:00 hrs).
Proposal can be submitted at the following address: i. Email: sr.dcmagc@gmail.com OR ii. Hard copy to reach up to 10.07.2026 (Up to 15:00 hrs)- Sr. DCM (Commercial Branch), Divisional Railway Manager's office, North Central Railway, Agra-282001 ***Note:** Interested applicants are required to submit their proposals in Annexure-C for AGC & MTJ. **• Availing EOI documents:** The EOI documents can be downloaded from the website <https://ncr.indianrailways.gov.in> upto the date 10.07.2026 (Up to 11:00 hrs) as mentioned in the EOI notice. **• Interested applicants** are required to submit their proposals with complete details in a sealed envelope at address: Sr. DCM (Commercial Branch), Divisional Railway Manager's office, North Central Railway, Agra-282001 or through e-mail at sr.dcmagc@gmail.com within a maximum period up to date- 10.07.2026 (Up to 15:00 hrs). For any clarification or further information, interested applicant may contact to CPS/AGC & MTJ, Mob No.: 9760536968 & 9760536982 during working hrs. 1449/26 FA

North central railways

@CPRONCR

www.ncr.indianrailways.gov.in

OFFICE OF SUPERINTENDING ENGINEER
PWE CIRCLE JHUNJHUNU
No.-SE/Jhunjhun/2026/D-522 Date:- 16-06-2026
Notice Inviting Bid No. 01/2026-27

Bids for 01 (One Nos) Road Work are invited from interested bidders upto 06:00 PM dated 16.06.2026 to 06.07.2026. Other particulars of the bid may be visited on the procurement portal (<http://proc.rajabasthan.gov.in>, <http://sppp.raj.nic.in>) of the state; and PWD departmental website. The approximate value of the procurement is Rs. 363.00 Lacs.

Sd/-
(Sateesh Chand Gupta)
Superintending Engineer
PWD Circle Jhunjhunu

NORTH WESTERN RAILWAY E-TENDER NOTICE
E-Tender Notice No 89 to 92/26-27
Divl. Rly. Manager, N. W.Rly. Bikaner for and on behalf of President of India invites open E-Tender for the following works up to 15.00 hours on 15.07.2026 as below:-
Tender No.- 89. Name of Work with its Location: Renovation of officer rest House at Bikaner under ADEN/HQ/BKN. **Approx. Cost of Work:** Rs. 16256133.22. **Earnest money:** Rs. 325100.00. **Tender No.: 90. Name of Work with its Location:** Augmentation of resting facilities for ticket checking staff at Bikaner station of Bikaner Division under ADEN/HQ/BKN. **Approx. Cost of Work:** Rs. 20370098.52. **Earnest money:** Rs. 407400.00. **Tender No.: 91. Name of Work with its Location:** Provision of over head water tank 225KL for DRM office and other service buildings along with water supply system at Bikaner under ADEN/HQ/BKN. **Approx. Cost of Work:** Rs. 15297820.56. **Earnest money:** Rs. 306000.00. **Tender No.: 92. Name of Work with its Location:** Renovation of resting facilities for ticket checking staff at Bathinda station under ADEN/Hanumangarh-I. **Approx. Cost of Work:** Rs. 18162704.79. **Earnest money:** Rs. 363300.00. **Note:** Other term & condition will be shown on N.W.Rly. website www.lreps.gov.in.

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PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON
See Section 84 Bhartiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita-2023

Whereas complaint has been made before me that the accused person Namely **Devinder Soni S/o** Makhan Ji R/o B7/1, Gali No. 6, Shanti Bazaar, Hastals Road, Uttam Nagar, Delhi has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case **FIR No. 91/2014 U/s 103/104 T. M Act 8 63 CR Act, PS: Economic Offences Wing, New Delhi**, and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **Devinder Soni** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Devinder Soni** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said **Devinder Soni** accused of **FIR No. 91/2014 U/s 103/104 T. M Act 8 63 CR Act, PS: Economic Offences Wing, New Delhi**, is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **19.08.2026**.

By Order

Mrs. Vasundhra Azad

Ld. CJM West, Room No. 146

Tis Hazari Court

DP/8141/EOW/2026

(Court Matter)

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON
See Section 82 Cr.P.C./ 84 Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita, 2023

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused **Deepak Gupta, S/o: Ram Charan Gupta, R/o: N-1/24, Budh Vihar, Phase-1, Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case **FIR No.: 612/2021, U/s: 406 IPC, P.S. Vijay Vihar, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said **Deepak Gupta** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said **Deepak Gupta** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused **Deepak Gupta of P.S. Vijay Vihar, Delhi** is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before **31.10.2026**.

By Order

Ms. Shagun

Ld. JMFC, North West, Room No.-109, Ist Floor,

Rohini Court, New Delhi

DP/8458/RD/2026

(Court Matter)

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON
See Section 82 Cr.P.C.

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused **Kallu @ Dhancha, S/o: Suresh Kumar, R/o: Footpath Near Rajender Place Metro Station, Prasad Nagar, Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case **FIR No.: 105/2024, U/s: 392/411/34 IPC, P.S. Prasad Nagar, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said **Kallu @ Dhancha** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said **Kallu @ Dhancha** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused **Kallu @ Dhancha of P.S. Prasad Nagar, Delhi** is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before **05.09.2026**.

By Order

Sh. Karanbir Singh

JMFC-02, Central, Room No. 26,

Tis Hazari Court, New Delhi

DP/8187/CD/2026

(Court Matter)

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON
See Section 82 CrPC

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused person **Md. Aftab Khan S/o** Abdul Karim Khan R/o Mohan Badiyaam, PS Sankri, Distt.-Madhubani, Bihar, **Also at:** Gali No.-2, Sukhi Nahar, Prem Nagar, Delhi, has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in **FIR No. 220/2019, U/S 279/337 IPC, PS Pashim Vihar East, Outer Distt., New Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **Md. Aftab Khan** cannot be found, and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Md. Aftab Khan** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant);

Proclamation is hereby made that **Md. Aftab Khan** the said accused of **FIR No. 220/2019, U/S 279/337 IPC, PS Pashim Vihar East, Outer Distt., New Delhi**, is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **29.07.2026**.

By Order

Ms. Moksha Bains

Judicial Magistrate First Class-II,

West Distt., Court No.-31,

Tis Hazari Courts, New Delhi

DP/8498/OD/2026

(Court Matter)

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON
See Section 82 CrPC

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused person **Rajbala W/o** Lt. Charan Singh, (1) R/o GF & FF Plot No. 1668-D, Kamla Park, Najafgarh, New Delhi-43, (2) R/o Premises GF & 1st Floor Near H.No. 1667, Kh. No. 23/18/1, Kamla Park, Dharam Pura, Najafgarh, New Delhi-43, has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in (1) **CT Cases: 433/2023 & (2) CT Cases: 452/2023, U/S 135 Indian Electricity Act, PS Najafgarh, Dwarka Distt., Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused person cannot be found, and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused person has absconded (or is concealing herself to avoid the service of the said warrant);

Proclamation is hereby made that **Rajbala** the said accused of (1) **CT Cases: 433/2023 & (2) CT Cases: 452/2023, U/S 135 Indian Electricity Act, PS Najafgarh, Dwarka Distt., Delhi**, is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **06.08.2026**.

By Order

Ms. Harleen Singh

Additional District Sessions Judge

(South-West), Special Court Electricity,

Court No.-609, Dwarka Courts, New Delhi

DP/8513/DW/2026

(Court Matter)

ROYAL STARS

ARIES (MAR 21 - APR 20): Today is a mixed bag. On one hand, you feel confident about dealing with social situations. Yet, when it comes to issues at home like dealing with a parent, you feel unsure. Tonight: It is what it is.

TAURUS (APR 21 - MAY 21): This is an excellent day to make decisions about redecorating, remodeling or entertaining, because you're in a sensible frame of mind. Conversations might be confusing today. Tonight: Patience.

GEMINI (MAY 22 - JUNE 21): You'll enjoy discussions with older friends or members of groups who are senior or in charge. They will welcome your grounded and serious input. You might have sensible recommendations. Money issues might be confusing. Tonight: Tread carefully.

CANCER (JUNE 22 - JULY 23): Financial discussions with bosses, parents and people in authority will be practical today. You'll be pleased with what is agreed upon. However, you will feel more tired today. Tonight: Take it easy.

LEO (JULY 24 - AUG 23): You have strong ideas about travel, higher education, politics, religion and publishing. You're in a practical frame of mind, but you also see the best way to create an attractive look. Don't second-guess yourself today. Tonight: Confidence.

VIRGO (AUG 24 - SEP 23): Discussions with friends and groups might be confusing today. You might feel disappointed at your ability to assert yourself. When working behind the scenes, you'll see practical ways to deal with shared property and how to divide expenses with someone. Tonight: Check your finances.

LIBRA (SEP 24 - OCT 23): You'll impress others today with your sensible suggestions about how to make improvements. Or perhaps how to help people get along. Your approach will be doable and sensible. Tonight: Low-key.

SCORPIO (OCT 24 - NOV 23): Others will admire you today because you're full of practical ideas that can improve things that are related to your work, health or pet. They might be related to saving money. Steer clear of politics and religion today. Tonight: Downtime.

SAGITTARIUS (NOV 24 - DEC 22): You love to travel, and today is a fabulous day to make travel plans, because you have realistic ideas and you won't overlook details. However, discussions about shared property, shared expenses or inheritances might be fuzzy. Tonight: Flights of fancy.

CAPRICORN (DEC 23 - JAN 20): You hate waste. You're a practical sign who is willing to work for what is important to you. Today you might get the financial and practical support to make improvements at home or to your family. This will please you. Discussions with partners and spouses might confuse you. Tonight: Be cautious.

AQUARIUS (JAN 21 - FEB 19): It's hard to defend your own best interests at work today. Somehow your heart just isn't into it. Discussions with partners and close friends are practical, pleasant and doable. Tonight: Patience.

PISCES (FEB 20 - MAR 20): Parents should be extra vigilant today. You might make an assumption that is wrong. You might think you know where they are, but you don't. Likewise, romance is on shaky ground as well. Fortunately it's a solid day at work. Tonight: Relax.

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON
(SEE SECTION 82(2) (ii) Cr.P.C.)

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused person(s) **JASBIR SINGH S/o** Nomia Ram R/o Village Post Office Sui, Distt. Bhiwani, Haryana; **also at** MCD School Mubarakpur Dabas Evening Shift, Delhi-110081; **also at** C-213, Laxmi Park, Nangloi, Delhi has committed (or are suspected to have committed) the offence in case **FIR No./CC No. 1847/2021, U/s 138 NI Act, PS Nangloi, Outer Distt., Delhi** and it has been returned to a Warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused person(s) **JASBIR SINGH** can not be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused person(s) **JASBIR SINGH** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation are hereby made that the said accused person(s) **JASBIR SINGH** of **FIR No./CC No. 1847/2021, U/s 138 NI Act, PS Nangloi, Outer Distt., Delhi** are required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before dated **28.09.2026 at 10:00 AM**.

By Order

Sh. Anshul Singhal

Judicial Magistrate First Class

Room No. 268, Tis Hazari Courts, Delhi

DP/8358/OD/2026

(Court Matter)

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON
(SEE SECTION 82(2) (ii) Cr.P.C/ 84 BNSS)

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused person(s) **Sanjeev Mehto S/o** Hamanth Mehto R/o R-19, Sharma Colony, Budh Vihar Phase-2, Delhi has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in Case **FIR No. 41/2025 U/s 12 Gambling Act, PS Budh Vihar, Distt. Rohini, Delhi** and it has been returned to a Warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused person(s) **Sanjeev Mehto** can not be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused person(s) **Sanjeev Mehto** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused person(s) **Sanjeev Mehto** of Case **FIR No. 41/2025 U/s 12 Gambling Act, PS Budh Vihar, Distt. Rohini, Delhi** is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before dated **04.08.2026 at 10:00 AM**.

By Order

Ms. Sanyam Jain

Judicial Magistrate First Class

North District, Room No. 112

1st Floor, Rohini Courts, Delhi

DP/8453/RD/2026

(Court Matter)

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON
See Section 84 Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita, 2023

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused **Varun @ Golu, S/o: Mahender, R/o: H.No-13/102, Block-13, Trilok Puri, Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case **FIR No.: 460/2019, U/s: 356/379/411 IPC, P.S. Hazrat Nizamuddin, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said **Varun @ Golu** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said **Varun @ Golu** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused **Varun @ Golu** of **P.S. Hazrat Nizamuddin, Delhi** is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before **01.08.2026**.

By Order

Sh. Manuj Kaushal

JMFC-03, Central, Room No. 512,

Saket Court, New Delhi

DP/8490/SE/2026

(Court Matter)

● RESULTS

GROUP L

England 0-0 Ghana
Boston Stadium

Panama 0-1 Croatia
Toronto Stadium

GROUP K

Colombia 1-0 DR Congo
Estadio Guadalupe

● MATCH SCHEDULE

GROUP E

Curacao vs Ivory Coast
Philadelphia, 1.30 am

(Friday)

Ecuador vs Germany
New York, 1.30 am

(Friday)

GROUP F

Tunisia vs Netherlands
Kansas City, 4.30 am

(Friday)

Japan vs Sweden
Dallas, 4.30 am

(Friday)

GROUP D

Turkiye vs USA
Los Angeles, 7.30 am

(Friday)

Paraguay vs Australia
San Francisco, 7.30 am

(Friday)

ZEE5 OTT & UNITE8 CHANNELS



2.85 million fans have attended the World Cup games so far. AP

WC attendance record set to be broken

WORLD CUP attendances are on track for record highs despite daunting ticket prices and travel restrictions. Experts say it is less a reflection of America's fondness for football, and more a measure of its love of spectacle. Through 44 matches, total attendance topped 2.85 million, with the average stadium about 99.6% full, according to a Reuters analysis based on FIFA data. The existing mark of nearly 3.6 million spectators was set in 1994, the last time the US hosted. REUTERS

Trump to attend July 19 final, present trophy

U.S. PRESIDENT Donald Trump will be on hand to present the World Cup final trophy on July 19 at New York New Jersey Stadium, FIFA president Gianni Infantino said on Tuesday. The global soccer boss has fostered an increasingly chummy relationship with the U.S. president and in December awarded him the inaugural edition of this invented FIFA Peace Prize, as Trump sought out sport's mega-watt spotlight. "We will be together with the president enjoying the final and handing the trophy to the winner, of course, together," Infantino said on the "Fox and Friends" television show. REUTERS

● LAST LINE OF DEFENCE

How four little-known goalkeepers became unlikely stars of the World Cup

Nihal Koshie
New Delhi, June 24

THE GOALS have the names. The saves have the stories. Lionel Messi, Kylian Mbappe, Erling Haaland and Cristiano Ronaldo have dominated the headlines, the Golden Boot race well and truly on. But while the superstars chase goals, little-known goalkeepers have been stealing moments of their own. Cape Verde, World Cup debutants, have their 40-year-old goalkeeper Vozinha to thank for two draws against European champions Spain and Uruguay. Curacao, also making their first appearance, owe their 0-0 draw with Ecuador to Eloy Room. The 37-year-old entered the record books with 15 saves, the joint most at a single World Cup match. Iran's Alireza Beirvanvand produced the save of the tournament so far. He found himself on the ground after attempting to cut off a cross from the left, but miraculously extended his left palm to deny Belgium's Maxim de Cuyper from close range. Vozinha, Room, Beirvanvand. Add to that list Congo's Lionel Mpasi. Colombia arrived for their Group K game against Congo having beaten Uzbekistan 3-1 in their opener, widely expected to test a Congolese backline making only their second World Cup appearance. They needed a win to secure their place in the Round of 32. By the end of 90 minutes, plus six of added time, they had it, just. Of Colombia's 19 shots, nine were on target. Mpasi made eight saves. Five of those came in the first 20 minutes, the most by any goalkeeper in that period of play at a World Cup in nearly

WORLD CUP: GROUP L

3 LIONS, NO BITE

A night of toothless football ends in a goalless draw as Ghana produce defensive masterclass vs England



Sandip G
Boston, June 24

AN ANGUISHED England fan in a Brighton shirt threw his poncho into the pelting rain and screamed: "Make them stand in the rain the whole night." Seconds were tumbling away, the game was meandering, and England fans emboldened after the 4-2 win over Croatia were disillusioned by what they saw in Boston on a shivering evening that ended goalless.

It was supposed to be another statement night, a chance to match the strides of France and Argentina. Instead it was a toothless attacking display, reminiscent of the end days under Gareth Southgate. England might yet go deep in the tournament, but the performance against Ghana was not an advertisement of their attacking riches. It was a prognosis of their limitations.

There were passages when even the most invested fans turned their heads away, their eyes wandered, their conversation drifted to the England-like weather (though Bostonians would claim it was so very Boston in summer). Some hollered the names of substitutes, and the bench was stacked with individuals who could conjure a moment of invention. What was needed was an individual act of brilliance rather than a

structural rejig. Bellingham was pushed into a play-maker's role just behind Kane, but found little joy against Ghana's compact shape.

Tuchel rang in the changes. The Arsenal pair of Eberechi Eze and Bukayo Saka strode in. But it did not puncture Ghana's belief in their defensive durability. They blocked and blocked until they could block no more. Another England fan griped: "It's worse than losing. Tell me one decent shot on goal."

Just then, England had

They were not merely defending in numbers but defending intelligently. The speed of their covering was remarkable, giving England as little time on the ball as possible.

their most incisive spell. Declan Rice drove a free kick powerfully goal-wards that Asare did well to deal with. Saka whipped the ball fiercely at goal moments later, but for goalkeeper Benjamin Asare's intervention, the Hearts of Oak man making history as the first locally based Ghanaian goalkeeper to start a World Cup match.

The next minute Nico O'Reilly (pic) headed powerfully onto the crossbar. The rebound fell to Harry Kane. He skied it into the upper tiers,



rounding off a forgettable evening when both his precision and imagination deserted him. And so it ended. "A sticky day," a fan consoled his friends. Another muttered: "Same old England." After the game England fans applauded politely. Indifference was written on their faces.

Then, from the Ghana dugout, emerged a familiar figure for English football watchers: Carlos Queiroz, Alex Ferguson's trusted accomplice in Manchester United's halcyon days, a human treatise on defensive tactics. A legendary story: before the 2008 Champions League semifinal against Barcelona, to nullify their passing game, Queiroz placed two gym mats between the midfielders and the defenders in training. The ball was not allowed to touch the mats. As Michael Carrick later recalled, for a few minutes Queiroz simply said: don't let the ball get on those mats.

United drew 0-0 at Barcelona and won 1-0 at Old Trafford. Barcelona were kept goalless across both legs.

Ghana defended stoutly, not cynically but clinically. An immovable yellow barricade blocked all probable paths to goal. Like the pawns protecting the queen on a chess

board, Tuchel's favourite pastime, Ghana built a human fortress around the goalmouth. Starting in a 4-2-3-1, they pushed deeper as the game wore on, eventually operating as a compact 5-4-1. Whenever England found a half-chance, Ghana flung bodies at the ball. Declan Rice later credited their organisation: "5-4-1 without the ball, very compact, tight spaces to play through."

They were not merely defending in numbers but defending intelligently. The speed of their covering was remarkable, giving England as little time on the ball as possible. The defensive block was not stationary. It shape-shifted according to the situation, and whenever England appeared to find a pocket of space, it closed. Slowly England grew ponderous. In the first half Ghana had barely ten percent possession, but their sole purpose was to frustrate England and hold their shape, just as England's was to press unblinkingly and hope Ghana eventually surrendered to their pressure. Like desperate sleuths plucking the suspects' nails to gush out the truth, England resorted to every tactic available to crack the Ghanaian wall. Neither side managed a single shot on goal in the first half. Kane's first meaningful attempt came only in the dying minutes, deflected wide by the telescopic legs of Marvin Senaya.

England needed a genius's brushstroke. Nothing came. It was their tactical failure too, their inability to thread the ball through crowded defences, to find a Yamal or an Olise moment. Set pieces seemed the likeliest avenue but even those fell flat against a defensive rearguard orchestrated by the man who once neutralised Barcelona with two gym mats and a simple instruction.



Hydration breaks have generated heated debates. AP

Tuchel and his Uruguay counterpart Marcelo Bielsa have expressed displeasure with the breaks. Tuchel said they were altering the natural rhythm and flow of matches more than he initially expected.

Bielsa felt hydration breaks were adding nothing to the game. "In my view, it adds nothing and takes away a lot. When [the match] was divided into four periods, no thought was given to the effect it might

“There is no additional revenue for FIFA, as all commercial agreements were signed well in advance. So, this is not a financial issue for us. For us, it is purely a sporting matter.”

GIANNI INFANTINO, FIFA PRESIDENT

have on what makes football such a captivating sport, but instead to other repercussions which I'm neither discussing nor analysing," Bielsa said.

Dutch defender Virgil van Dijk called for a game-by-game approach with regard to the hydration breaks, admitting that it was not providing good value to those watching on television.

"I think for the neutral

watchers on TV, it's also not great. So, if it's really hot, obviously it would be good to put them in, but I think you have to look at it in every game separately, in my opinion," he said.

Effect on games

The hydration break had an early impact in the tournament during Germany's game against Curacao in Houston. The four-time champions had dominated the opening stages and taken the lead, but Curacao gradually grew into the contest and found an equaliser through Livano Comenencia.

The break arrived shortly after Curacao's equaliser and gave Germany an opportunity to regroup. The break was taken despite the temperature hovering around 22 degrees Celsius. Following the restart, Germany looked sharper and more organised and quickly reasserted control of possession. They went on to score six more goals and turn what had briefly become a competitive contest into a comfortable victory.

GHANA FAN 'CASTS JUJU ON KANE'

The witch doctor, the Kane miss, and the banter in the stands



England's Harry Kane blasts the ball over the bar during the World Cup match against Ghana in Boston on Tuesday. AP

Sandip G
Boston, June 24

WHEN HARRY Kane miscued a rebound deep into the stands in the dying moments of the goalless draw against Ghana, an England fan turned to a Ghanaian neighbour and quipped: "Oh, the spell is working after all." The Ghana supporter retorted: "No spell friend, he needs some shooting practice."

The banter was about a claim made before the match by Nana Kwaku Bonsam — whose name translates as Devil of Wednesday — a Ghanaian witch doctor who told the *Daily Star* he had cast black magic (juju) on Kane. He had credentials of a sort: in 2014, he claimed to have engineered a knee injury that threatened Cristiano Ronaldo's participation in the World Cup ahead of Portugal's clash with Ghana.

"I am working on Harry Kane," he said. "I have shown what I am capable of before so I know what work I must do to stop him." Headed, with some care: "I am not wishing him serious injury. It will be just enough to stop him against my country."

Bonsam is not an ordinary witch doctor, if the category permits degrees. He once contested in a parliamentary election. He built a following during years spent in New York's Bronx, which has a sizable Ghanaian population. Hundreds welcomed him at Kumasi Airport when he returned home. He drives a Cadillac, wears Dolce and Gabbana tracksuits, has 14 children, a cattle farm, a chain of shrines and schools, and has lived in New York, Amsterdam and Berlin. The New York Times profiled him a decade ago, describing him as "a traditional priest loved and despised for his spiritual power."

Back in Ghana, juju is spoken of in graver tones. "Some sections take it seriously, even highly educated people," says Joseph, the Ghanaian fan in the stands. "Whenever we perform badly, they believe someone has done something. When we do well again, some people would say we have done something and that's why we are winning. I don't believe in any of these. Most of us don't."

The belief runs deep enough that CAF (Confederation of African Football) once felt compelled to address it directly. "We are no more willing to see witch doctors on the pitch than cannibals at the concession stands," read a 2008

CAF statement, issued after a string of incidents involving charms, powders and spiritual advisers at African tournaments. Some countries, including Zambia, have outlawed the practice. Former Zambian player, Nchimunya Mweetwa, once told the *BBC* about his encounter with juju. "The school team had a witch doctor, who we were made to believe would win us matches. After training, he would ask them to apply juju oil," he said.

At the 2025 AFCON final between Morocco and Senegal, the issue surfaced in a different form. Moroccan ball boys and players repeatedly attempted to remove goalkeeper Edouard Mendy's towels throughout the match -- wet conditions had made them essential for his grip. One Moroccan player was later suspended and fined by CAF for his role in the episode. Some observers framed it as gamesmanship. Others saw something else.

"In Europe, people don't understand that there is something behind it," former Morocco coach Herve Renard said afterwards. "Was the towel charmed? In Africa, these are beliefs, and everyone is free to believe what they want."

At the 2022 World Cup, French outlet RFI reported that several Cameroon players had been visiting a spiritual practitioner named Nji Oussen. "Everyone wants to be selected or to be a holder. Thus, for important competitions such as the World Cup or the African Cup of Nations, players often call on my services to invoke the gods in order to disturb the opponent," Oussen told RFI. Samuel Eto'o, as federation president, denied the report and demanded an apology.

On Tuesday, the banter continued through the second half. The England fan nudged his Ghanaian neighbour: "Can you teach us some? We want to do magic on our opponents!" Joseph played along: "500 pounds for a session! Deal? It is not easy brother!" Another England supporter: "With that money, we could come to Ghana and learn."

When Nico O'Reilly hit the post, the Englishman asked: "You didn't spare Nico either?" After the game, Declan Rice said, with a grin: "Credit to Ghana, they defended well. We tried everything. Shots, headers, set-pieces... nothing worked. I don't know... maybe the black magic was working!"

● Number Plate

8

● Lionel Mpasi Nzau made a total of 8 saves against Colombia, of which five came in the first 20 minutes. It is the most by any goalkeeper in that period of play at a World Cup in nearly 30 years.

20

● Eloy Room has recorded the most saves at the World Cup, 20, so far. Vozinha completed 7 saves against Spain while Alireza Beirvanvand has recorded the third most saves at the World Cup, 13.



Congo goalkeeper Lionel Mpasi makes a save against Colombia. AP

earned respect. They needed luck to beat him.

For a country returning to the World Cup after 52 years, formerly known as Zaire,

Mpasi's performance gave them belief. Congo can still advance to the Round of 32 if they beat Uzbekistan and results go their way.

winding one. After nearly a decade in the lower divisions of French football, he made his Ligue 1 debut in January this year for Le Havre AC. He was 31. Most keepers are established internationals by then.

PSG product

A product of the PSG academy who had represented France's youth teams, he spent four years in Toulouse's reserve side, then moved to Rodez AF in 2016, building a quiet reputation as a steady pair of hands. He came to Houston as a backup keeper with a handful of top-flight appearances behind him.

Born to Congolese parents in Meaux, France, he holds dual citizenship and chose Congo. After Congo beat Jamaica to qualify for the World Cup, he spoke about what the moment meant. "My parents are around

50 years old. They were babies, or maybe my father was eight or 10, when Zaire played in the World Cup. So many people in DRC have never seen the country at a World Cup. You could feel it, because the welcome we received from the people was historic. We saw that we had done something historic," he told Radio France Internationale.

Like Vozinha, who did not turn professional until he was 25 and whose mother could not get a visa to watch him play against Spain. Like Room, who was without a club in the final weeks of qualifying. Like Beirvanvand, once a shepherd, then a car washer, then a waiter. Mpasi's story is also one of persistence. In the shadow of Messi, Mbappe and Ronaldo, the journeymen goalkeepers are writing their own story at this World Cup.

India to learn Olympic bid fate in 2027

Mihir Vasavda
Mumbai, June 24

INDIA'S AMBITIOUS bid to host the 2036 Olympic Games will be tested in March next year when the International Olympic Committee (IOC) decides whether it progresses to the next stage of the host selection process.

The IOC approved a roadmap for choosing future Olympic hosts, setting out a timeline that will culminate in the election of the 2036 host at an IOC Session in mid-2029. Under the new process, interested bidders will first go through a dialogue phase before a shortlist of candidates is drawn up in the first quarter of 2027.

For India, which formally entered the race through the Indian Olympic Association and is currently engaged in dialogue with the IOC's Future Host Commission, the first major checkpoint will come in March 2027. Only bidders selected for the next phase will be invited into what the IOC calls 'strategic dialogue', involving detailed evaluations of venues, governance structures, financing plans and delivery capabilities.

The IOC's new framework marks a departure from the system that awarded the 2028 Los Angeles and 2032 Brisbane Olympics. Under IOC president Kirsty Coventry, the organisation has opted to restore a bidding process with candidates remaining in contention deeper into the cycle.

According to the timeline approved by IOC members, short-listed candidates will face further scrutiny through 2027 and 2028. Site inspections, legal commitments, financial guarantees and operational assessments will form part of the evaluation process. The winning host is expected to be elected in 2029. An Indian delegation of officials from the IOA and Gujarat government are currently in Lausanne, presenting on the sidelines of the IOC Session.

WOMEN'S T20 WORLD CUP

As spinners do heavy lifting, India search for pace lift

India remain in the hunt for a semifinal place at the Women's T20 World Cup, but one concern continues to stand out

Shankar Narayan
Mumbai, June 24

THREE MATCHES into the Women's T20 World Cup, India are walking a tightrope. With two wins in three outings, the semi-final dream still glimmers on the horizon, but the stumble against South Africa has cast fresh shadows on their path.

The Harmanpreet Kaur-led side would not have wanted to find themselves in this position. Yet, with two group matches remaining, they need wins in both to stay in contention for a final four berth.

While the batting has relied on individual contributions at different stages, India's bowling attack has developed a clear pattern. As the tournament enters its decisive phase, one aspect of that attack stands out more than any other.

There was little doubt when the squad for the tournament was announced that India's spinners would have to carry a lot of the load if they were to go deep at the World Cup. The pacers would then have to play the ideal support cast.

There has only been a faint glimmer of that support seen so far. 21 of the 24 wickets taken by India have been by the spinners. That is a whopping 87.5% of scalps taken by one part of the attack. Nandni Sharma, playing her first major global event, is the only pacer who has wickets to her name, having taken 2/22 against the Netherlands. The only other dismissal came via a run out. India's reluctance to use pace has been such that in the matches against Pakistan and

South Africa, a total of 8.1 overs were bowled by the pacers.

The contrast with other leading sides is striking. Australia have enjoyed a balanced split between pace and spin, with their spinners accounting for 14 wickets and seamers 13. Left-arm spinner Sophie Molineux leads their wicket charts with six scalps, while Kim Garth (5), Ellyse Perry (4) and Annabel Sutherland (4) have complemented the slow bowlers.

England's attack has been led by spin too, with the tweakers taking 15 wickets compared to 10 for the seamers. Sophie Ecclestone tops their tally with seven wickets, while Charlie Dean and Linsey Smith have helped take the tally to 15. Freya Kemp (5), Danielle Gibson (3) and Lauren Bell (2) have provided useful support.

South Africa's seamers have accounted for 17 of their 20 wickets in the tournament, with Marizanne Kapp leading the way with six. Shabnim Ismail and Ayabonga Khaka have chipped in with four wickets each. Against India, Kapp and Ismail's strikes highlighted the impact a quality pace attack can have in major tournaments.

Pace uncertainty

The lack of a settled pace combination in any of the matches hasn't helped either. Arundhati Reddy and Kranti Gaud played against Pakistan. Nandni replaced Arundhati against the Netherlands before the latter came back in for Kranti against South Africa.

Arundhati's returns also underline why India need more



Arundhati Reddy has 20 wickets in 21 T20Is since 2025. FILE

In a young attack, Arundhati's experience remains valuable, but India need greater control and a more serious wicket-taking threat with the new ball.

from their senior seamer. Since the start of 2025, she has taken 20 wickets in 21 T20Is but gone at more than eight runs an over. In a young attack, her experience remains valuable, but India need greater control and a more serious wicket-taking threat with the new ball.

The continued absence of Renuka Singh Thakur has also raised questions. Thursday's match against Bangladesh at Old Trafford could offer India a chance to test a different pace combination before Sunday's potentially decisive clash

Anushka, 18, sets national record, seals Asiad spot

Prithish Raj
Bhubaneswar, June 24

WHAT'S SUSHIL Yadav left unfinished at 18 due to family responsibilities, his daughter Anushka Yadav completed in spectacular fashion on Wednesday. As the sun set at the Kalinga Stadium during the Inter-state athletics Championships, Sushil watched 18-year-old Anushka break the women's Hammer Throw national record twice in the space of 40 minutes.

Anushka, who hails from Baleni village in Baghpat, Uttar Pradesh, first improved the national mark in her second attempt with a throw of 65.64m and broke it again in the final attempt with a mark of 67.02m.

The previous national record was in the name of Sarita Singh (65.25m), and Anushka's performance also went beyond the Asian Games qualification mark of 61.72m. "I had to leave the sport when I was 18 due to family responsibilities and my marriage. Since then, I wanted to make one of my kids a hammer thrower," an ecstatic Sushil told *The Indian Express*. "Initially, my son (who is 16 years old) started and Anushka started coming along. Then, I realised that her body and movements were conducive for the event."

Her father being a former athlete definitely helped, and Anushka picked up the discipline like a duck to water.

"My first choice was running but when Papa said that I have to do the hammer throw, I did so. There are many hammer throwers at the ground I train and that helped. Apart from my father, Chirag Yadav and Gagan Yadav also trained me. So, I have three coaches," said Anushka.

Anushka trains at the Sri Krishna Inter College Ground near her village and the venue is famous for producing several throwers. Rachna, the former meet record holder, Tanya Chaudhary, who finished sec-



Anushka Yadav set a mark of 67.02m on Wednesday. EXPRESS

ond behind Anushka, and many other throwers – both men and women – train at the ground.

"We have the likes of Tanya and Rachna right now and in the past also, there have been many international throwers from our village and those nearby. It has helped Anushka massively. In the morning, when I am at the farm or field, there are seniors like Gagan and Chirag who train Anushka. When I come back in the evening, I train her," said Sushil.

Injured due to tractor

Anushka, who is also the current U20 national champion and holds the U20 national record, has been consistently crossing the 60m mark in senior competitions. She recorded her personal best last year at the National Games with a mark of 62.89m. "She has been throwing very well in practice and has crossed the 70m mark also. But an injury earlier this year hampered her progress," said Sushil.

In March this year, Anushka suffered a big setback. "I was injured while working on the farm. My father asked me to connect the tiller with the tractor and that's when my brother mistakenly drove it on my foot injuring the right knee," Anushka explained. For two months after the injury, she didn't throw a hammer but kept in touch with the sport. "She did the usual drills or small practice move-

Meena breaks NR, Jyothi books Asiad berth

DEV MEENA continued his record breaking spree with a 5.46m mark in Pole Vault. He broke the national record set last month at the Federation Cup. With this mark He also qualified for the Asian Games by breaching the 5.45m mark set by the Athletics Federation of India.

In the most anticipated event of the day, returning hurdler Jyothi Yarraji clocked 12.99s in the final of the 100m hurdles to book her berth for the Asian Games by breaching the AFI qualification mark of 13.34s. She breached the mark twice clocking 13.12s in the heats and went below the 13s mark in the final. Apart from her, Nandhini of Tamil Nadu also qualified with a personal best of 13.22s. ENS

ments," said Sushil.

She started her season at the Junior National Championships in April but couldn't perform up to the mark, with a best throw of 58.02m. "As her knee will improve, she will continue getting better. We had a 70m mark in our mind today but she got the national record which is a big achievement for all of us," said Sushil.



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